



Harrison
Taylor

THEY'RE 3,000
MILES APART
AND TAYLOR'S
MET SOMEONE
NEW...

Separate Schools #3

Open Minds

Harrison and Taylor's Open Relationship

BOARDWALK

K T M O R R I S O N

OPEN MINDS

Separate Schools #3

KT MORRISON

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About the Author

KT Morrison writes stories about women who fall in love with sexy men who aren't their husband, and loving relationships that go too far—couples who open a mysterious door, then struggle to get it closed as trouble pushes through the threshold.

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All characters are over the age of eighteen.

OPEN MINDS

A Separate Schools Novel

Separate Schools #3

56,000 words

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Shifting Plates

SEPTEMBER 30-OCTOBER 2

Saturday, September 30

Chapter One

THEY RAN IN THE DARK, their mismatched footwear clapping and slapping against the macadam. Two streets down from Scratchy's bar, Harrison in sneakers, and a tall thin girl named Ashley in short-cut high-heeled boots tramped as fast as possible, breath scorching their throats. The cops were after them.

He slowed for the girl, skipping sidestep, holding out a hand, saying, "Come on, come on, Ashley, quicker . . ."

Ashley cackled, long clumsy legs skip-strutting to catch up with him. She couldn't breathe she laughed so hard now. It got him laughing even though he was scared.

"Come on, seriously . . ."

Headlights shone in the T-Bone intersection they passed thirty seconds ago.

"Shit, come on," he said, trying to push himself back from the streetlights cone of light shining from above. His back hit a chain-link fence, and it rattled. "Let's go, let's go," he hissed, reaching for her hand, their fingers intertwining for a second but then they separated again, him getting ahead of her, her high heels clacking now on an unmaintained and frost-heaved section of ancient sidewalk.

They ran in the rural subdivision off the main street, mostly small affordable bungalow homes lined by shrubbery, high hedges, chain-link fences; behind each of these squared off patches of yard there might be a pit bull or two. The neighborhood was quiet, but a radio squawked back near

the light on the street. Police red and blues flashed the tree canopy one street over and down, where the incident had occurred.

On his right a slanted gateway sat uneven in its hinges, framed by thick boxy shrubs. He jiggled on the fence and no dogs barked on the other side. The house had one light on, and he saw kitchen cupboards but no one standing there. He hooked an arm over the gate as the headlights at the T-Bone intersection swept their way. There was no lock, just the swing latch he flicked with his finger, pushed the door open and held his hand out for Ashley. "Get in here!"

Ashley thought the whole thing was hilarious, but if the cops caught them, she wouldn't be the one spending the night in jail. She doubled over, snorting, laughing, gasping for breath, her long caramel-brown hair swinging around, wafting up tequila and tropical shampoo. Their hands missed again, but he snatched her wrist, pulled her with him, two of them tumbling into some stranger's backyard and slapping the crooked gate shut behind them.

Ashley fell against him, caught him off balance; he fell back to land on his ass, Ashley coming down on top of him, her chin bouncing off his hairline. They both shouted with pain, collapsed, he put his hands over his face. Ashley squirmed next to him, her hurting cries turning to chuckling laughter again.

"Quiet, quiet," he said through his hands.

The headlights stopped, didn't continue down the street. But as he sat up, light still flickered in the fading autumn leaves. The cop car had stopped at the intersection, nose pointing down this way where they hid.

"Holy shit," Ashley laughed.

He said, "You gotta be quiet."

Ashley laughed still, hooked an arm around him to pull herself up to sit. Hip to hip and side to side, both of them leaned now against an aluminum shed with someone's probable garden tractor inside. They listened to the squawk of the cop's radio, there were shouts down the street. The whole thing had happened so fast.

Coming out of Scratchy's, he's with Brady and his buddies, these girls they'd met; a bunch of guys screeched up in a pickup truck who knew the girls with them. There was an argument. A guy from the truck and one girl separating themselves, the guy needing to *talk* to his woman. The guy's buddies got between them all, acting like cops and telling them to Back off,

man. Brady's friend Hector didn't like it, shoved one of the pickup truck guys. That's when the brawl started.

Ashley sighed, drawing in long breaths and exhales. "Holy cow, man, that was so fuckin' hilarious."

"I'm glad *you* liked it," he said, listening for trouble.

"You fucking hit that guy so hard," she said and clapped her hands once. He shifted at the hips, collected her hands together so she wouldn't clap them again.

"Just listen," he said, turning an ear up, trying to remind her they were still on the run.

"You're gonna have a black eye," she said in the quiet, her speech thick with Michigan accent.

"Probably." His whole head throbbed. The other guy punched him first. If the cops found them, that's what he'd tell them. And it was the truth. He had a good premonition the cops wouldn't listen. Wouldn't care which was the good kid, which was the bad kid. Just a bunch of dumb twenty-year-olds getting drunk and fighting in a parking lot. They wouldn't have the patience to hear him out. The guy *had* punched him first. And, fuck, that guy got him good. His head *exploded* with white light and pain. But he was so fucking mad. Mad and sore but also happy. The pumped up kind of happy. Exuberant. And he'd hauled off with a fist clenched tighter than he believed possible. A sweeping crescent starting somewhere down at his knee coming up and getting this dark-haired guy—about three inches taller than him—right in the neck, jaw, and chin. There was a wet slap; his elbow zipped off like a lightning strike. His hand was unharmed. Maybe he imagined it (because in the aftermath the adrenaline had his vision fuzzy), but he was almost *positive* both of the guy's feet came right off the pavement. He fell down hard. As they ran, the worry wormed through him. A guy could die from a punch like that. Sure, it didn't matter if the guy who swung it hadn't fought since grade school, a good guy just going through a lot of shit; none of that mattered. If a mousy bookkeeper swung off and hit some assailant in self-defense and their head knocked off the concrete and three days later they died, nobody would care that this shit had been building inside that meek little mouse. He pictured himself on trial. The jury, everything. His mom trying not to cry behind him, wet sniffing, opening and closing her Kleenex. His dad—could see him, see the disappointment in his face. Hating that he had to come to court when there were better things to do.

“Let me see,” Ashley said now, slipping her hands up from between his. She gripped his left hand, said, “How is it? Did you break it?”

“Wrong hand.”

She dropped it, took the other one, her warm fingers working over his skin. “How’s your hand?”

“Totally fine,” he said. “But my eye’s killing me.”

“Can you see?” she said, and now her fingers traced through the hair above his ear. He drew his head back to look at her. The right eye was a little bleary, a wet warbling of his vision but the left eye saw clear. It had been a gray afternoon and evening, but now it was full dark, the dim dissipated, and the stars shone. The yard they hid in was ringed with shrubs, tall trees poking up here and there around the house but the space where they hid left unfiltered, and bright universal light caressed this girl’s narrow face. She was pretty. No, kind of *hot*. She said dumb things all night, calling everybody basic bitches, her accent was trash, she was kind of annoying, a bit of a loudmouth. But she was *hot*. A high school dropout, which concerned him, but she had a job in retail. Long legs, thin like Taylor, but *not* Taylor. Her jeans were painted on, brown leather boots with what—four-, five-inch heels? She’d come in Scratchy’s wearing a wool coat with a big shawl collar, but she took it off at the table, and underneath wore a tight top with her tits mashed together showing off that apostrophe of cleavage in the scoop neck.

“I’m fine,” he said, “I’ve been hit harder.” *Wasn’t even close to being true*. His head throbbed, the eye socket ringed with pain, an aching knot in his jaw and above his ear and through his temple. But the fact he could see was good. He was all right, but if the cops got their hands on him, they would take his freedom. “Shoot,” he said, “listen.”

He cocked his head up, ear turned to the sky. The radio squawked, and he heard a deep-voice cop. Pictured the guy too, some Army vet looking to bust heads, probably wearing his cat eye sunglasses at night, his balding head shaved to make him look extra tough. Kinda chunky, but really fucking strong. The cop would tase him, beat him with a flashlight, possibly shoot him, say later he swore the kid had something that looked like a weapon.

Those warm hands of Ashley’s now slipped around his neck, startling him at the same time his nipples hardened. She kissed him on the jaw, her lips looking for his mouth. He turned, let her lips find his. He put a hand

through her hair, grabbed the back of her neck, kissed her. His cock shot to steel in his pants, happening so fast it surprised him.

“Wait,” he said, their lips smacking apart. She ran a canine over her lower lip, big wet eyes watching him. In the bar, he’d noticed her eyes were green. These girls he’d never seen before had shown up at Scratchy’s around 11 P.M. He’d spent the afternoon with Brady, hung out at the gym and pumped iron. Lactic acid raced through his arms right now, inside his elbows; his chest burned, his neck stiff and sore. Brady had him doing neck exercises. Lifting weights with his stupid head. But it was awesome, and it felt good, and what a great way to spend a Saturday, and it was a great way to stop you from thinking about your girlfriend three-thousand miles away in the land of sunshine sleeping with her new boyfriend.

Ashley pulled him back for another kiss, and he let her. Took her lips again, and now she stuck her tongue in his mouth. It was hot and welcome, but the feel alarming, sending off all kinds of bells in his head. *That’s not Taylor, hey, that’s not Taylor’s tongue, it certainly doesn’t feel like hers . . .*

So fucking what?

So fucking what? You’re cheating on her . . .

He took Ashley’s tongue, twirled his against hers, she ran the tip of hers against his teeth, scraping off skin cells into his mouth. He grimaced, because he didn’t even know this girl. Didn’t go to school with this girl. Knew her—what, an hour? She had shitty friends, shitty language. Might be kind of racist even.

She was hot as shit and she has her tongue in your mouth . . .

You don’t know her mother. Don’t know her father. She doesn’t know yours. One-night stand sex.

Why not? Right?

He put his hand on her stomach, and she didn’t squirm away. He slipped his hand under her wool coat, fingered the hem of her shirt, pulled it out from the tight seal of her pants that had to be two sizes too small. She was taut and flat, and that reminded him of Taylor. His hand cupped her breast in its bra. Way bigger than Taylor. Soft, womanly, he thumbed the shape of her nipple over the lace. Her hand sunk down to his lap; she grabbed a hard handful of the inside of his thigh. It got one of his knees to raise, and then she grabbed his bulge. He was hard as a rock.

Now she got over him, straddling his lap. The radio still squawked, red and blues flashing somewhere in the treetops behind the shed, sending off a

faint flickering light in the trees that defined the black silhouette of this beautiful girl that seemed to want to have sex with him.

He straightened his legs, she scratched nails down under his coat, down his pants, kissed him while she undid the button and drew down his zipper. Then his cock was out and in her hand, cold in the air but warm in her grip. She scooted back, her ass below his knees, and then she crouched down, folding in half, making him think she must be into yoga, that wet pink mouth of hers going over his cock and then starting to bob up and down. His head knocked back, made a hollow thin sheet of aluminum sound.

“Fuck,” he whispered, hoping no one heard that.

The girl sucked him, head bobbing, rolling, and he palmed the back of her head. Shame and regret kept batting at the pleasure; pleasure trying to rise inside him and nonsensical morals taking pot shots, warning shots: *Don't enjoy this, what about Taylor? . . . Who is this girl?*

She was good with her mouth, eager.

What a crazy day. Lifting weights, new friends, shoot, showing up at Scratchy's Bar worried and nervous meeting Brady's friends, Brady sitting down with them, knuckle bumping, introducing him to a guy called Hector, a guy called JJ, another guy called Kruger. Brady said to them, “This is that guy I told you about, we double-teamed those hotties up north.” And that was it. Instant acceptance. He was in the fraternity. They knuckle bumped, ordered beers, wings; a game played on the big screen that he didn't give a shit about, but he had a pitcher of beer. Girls appeared. Girls talked. Girls moved from the table, new ones came; he danced. They pulled him to the dance floor. Ashley's crew arrived. They were obnoxious. Ashley's friend was all over Brady. The blonde girl with the boyfriend who showed up later in a pickup truck to make a scene made out with JJ on the dance floor. Ashley didn't give two shits about him, none of the girls did. They were nice, joined him in the conversation, but it didn't look like he would be going off with one of them. Not until the fight. Then it was him and Ashley racing into the dark, and now he was an action hero in a movie that was going to have a pornographic ending.

Until the cop came . . .

Sunday, October 1

Chapter Two

SNEAKER TOES PLANTED in the sandy skid-mark underneath the swing-set, denim butt slung in the seat, Harrison dangled, head down. Hands shoved in sweatshirt pouch, hood up, the elbow-pinned chain links creaked and groaned as he swayed from side to side.

He was sitting in the playground patch between his subdivision and Kelsey and Taylor's. A triangle grass-delta shape with candy-colored metal-post forts slung with wood-plank-ways, slides, firefighter poles, and monkey bars. It was a place he'd spent lots of evenings, weekends too, and sitting on the swing-set hunched over like this, he could picture himself from the outside—a perfect representation of surly fifteen-year-old Harrison, a tragic kid trying to find his place in the world after his sister had died. Even his sweatshirt was black, just like the old days.

He was supposed to be moving forward, but it seemed like he was regressing. But there were changes in him, and he felt them. Was proud of them.

And here, coming across the grassy patch—where sometimes they would play a game of 500 in the field next to the baseball diamond, going up on the hill with a bat and knocking out balls to whomever had showed up—was Kelsey Kay. Home for the weekend, he'd called her to hang out for an hour because he had to get out of the house before he screamed at his mother.

Kay took her time, head down, texting, sauntering across the field in a leather jacket, silver hair pulled back, hot pink ponytail fluttering off to one

side like a pennant. She wore skinny jeans, sneakers. He couldn't wait to talk to her.

At last she made her way to him, pausing a moment to clasp one of her hands on a firefighter pole—her silver rings knocking and singing against the metal—doing one loop-the-loop before tucking her phone in her jacket pocket and skipping to meet him, mocking him, being a little girl doing little girl things. And he got the message: Harrison still lived at home.

He laughed, his face tucked in the shroud of his hood, waiting for her to join him. She threw herself into the next swing, getting it to bump against him, putting her sneakers in the sand and pushing herself around so she swung in lazy circles. She hooked her arms around the chains, leaned forward and spit into the sand. He waited.

When he said nothing she finally sat up and looked at him. He showed her his face.

“Holy fucking shit, what the hell happened to you?” There was horror there in her expression at first—but by the end of her sentence her pretty lips were already smirking.

“Got a black eye,” he said.

“Really? I didn't notice.”

He squinted the injured eye, smiled at her.

When he'd woken this morning, it was a true-blue shiner. A dark purple disk under his eyebrow, the slit of his puffy eye narrow and wet. It looked good.

“Oh my God, Harrison,” she laughed. “Your mom do this?”

“No,” he said, indignant.

“That's a good shiner,” she said, working with her toes so they could get closer. She hooked an arm around his chain, joining them together. She studied his face. “So what happened?”

“Outside Scratchy's—”

She tsk-ed, rolled her eyes, let go of his chain and swung back to where she was.

“What . . . ?”

“You were out with Brady.”

“Yeah. So?”

“What happened?”

“I dunno, we were there late, there were these girls, we were headed out —”

“What girls?” she said, brow lowering, hands slipping into the pockets of her jacket as she hunched forward studying him.

“I don’t know, there were these girls there, when we went outside, these guys pulled up in a pickup truck—”

“Were you drinking?”

“We were just watching a game, hanging out. We had some beer—”

“Harrison, you’re like nineteen-years-old—don’t go to Scratchy’s . . .”

“They’re cool, they don’t ask for I.D.”

“No, but it’s a bunch of young idiots who end up having fights with guys over girlfriends and shit . . .”

“So what?”

“You’re not supposed to drink. Smarten up.”

“You smarten up.”

“You make me,” she said, and he laughed. She wasn’t joking.

“Well, whatever,” he said, “we went to the gym, Brady and I, we had an awesome workout . . . After, we went out to get something to eat and we just hung out at the bar.”

She shook her head admonishingly. “You’re such a loser.”

“Fuck off, Kay.”

“Look at you,” she said, and he saw that she was smirking again.

“Anyway, there were these girls, and some guy showed up with his buddies . . .”

“Oh, fucking spare me,” she said rolling her eyes. “I don’t even want to know. So you got in a fight, good for you.”

“Sheesh,” he said, getting stung by her disdain. They sat and swung idly, chains squeaking and groaning, watching out across the field to the backyards of the neighbors’ houses. They were quiet for a long while. He asked her how her weekend was going.

“Good. Me and pop are having some father-daughter time. He’s golfing now, and I’ll die before I golf, but we’re going out for dinner.”

“That’s nice.”

She sighed, said, “Fucking Res sucks.”

“Fucking commuting sucks.”

“Commuting sucks, *and* you live at home,” she said.

“What would you rather? Res or living at home.”

“My home or your home?” Smirking again.

“Yeah, good point.”

"I feel for you. But Res does suck. I gotta get out of there."

"What are you going to do?"

"Get my own place."

"You talking to your dad?"

She nodded. She turned to face him. "We should get a place together."

"I'm tapped, Kay," he said, and she swung toward him again, bumping his hips.

"We can figure it out," she said.

"Maybe *you* can figure it out. I got a couple hundred bucks to my name. I got insurance on my car, gas . . . "

"Fucking sell it, Harrison. You got that car to be independent, but you're living at home . . . Somebody's not seeing the whole picture . . . "

"Thanks, Dr. Phil."

She swung against him harder, hip-checking him. "Serious."

"There's nothing to even consider, Kay."

"Whatever."

Quiet again, they swung, Kelsey spat in the sand. She said, "How'd your mom take it?"

"Take what?"

She touched a finger under her eye. "Shiner."

"Fucking freaked out like crazy. Why do you think I called you?"

"What'd she say?"

He just rolled his eyes. It was awful. He'd lied through his teeth to her about how he'd gained the black eye, and even his ameliorating story did nothing to reduce his mother's sting. "I just needed to get out of the house," he said.

"Where's your dad?"

"Golfing. Maybe he's golfing with your dad."

She chuckled; he joined in. Their dads did not golf together.

"Yeah, shit her pants. She grounded me."

Kay laughed bright and loud, her hilarity stretching out to a long breathy snicker. "Did you tell her you're nineteen?"

"I told her."

"Apartment, bro," she said and held up a fist for her knuckles to be bumped. He gave her a dab and shoved his hand back in his sweatshirt pouch. "Maybe," he said.

"Sell the Soob. Come hang with me. You gotta get out of your house."

He looked over his shoulder, a wary, natural action. His house was behind him, his mom behind him, but always lurking. Couldn't see the house, but he was looking over his shoulder just the same. "Live with *you*?"

"Separate rooms."

"Save costs if we shared a bed . . ."

"So gross . . ."

"That's gross?" He laughed.

"I'm not sharing a bed with you."

"You just want to keep an eye on me."

"Do you need keeping an eye on?" she asked, imitating his squint now, narrowing her right eye and studying him.

He chuckled, returned his gaze out toward the neighbors' backyards.

She didn't look away, staring at the side of his head. Too smart, she knew something was up. "What? . . ." she said, a firm pronouncement.

"Don't you want to hear my story?"

"About how you're hanging out with those fucking losers Brady does, nineteen-years-old drinking at a bar; how you'll get stuck in Saginaw if you're not smart?"

"That's not my story."

"That's kinda your story," she said snidely.

He gave her a sidelong glance and smirked. "I like Brady."

"Okay."

"It was fucking crazy last night, Kay."

"Why?"

"Okay, I punched a guy in the parking lot."

"Great, stuck in Saginaw County Jail. That's a great way to get anchored. Nice knowing you."

"I know. I didn't want to, it really did just happen so fast. He shoved me first, punched me in the eye, and I don't know what happened . . ."

"Because you were drinking."

"We were just having fun."

"It's fun until what happens?"

"Somebody . . . loses . . . an eye . . . ?" he said hesitatingly, voice high and thin and questioning.

"Don't be smug," she said. "You know what I mean. It's so easy to get lost here. So easy to become nothing. Nothing is *easy*. *Something* is hard."

"That's what I'm trying to do, Kay, I'm trying to *be* something."

“You are on the wrong path, my friend.”

“Well, thanks for the talk,” he said, feigning stretching and standing, “I’m a head out . . . ”

“You think I’m wrong?”

He jabbed shovel hands in the air between them. “I don’t know. I was excited to tell you my story, now I feel like it’s stupid . . . ”

“All right, just tell me. So what happened? You punched some guy. I’m sure he deserved it.”

“He shoved me, punched me first.”

“Go on.”

“So yeah, the guy hits me, and I punch him, the guy’s bigger than me and he goes *down* . . . ”

“My hero,” she said and clutched her hands together at her cheek, blinking sardonically.

“This whole story was going a lot better in my head before I started telling you.”

“You gotta know your audience.”

He sighed. “Why did I call you?”

“Because you love me.”

“Anyway, we’re all shit-talking, shoving, two guys are still scrapping and then the cops come flying down Brockway . . . ”

“Oh my God,” she croaked, turning her eyes up so she showed only the whites. Her eyelashes fluttered.

“Yeah, so I take off with this girl, running down the side streets, you know, behind Scratchy’s . . . ?”

“Cool.”

“Kay, the cops are *looking* for us. They got the lights on, cop cars are creeping through the neighborhood and we hide out in this backyard . . . ”

“Such a bad boy. Is that what you want me to say?”

“Just listen.”

“I’m listening.”

“No, you keep interrupting and saying shitty things.”

“Your story’s shit.”

“You’re shit.”

“Go on.”

Now he was mad, didn’t even want to finish his story anymore. He had it all figured out, a three act play that he would impress her with. Before she

showed up, he was excited to tell somebody about his awesome night. But he should have expected this from Kay.

When he was silent too long, she said, “Don’t be such a child. Just finish your story.”

He punched her with it. “The girl gave me a blow job.”

He expected a scoffing sound, a gasp. Instead she punched him in the arm. Really hard. The rounded edge of a silver skull ring kneading between his shoulder muscles and banging against the bone. He jumped like she had zapped him with a cattle prod. “Jesus, Kay, holy shit!”

“She *what*?” She hauled back and punched him again in the shoulder, very close to where she’d nailed him the first time.

He sneakered his swing out of her range, rubbing his arm, scowling and wincing. “You fucking hit me hard,” he said, rubbing the shoulder, standing up now, his arm still hooked around the chains.

Kay said, “What did you do?”

“What . . . ?—I told you.”

“Who is she?”

“I don’t even know.”

“You’re such an idiot.”

“You’re the fucking idiot, why would you hit me so hard?”

“You fucking—you deserve it. What is *wrong* with you?”

“What? . . . ”

She folded her arms, looking away. “I don’t even want to hear your stupid story.” She was mad and pouting, hunched over, steaming hot, staring holes out into the neighbors’ backyards.

“Thought you’d be proud of me.”

She clucked her tongue. “Was the girl proud of you? Was she one of those fucking sluts impressed by a nineteen-year-old hanging out at a sports bar with a bunch of his weightlifting buddies? Did she think you’re so hot because you punched some guy then took off from the cops? . . . ”

“She—”

“That’s the life for you? That’s what you see?”

“Jesus, Kay, you’re so fucking savage.”

“Savage,” she said nodding, examining the word. “That’s a Brady word. Cool, bro.”

“Why am I friends with you?” The meanness in her face stayed there, but it softened. She hummed in her throat.

It took a while, but soon she muttered, "Sorry."

"For hitting me?"

"You're right, I flew off the handle."

"What does a blowjob matter, anyway?"

"It matters."

He threw his hands up, spoke to the sky. "She hardly texts me even. Always with this fucking Tripp now, driving around in his Porsche. What does any of it matter?"

"You know it matters. You're yelling at the sky, that's a good sign it matters."

"I'm yelling at you."

"You know it matters."

They swung sideways again, bumping hips, drawing lines in the sand with the toes of their sneakers.

He said, "I'm glad she told me about him, but now they're seeing each other or something, and, like, she doesn't have the time of day for me."

"She's not dating him. And she's not exactly speedy getting back to me either."

"That's good."

She side-eyed him.

He said, "You know, cause it's not just me she's forgetting about."

"It's not just you."

He sighed, a heavy weight settling on his heart. He kept his eyes straight ahead, asked Kay: "Is she still fucking him?"

Kay's head nodded up and down in his periphery.

"She told you that?"

"Yeah. But it's not serious."

"Not yet," he grumbled. "Just fucking."

"Give her space."

He grumbled again, gritted his teeth. "Sometimes I just fucking hate her, you know? Fucking *hate*. And then . . ."

"I get it, Harrison. It's up to you, kid. You want in, you gotta ride the choppy waves. You want out, then you're a smart guy. I think you're in the middle: a smart guy who's got it bad for the first girl who took his heart, and he's just lost out on those waves watching a storm rolling in."

"She took my heart and stomped on it."

"She did. I warned you. You know it's going to get worse."

“Oh God,” he sighed, clutched his forehead and squeezed, rubbed and beat knuckles on his temples. The hate came back, and he reveled in it for a moment. It gave him strength. He smiled, told Kelsey, “The girl last night . . . ?—she was hot too. Like, Taylor-hot.”

“Good for you. One of Brady’s skanks, I’m sure your dick will fall off from syph-level gingivitis or something.”

“Weren’t you a Brady-skank?”

She looked at him seriously. “Treat me with respect, Harrison. Don’t talk to me like that.”

It chilled him. “I’m sorry, I am. Just goofing around.”

“I should record you, play it back so you can hear yourself, hear what a dick you sound like sometimes.”

“Hear yourself sometimes, Kay.”

She scowled, leveled eyes at him. “I’m the thin fiber holding you and Tay-Tay together, I’m stretching to snapping because I *like* you. Don’t become someone I *don’t* like, or I’ll cut that fucking string and let you drop like a stone.”

He pressed his thighs together, feeling ill and bad. “Ouch,” he said, quiet. “Sorry.”

“Just be the Harrison we all know and love, okay?”

“That Harrison isn’t good enough.”

“Be you but better.”

“Jesus,” he sighed. “This is so hard, Kay. I’m open. *We’re* open, me and Taylor. What about all that shit about being the guy who could share her? Doesn’t that guy get in fights and get blowjobs while the cops are looking for him?”

She flicked her eyes up. “I’m fucking bewildered with you right now.”

“Why?”

“Who *are* you? Is that you? Is that Harrison?”

“I don’t know who Harrison is.”

“That Harrison is a shit like Brady and his gang of dead-enders who, five-years from now, won’t have those roid bodies, will be fat and beer-bellied, angry, unsatisfied. Pregnant girlfriend they don’t even like, still banging side pieces, and getting in fights outside of Scratchy’s. Look ahead, Harrison—you’re an adult now, you need a five-year plan.”

“Sometimes I think you’re actually looking out for me, you know . . . ?”

She smiled to one side. “I really am sorry I hit you.”

“I’m going to have a bruise.”

“You are.”

“Does the guy who shares his girlfriend have bruises?”

She didn’t laugh or smile, just looked at him.

He said, “I didn’t even want it.”

“Want what?”

“The blowjob.”

“You’re not that guy.”

“I didn’t ask for it or anything. I couldn’t believe she even tried. There was a cop looking for us, going up and down the sidewalk on the other side of the fence. We were hiding, for Christ’s sake. I didn’t stop her. But, like, she just did it—it was crazy, exciting, you know? But then the cop comes stomping down, and he’s right there, breathing, Kay, fucking so close we hear him *breathing*. He jiggles the gate where we came through. I pulled my dick out of her mouth, and she’s like quiet-cackling . . . ”

“How did you get away?”

“Once the cop walked on, we scooted, I grabbed her arm and we shot to the house’s front yard, then hopped fences straight across till we came out behind that Dollar Tree plaza . . . ? Then we were safe, just two people on a date, walking around the plaza. There’re restaurants there . . . ”

“Not much of a blowjob.”

“I’m holding it close. It’s something. She really was hot, Kay.”

“All right, all right . . . ”

“We called Brady, and he swung by, picked us up.”

Kay nodded for a while, said, “Don’t hang out with those meatheads.”

“Why not? I had fun. A lot of fun.”

“They’re on steroids.”

“So what?”

She looked at him. “Dude, if I have to put you in an after-school-special chokehold, I will.”

“I’m not taking steroids.”

“Good. Don’t.”

“Brady said don’t bother till a year and a half, then all my natural growth will taper and then I can start a cycle of—”

“Oh my God, this is what I mean. Don’t hang out with Brady.”

“Kay, you dated him.”

“He had a hot body, and he was really good in bed.”

“He’s fun, you know it. And what the fuck, you said he was on steroids and *you* spent time with him.”

“Are you an idiot—you think there was ever a chance *I* would start taking steroids?”

He stared at her till his comment’s stupidity seeped in. “Good point.”

“You’re a sweet guy. I like you lifting weights. But you’re not like them. Don’t try to imitate them, they’re not good guys. Brady was a stunt fuck, not a boyfriend.”

Stunt fuck indeed. How could he explain to Kay he had a haunting image of the foursome they had up at Wolf Lake, and his beloved Taylor—after fucking Brady—had jerked Brady off onto his stomach. Taylor’s lusty eyes turned down, watching his good-looking dick in her hand, then practically swooning when the guy’s load splashed onto his rock-hard flexed abs. “So hot,” Taylor had sighed, watching the guy’s come line the valleys of his washboard stomach. Didn’t Kay know how bad *he* wanted that power? To be that for Taylor, to make her horny and perverse like that? He wanted to be a stunt fuck on top of being her heart-connection. He wanted to be everything for her. The thought of another man should be an impossibility. The fact she wanted other men was a weakness on his own part, one he wanted to correct.

When he looked up again, Kay was watching him, her head cocked with a measure of sympathy. She said, “Gloomy Gus.”

“Yeah,” he agreed. How long would it take for him to be the Harrison Taylor already loved plus a shredded stud she couldn’t keep her hands off? Not by Thanksgiving. Brady said a whole year. A whole year of suffering while his girlfriend fucked her way across a California university campus, him on his knees like some acolyte, worshipping at a temple of weightlifting, hoping one day to be fucking worthy of the girl who was literally crushing his heart.

Kay swung his way, hooked a heel between his knees and they locked legs, both of them clutching the chains and looking at each other close.

“Okay,” she said. “Maybe I’m a little hard on you. You’re a sweet guy who benefits from a strong hand. Tough love, you know. I don’t want to see you hurt.”

“Thanks.”

“Don’t be gloomy.”

“It’s hard, Kay.”

They stayed close. Quiet, which was nice, just two people who had grown up together and shared a lot of shit.

She squeezed one of his legs in a lock, pulse-flexing her thighs over and over. “Where are you taking me for my birthday?”

“Me?”

“Yeah, you.”

“You don’t want to go out with your friends?”

“You are my friend, Harrison. I want to go out with someone I know. It’s my birthday, for fuck’s sake. I don’t want to go out on my birthday with new friends. Just me and you. Make it good. I want to have fun.”

He chuckled, looked at her. “So, no pressure . . . ”

Chapter Three

LAST NIGHT she and Tripp had gone to the Boardwalk again, and now she lay with him in his dorm room bed. Carnival smells clung in her hair: cotton candy, funnel cakes, kettle corn; she'd eaten a phallic corn dog on a stick and he watched her, laughing, getting her snorting too, both of them ending up hunched over, cackling. They'd shared a deep-fried Twinkie and a churro, standing under the flashing lights across from the Looff Carousel, the glossy hundred-year-old mannequin horses going around, doing the up and down thing, the simulated galloping, riders trying to toss brass rings into the open mouth of a clown painted on a board.

They took a tour on the Sky Glider again, moving on a slow cable twenty feet above the Boardwalk, suspended inside a pastel-colored pill, some futuristic half a Tic Tac design that looked wild and crazy in 1950 aged now to cute and whimsical. On the creaking nighttime tour, feet dangling out of the bulb-shaped carriage, they'd watched the ocean, the beach, the people below, held hands, and they kissed. A lot. Enough they got their heart rates high. She would've loved to do more, ached to do it, but they were so exposed. Sure, they toured high above the carnival crowd, but artificial light billowed up from below. They waited till they were some place dark.

After the Sky Glider, they played some shooting games, her standing with her hand on Tripp's back, like two teenagers in an old movie from the eighties, her tall handsome roguish boyfriend hunched over with a BB rifle cabled to the countertop, pinging off Old West gunfighters as they popped up behind barrels. He won her a teddy bear. It lay in bed with them. And

after that, she couldn't wait to make out with him again, all primed from their tour on the Sky Glider.

They went to the Cave Train, hustling to get the last car in the long line of two-passenger carts attached to the imitation steam engine up front with its cow catcher plow. The ride was a dark adventure, following a path through animatronic cavemen and dinosaurs. In the last cart they were unwatched. Tripp squeezed the inside of her thigh while they kissed, and she guided his hand under her shirt then shoved it down her pants. Her jeans were tight, but Tripp got a finger inside her. She opened her legs wide, his tongue in her mouth, a long finger probing inside her, tickling dark pleasure, practically coming as they passed the Sharkasaurus, her eyes rolling up as they entered a swirling cave with neon-painted pictographs. After that, she took him by the hand, and they quick-stepped, trying to find where he'd parked his sports car. Quick drive with the top down, back to campus, and they were running to the dorm room. Quincy, his roommate, was home but passed out drunk. Face down in his bed, they didn't disturb him coming in. Their mouths went all over each other, stumbling and tripping, falling into his bed. They made love once, fast and hard. The second time slow. Lots of hands, lots of mouth; he finished inside her again.

Outside Tripp's dorm room window, the top of a palm tree rocked from side to side, a silent wind kicking up one frond, folding it in half over and over, flapping where it had weakened. The sky glowed blue, hot looking. It would be a nice sunny Sunday out there. The halls boomed with action. It sounded like somebody was running an air compressor somewhere down the hall. She had no idea what that was. There was yelling, laughing, thumping. The whole outside world moving on around them, her and Tripp safe in his narrow single bed. So narrow, their bodies pressed together. One thing the dorms had going for them was the sweet ass air-conditioning. She wasn't too hot even under sheets and a comforter, pressed up against a tanned California boy.

Tripp Heavens was heavenly. No doubt about it. Last weekend she'd induced him to taking her to the boardwalk. Show her all the sites he'd bragged about out in Pogo, show her the amusement park. And they'd had fun. Good honest fun. Yeah, they had sex later, but good wholesome sex. Then the guy didn't call her for a week. Just a couple of texts. She bumped into him in the hall, did that flirty thing she hadn't done in so long. Maybe they were an item, maybe they weren't. One thing for sure: she loved laying

in bed with him, loved waking up with him. He was tall, maybe *six-two*. Her eyes came to his collarbone when they were standing. It was nice being at the park with him. Nice holding hands with him, feeling safe with him. He had big hands, and she liked hers inside them. She watched him sleep. It was just the two of them, Quincy awake but gone, probably drowning himself in chocolate milk and aspirin, hanging out with the guys playing Xbox in the rec area.

She rolled to face Tripp, slunk an arm across his chest, let her curled hand rest on his neck. He breathed softly. He had perfect pouting lips, masculine still, and when he woke in the two mornings she'd been with him, she liked to thumb the stubble on his jaw. There was a strange hidden ruggedness to him. Because he was youthful, boyish, or right at that precipice where you could see the man parts coming out. Confident, calm. She thought about him a lot.

She tested the scratch on his chin, going up the angle of his jaw and playing with his earlobe while he slept. His eyelashes fluttered. She kissed his nipple. She wore one of his T-shirts and it was huge on her. Panties underneath that. Her clothes tossed off somewhere on the door room floor, tangled with his. He didn't sleep nude, which she found weird. After they'd had sex the second time, he tugged on a pair of boxer shorts. It was curious, but cute. He had a great dick. A really sexy one. Not that she was a dick girl, but it was fun getting familiar with that secret part of him. It was big when it was soft. Floppy, kind of fat, wrinkled, sagging. It was fun to discern the glans's shape under the heavy skin. She'd coaxed him last Wednesday when they had a quickie here in his dorm room to shake his hips and get it slapping side to side. He called her stupid, but did it anyway, both of them laughing, him trying it but only for a few seconds before he jumped back on the bed face down. She climbed on his back and kissed his shoulders. It was nice.

Tripp's phone lay up in the pillows, his screen coming to slow life, showing an incoming email, no name. *Shit, it was almost twelve o'clock.* She was starving.

"Hey," she whispered, scratching the nail of her index finger on his lower lip, pulling it down and getting a good look at his healthy gums and bright white lower teeth. "Let's get breakfast," she said.

He moaned, didn't wake. She peeled the sheet down, showed off that hard sinewy chest and stomach. He had a sparse scatter of hair up the center

of his chest, then it disappeared, emerging again down below his navel in a scraggly stripe down to his dick.

She slipped a hand under the sheets, right under the waistband of his boxers, grabbed a handful of soft warm man flesh. She squeezed, gently pulled. Now he was waking. His eyebrows raised, lowered, eyes squinting, eyebrows raising again. He made a funny cough in his throat, his lips blew a gentle raspberry. His eyes opened, she thumbed over his cock head, his foreskin pulled back. He moaned and smiled, stretched, folded an arm up behind his head, showing off that matching thatch of hair in his underarm. With his penis still in her hand, she leaned over and put her nose in that man patch and kissed him there.

He caressed her head, cupped her cheek, guided her up to his mouth. They tongued. His penis grew larger. He said, "How long have you been awake?" his head turned to the side, disguising his morning breath.

"Just up," she said, now wary of her own breath. She spoke away from him. He laughed, picking up on what they were both doing. He rolled a shoulder over, tugged open the top drawer of his nightstand, withdrew a blister pack of gum. He thumbed out two pieces; they chewed. She never stopped with her hand on him. He was growing. She was horny. He asked her what time it was.

"It's almost lunchtime. You want to go get something to eat?"

"Yeah, but then I got a whole bunch of shit I have to do this afternoon. Shoot, really?—It's lunchtime?"

"Almost twelve."

"Shit," he said.

"We don't have to eat," she said, kissed his neck. The air swirled between them, minty and fresh.

"I'm hungry too."

"I don't want to bug you if you got shit to do. But, you know . . ."

"You know what?" he said smirking.

"One more time?"

His eyes narrowed as he smiled. "You're so sexy, Michigan."

She smiled too, showed him her teeth, blew a tiny bubble with the meager piece of chewing gum. He poked it with a finger. It popped.

"You're sexy too," she said, winding her tongue around to gather back the popped gum webbing.

“I don’t even think you get what I’m talking about. You should see what you look like, you should see your face right now.”

She persisted. “You should see your face.”

“Wow,” he said, “you mean we’re both hot?”

“We’re both hot,” she said, nodded, feeling good.

“Everybody better look out.”

She opened her mouth, a joke about to escape that could burst the bubble. Something about what their babies would look like. Boy, would that deflate things fast. She just laughed instead, hid her face on his chest. He stroked her shoulder, gathered her hair, wove his fingers through it over and over.

Now his cock was hard, evident under the bedding; she poked it out through the fly of the boxers, and wagged it back and forth, a ghost in his lap the size of a Barbie doll with a sheet over its head.

“Don’t,” he said, snickering, “that tickles,” his knees raising.

“What tickles?”

“The sheet on the tip.”

“Oh, is that your dick,” she said, “I thought it was a ghost.”

He snapped back the sheet, whispered, “Boo.”

She giggled, looked at her hand gripping his thick erection. She rolled it up, watched the foreskin swallow that plump end of him. Yanked down slow, the gummy skin retracting, exposing that sensitive part of him; the part when stimulated provoked propulsion. She let her fingers wander up, circle around the bulb end, tickling.

“God, you’re so amazing.”

“I had so much fun last night,” she said.

“Me too,” he said, snapping gum.

“What do you have to do today?”

“A bunch of phone calls, homework, reading, I got to meet up with a couple guys about this thing we’re doing . . .”

Vague. Noncommittal. Couple guys about this thing. Could be girls for all she knew. “You call me Michigan.”

“Where you’re from.” He smoothed a hand over her hair.

“Calling me Michigan to keep all your girls straight? Like you’ve got a Kansas, a Wisconsin, a Texas . . .”

“I know who you are, Taylor. I don’t have to keep you straight in my mind. I think about you all the time.”

“Not other girls?”

“How serious do you want to be?”

“It’s a little early to be serious, Tripp,” she said, condescending, even though she was the one setting off the conversation.

“You’re the one . . .” He chuckled. When she looked up, he’d closed his eyes.

“Hey,” she said, setting the point of her chin on his chest, showing him her sultry face.

“What?”

“What kind of range you got on this thing?” She wagged his dick left and right.

“Range?”

“How far does it shoot?” She squinted an eye, gave him a serious stare like she saw all men do when they were assessing each other’s equipment; race boats, sports cars, fishing gear, golf clubs, whatever.

“What you mean? When I come?”

“Yeah how far does it go?”

He laughed. “I don’t know. I never measured it.”

“Can you take a guess?”

“It’s kinda different every time.”

She grunted, raised her eyebrows. “Really?”

“Sure.”

“I guess that makes sense.”

His head rolled her way. “Like if it’s been a while . . .” He let it hang

“That makes a difference?”

“Sure.”

She rolled to her back, switched hands on his dick, laying side by side, stroking his dick with her more clumsy left hand, both of them looking up.

“Like if you wait a long time would it reach the ceiling?”

“No way,” he laughed. “No, there’s no way. No way I could do that.”

She squeezed and stroked, her thigh rubbing against his. “I saw a video once where a guy practically did.”

“It was probably fake.”

“I guess so. Yeah, it could be fake . . . It was a lot too.”

“Where did you see this?”

“Porn.”

“You watch porn? You and your boyfriend?”

“No. Not me and Harrison. Never. Oh, maybe once. No, me and my friend used to sometimes.”

“Why?”

She looked upside down at him, eyes rolled up in her head. “Why did we watch porn?”

“No, why did you want to know?”

She hummed, considering. “Operational efficiency.”

“What?”

“Like, if I want to suck your dick on the Sky Glider, jerk you off . . . ”

He made a chuffing sound of appreciation, her words turning him on. He chuckled. “Yeah?”

“I need to know the liabilities . . . ”

Their eyes met, stayed connected. He said, “You’re so bad. In the best way possible, Michigan.”

She wormed up to kiss him and he folded an arm around her back. They made out, nibbled lips, sucked tongues. Her hand slunk down again, found his hardness. She looked in his eyes; they were point blank.

He said, “You want to suck my dick on the Sky Glider?”

She whispered, “I wanted to last night.”

“That was a blast.”

“Uh-huh . . . ” She bit her lower lip, jerked him, humped his leg.

His eyes rolled with the pleasure she delivered, and he groaned. “You are a hundred percent the sexiest girl I’ve ever met in my life . . . ”

Now she kept his eyes, thumbed down her panties, let her bare leg eclipse his. Panties whisked out from under the sheets, she batted them against his face. Instant regret slapped her—shit, what if they smelled?—she snatched them back before it was too late, tossing them overboard. She laughed it off, in case he thought of remarking about her stinky panties. She wormed up his body and kissed him.

Tripp rolled her way, looking to get on top of her.

“No, like this,” she said, squirming out from underneath him. She turned to her side, faced the wall, Tripp settled his body against hers.

“You have a beautiful back,” he said, looming behind her on his side, tracing his fingertips over her shoulder blades and down her spine.

“That feels nice . . . ”

He scooped a hand over her haunch, pushed one of her knees forward to scissor her legs open.

“Yeah,” she said, and he fidgeted behind her, his body bouncing on the bed as he got closer. The pads of his two middle fingers stroked at her stripe now, moving slippery, finding her wet spilling over.

“Mm, yeah,” she whispered again

Then he was angling, his stomach touching the low of her back, the hard end of his dick poking against her butt cheek, the back of her thigh, finding her center. She arched, angled herself for penetration. He pushed inside her, doing it slow but insistent, his weight rolling over top of her, one of his hands landing down on the bed right in front of her face between her nose and the wall. She kissed his thumb as he sunk deeper.

“God, that’s it,” she sighed.

“You feel so good, Taylor . . . ”

“God, your dick . . . ”

“You are incredible . . . ”

* * *

NOW IT WAS QUIET, Tripp pushing himself in and out; she caressed his wrist, looked at her small hand next to his. Lay the flat of her palm against the back of his hand, measuring her thin little fingers against his. He fucked her. Her breath came quicker, and she submitted to him. Didn’t give him anything back, just lay and received, examining the pleasure. Not making love now, but being made love to. A vessel. Her upturned spout receiving his male reproductive organ; reaming in and out of her, a little oversized, maybe a little too thick, but why did that produce pleasure? That was biology, that was the message to her brain. *We want this*. Provide lubrication, give me pleasure, make this act of biology a desirable thing, one I enjoy. And she enjoyed it; could picture that thing he had, like a pinpoint camera angled out from her cervix and pointed toward the mouth of her canal, seeing that plump, succulent end of his reproductive impalement burrowing in, retracting, burrowing in, retracting . . . the pleasure she felt hypersensitive in that ripe plum-shape. The pleasure in him would overflow, enough his seed would billow outward; what would it look like from that camera viewpoint? That white milk spewing and roiling through her shiny pink insides, his penis slicking through . . .

“Oh,” she gasped, a sudden turning over in her stomach, her sex cranks winding up into a higher gear. She went wetter. Wet enough, she thought he might’ve come; but no, it was all her.

She went flatter on her stomach, the other leg bent outward, knee touching the wall, her legs like a figure-4. He pounded, his pubis bashing against her bottom. An orgasm rolled up, lapping at her shore, nice, but arriving with a warning: *There’s a bigger wave coming behind me, everybody run!*

“Ah, oh, ah, ah, mm, oh no . . .”

Then the door opened, the sound of the halls louder, the banging, whatever that compressor was, a bright metallic click-clack as someone levered the dorm room door, kicked it open, the metal handle banging against cinderblock. Tripp stopped, buried inside her, falling on top of her, rolling to his side, his penis still penetrating. She whimpered, her fingers holding on to what was assured, *promised* pleasure so damn close; that pleasure dissipating, that thing in her grasp turning to fog.

“Oh, come on,” she whisper-cried.

Tripp chuckled in her ear, and now Quincy was coming in, moaning from a heavy hangover, someone else laughing, two other dudes with him. Deep voice, that black guy, what was his name?—Hayward. Shoot, a whole bunch of guys coming in, she was naked, Tripp’s dick in her . . .

“Shee-it, hold on . . . hey man, what’s up?” Deep voice. Hayward.

By her ear, Tripp said, “Hey, man.” They kept still.

There was chuckling. Three guys standing in their dorm room, seeing Tripp engaged with his girl. Front to back, fucking her from behind. Would they wonder if they were having anal sex?

Quincy’s voice now: “What’s up guys? Hey, Taylor . . .” His voice was thick with mellow nausea.

The third guy said to Quincy, “You get it?” Who was he? *Who cares?*

Quincy, on the edge of puking: “Yeah, come on, let’s go . . .”

More snickering. Probably all of them glancing at each other, *Hey, check out Tripp and Taylor*. Fuck off, guys.

More snickering then a snort, silence. She waited. Tripp snuffled near her ear. His penis was still hard, and she had tightened on him. His light laughing felt slippery and ticklish. She snickered too.

The silence exploded with a cottony whomp. It was followed by cackling, growing distant down the hall to the door, dorm room door

slamming shut.

“Fucking assholes,” Tripp said, laughing. Before leaving, they’d walloped him with a pillow.

“Fucking come on,” she said, laughing too.

“Such idiots,” he chuckled.

“So I guess they knew what we were doing.”

“Our clothes are all over the floor, Taylor. I don’t think they thought we were having a nap. Your panties are right there . . . ”

She groaned.

“You want to keep going?”

“You want to finish?”

“You not feeling it now?”

“I’m feeling it. Or I *was* feeling it. Maybe it’s still there . . . ” She wiggled her butt against him, his erection feeling real good inside her.

“What do you need?”

“Get on top of me.”

“Like how?”

She flattened, getting her stomach onto the bed; Tripp, agile, staying inside her, rolling over on top of her. “I like your weight on me.”

“I’m not crushing you?”

“I like you crushing me.”

“Your body is so amazing,” he said.

“Tell me.”

He started fucking her again, her flat on her stomach, legs parted. He got his knees between them, jacking up and down, his cock stroking in and out of her.

“The sexiest body, Taylor.”

“Call me Michigan.”

“You don’t like it.”

“Do it.”

“Look at that perfect white-bikini Michigan ass—you tan in the summer?”

Pump-pump-pump . . .

“Ah, mm, I do . . . ”

“Get you to tan here in California, even out this little bare ass...”

Pump-pump-pump . . .

“Your dick feels so good . . . ”

“Yeah? . . . Go up to my folks place in Sequoia, sunbathe naked . . . ”

“You take me there?”

Pump-pump-pump . . .

“Shit, Taylor, look at your body . . . ”

“You like it?” She put her hands up under the pillow, breasts scratching against the rough door room cotton, her nipples hard and rubbery, rolling and folding against the fabric.

“Take you up there, spend some time with me . . . ”

“I’d do it . . . ”

Pump-pump-pump . . .

The headboard rattled . . .

She said, “Put your hands on my neck.”

He massaged her, one hand rubbing her shoulders, thumb pressing into the muscles.

“My neck, my throat . . . ”

The hand circled her neck, caressed her.

“Squeeze me . . . ”

“No . . . ”

“Come on . . . ”

“No, Taylor.”

“Fuck me harder,” she said, hiding disappointment, squinting, burrowing her face into the pillow trying to get away from it. She clutched the hand on her neck, squeezed his fingers. “Come inside me,” she squeaked.

She listened to him breathing hard and fast, his pace picking up, driving pleasure up between her legs and inside her. Their juices spilled and overflowed. Soon he was grunting and stabbing, pushing that thick thing deep and holding it. She could feel it pulsing and flexing, feel herself swamping with his seed. She groaned.

He sighed near her ear, whispered, “You didn’t? . . . ”

Come? “I did,” she lied—but she had earlier.

“Wow, Taylor,” he breathed, threw himself off her, his wet dick slicking out of her, drops of wet on her ass cheeks, his body bouncing on the bed. She rolled, watched the pleasure he received from being inside her body rush through him. The pulse in his neck pattered, a vein in his temple throbbed. She caressed his hairline. He was sweaty, his hair damp and thick.

“You’re so fucking sexy,” she told him.

He smiled dreamily. "Taylor, you're too much."

"Don't forget it," she said, running fingers over the knot of his cheekbone, the hollow of his cheeks, and over the ridge of his handsome jaw. Between his legs his fat organ lay upward and exhausted on his stomach, shining wet. Her lubrication, his semen. *Fucking amazing* . . .

Her phone buzzed; Tripp's dinged a beat afterward.

"Perfect timing," he said, and laughed, putting a forearm up over his brow, hiding his eyes away from the bright sun coming in the windows.

"You talk about my body," she said, "look at your body," walking her fingernails down the flat of his stomach, then her high-heeled first finger and middle finger doing a little walk-around tour of his belly-up dick, hiking a step, trotting over his scrotum to the other side.

They both laughed. His stomach bouncing up and down. He rolled and hugged her, gathered her up in his arms, making her feel small, grabbed her ass cheek, squeezed hard.

"I love your hands," she told him.

"I love everything about you," he said, the words way too big, and now the silence huge and heavy, those words looming large. That was the wrong thing to say. She knew what he meant, but didn't know how to respond. Laugh it off? Make it better? Stay silent? . . . She stayed silent; they were both kind of weird now. He chuckled, changed the energy of the moment by rolling away, collecting his phone. Still on his back, he held it a few inches above his face and brought it to life.

Hands folded under her cheek, she said, "Something important?"

"It's Ronny," he said, like she would know who that was. Probably just wanted her to know that it wasn't a girl. Unless Ronny *was* a girl. Ronny could be a girl. *Rhonda*. She was hurt for a moment, but didn't want to show it, so she sat up, sloughing it off. She said, "Grab me a sock or something . . ."

Tripp leaned over the edge of the bed and she watched the way his muscles worked against his skin, long and lean, she could look at him for a long time. He snatched up a sock from the floor, passed it to her.

"You don't have a clean one?"

"What do you need it for?"

She laughed. "What do you think?"

"Oh, hold on . . ." He sat up and looked around now.

“No, it’s fine,” she said, then patted between her legs with the long clean ankle and calf part, keeping the foot part on her thigh. She sopped up what dribbled from her, looked around now like she was unperturbed though she was turning over inside. Tripp returned to his messages. She saw her phone, picked it up. *She could check messages too.* Screen brought to life, she saw four alerts from Kelsey, two from Roxie, one from her dad, two from her mom, something from Shelby. All things she was supposed to get back to. The four from Kelsey were the most recent. Roxie was saying Don’t ghost me, bitch; her mom was saying Just let me know you’re okay; her dad was saying Haven’t heard from you in a while, angel. She couldn’t see what Shelby’s was, it was in a folder with a bunch of other unanswered messages. Probably some from Harrison in there too. He’d stopped texting a few days ago. The topmost messages had her attention.

Kay: code fucking red tay tay

Kay: bitch txt me back rn serious

Chapter Four

TAYLOR QUICK-THUMBED A TEXT.

Taylor: Code red what?

She waited. *Come on, fucking Kay, you're always texting me, get back to me.* Like she expected her friend to be sitting on pins and needles waiting for her response.

"Shit," she sighed, letting her head fall back. *Was there bad news?*

Tripp asked her what was wrong, and she said, "Ah, nothing. It's my friend, Kay. Just some shit at home."

"It's all right?"

"I don't know yet," she said, shrugging to show it wasn't a big deal. Was kinda cool, though, to sit here, leaning with her back against his wall, topless, happy, sock collecting the leaking load from her hot and popular boyfriend. Tripp went back to his phone. *Come on, Kay . . .*

Her phone dinged.

Kay: where u been bitch?

Taylor: right here

Taylor: what's going on?

Kay: code fucking red

Taylor: u said that

Kay: it's Harrison

A sudden cold front moved in, all that acquired warmth chilling, practically crackling while it frosted over.

Taylor: What's wrong with Harrison

He hadn't texted in days. Was he hurt, was her Harrison hurt . . . ?

She waited and waited, dying to read what Kay would text.

At last Kay responded, and it was horrible.

Kay: Harrison got a bj from some skank

It was like a slap across the face. She shook her head, bewildered. Maybe she read it wrong. *Not Harrison.*

She tried to text back but her hands were shaking. *What do you mean* came out mis-typed.

Taylor: what dpo yopou mena

Kay: some fuckbitch girl went down on him

Kay: you should hear him

"Oh no, oh my gosh," she sighed.

Tripp said, "What's wrong?"

"Nothing."

She texted fast.

Taylor: who's the girl

Kay: some skank at Scratchy's

Taylor: Like an old woman?

Kay: no our age

Taylor: who?

Kay: some bitch

Taylor: what's her name?

Kay: I don't know

Taylor: find out

She waited, Kay's dancing dots taking forever.

Kay: if u want I will believe me I will

Taylor: what happened?

Kay: He's lifting weights with Brady

"Oh no, no, no," she said.

Tripp said, "Is something wrong?"

"I'm fine," she said, though she was not fine.

Taylor: Is he seeing her?

Kay: I don't think so

Kay: maybe

Taylor: are you serious?

Kay: I said code red

Kay: how's it going there?

Taylor: Is he going to see her again?

Kay: You know what he's like

She put her phone down face first. Buried her face in her hands. She *did* know what Harrison was like. Some girl coming on to him, him feeling all hurt . . . it was just like Kay'd said. This skank would wrap him around her finger. Harrison. Her sweet Harrison. Her best friend. With some other girl? Her stomach rolled over, and a queasy, furry squeeze came up her throat. She hitched a breath and gulped before she yakked all over Tripp's bed.

"Are you okay?" Tripp set his phone down, looking at her.

"No," she said, her voice a gurgling croak.

"Shoot, what's going on?"

She shook her head no. "Nothing," she blurted.

"Tell me."

"I can't," she said, the tears coming but pushing them back.

"Holy shit, Taylor, did something happen?"

"Uh-huh," she said, bewildered. Couple thousand miles away from home, no one to talk to, a thin digital strand between her and Kay the only tenuous connection she had to everything that mattered, everything that *should* matter...

She scooted forward, breasts jiggling, covering them with a forearm now. Tripp sidled, put his arm around her, held her. "Shoot, what do you need—what's going on?"

"Nothing."

"Taylor, serious, you just went gray. Literally *gray* . . ."

She pressed her cheeks, eyes wide but unseeing. Harrison with some fucking girl, way too much perfume, some slut that'll spread her legs for everybody, some piece of shit skank with cowboy boots or some shit, some

Michigan trashcan hooker, seeing how cute Harrison was, that little smile, that glint in his eyes, all that hurt inside, the brave guy he was out front.

She punched a fist on the mattress. *Bitch didn't even know him.*

"Hey," Tripp said, rubbing a hand up and down her arm, soothing her.

"I gotta go," she said.

"Taylor, stay with me. Don't go."

"I'm going to go," she said, "I don't even know what the fuck I'm doing anymore," standing up, hands jabbing in the air, looking around wild-eyed, stepping on her clothes scattered on the floor.

"Hey," he said, standing up, still sweaty, so good-looking, fat dick half-hard. He was tall, his head above her; she fell against his chest. "What's going on?" he asked, rubbing her back.

"It's my boyfriend," she said.

Tripp stiffened, then relaxed, drew in a short breath. "Something happen to him?"

"I don't want to talk about it," she said. "I just . . . I want to go."

"You can go," he said, arms slinking away from her.

She looked up at him, sheepish, stupid. "Yeah," she said dumbly, "I think I should go," snatching up her things from the floor.

Tripp watched her dress, sitting on the bed, turning his phone over in his hands, over and over, watching her put legs through panties, squeeze her way-too tight jeans on, slip feet in her shoes, throw on a shirt. "Hey," she said, putting her hand out and wiggling her fingers.

He eyed her. He said, "What?" She could tell he was hurt.

"My bear."

Tripp looked to the side, around behind him and under his elbow. The bear he'd won her pinging off black-hat cowboys with a BB gun. "Oh yeah," he said, and handed it over.

She quivered inside—a fucking *earthquake*—trying to hold it all together. There were only seconds before she burst into crying, and all that candy floss and fried dough was coming up, making its presence known, those intermingling flavors teasing her, so sickly sweet and good last night but now disgusting, wanting to spread out all over the floor, all over Tripp's lap. God, his handsome lap, him sitting there naked. Tall, handsome, popular, hung . . . *What the fuck was going on?*

He held out the white fluffy teddy bear with a red collar, she took it, then fell down to sit at his side. She held it against her stomach and

hunched over. The clock was ticking. She was going to throw up, she was sure of it. But perhaps she was in the storm's eye, a momentary stilling. A blessing, a way to save this embarrassing interlude. She said, "I had an awesome time last night . . ."

"Me too," he said, slapped a hand on the inside of her thigh, squeezing her above her knee.

She put both hands over his. "Sorry I'm being a jerk right now. I'm really far from home. I get homesick."

Tripp nodded. "Hometown drama."

"You ever get it?"

"Sure," he sighed, letting his head rock back to lean on the headboard. He eyed her sleepily.

"You look so good," she told him, voice timid.

He smiled, but it wasn't the response she wanted. Inexplicable flickering numbers began scrolling inside her; she snatched at them, grabbing 17's and 76's, good numbers, even 13 was a good number. She drew in a long breath, shook her head, but held those imaginary numbers against her chest for good fortune. She was fucking *fucking up* again . . .

"Yeah," she said. "I'm going to deal with something—we were going to split up after lunch, anyway . . ."

"We were," he said, and now he took her hand. She was happy for that.

Her hand went around his now, gripped his thumb. "You mad at me?"

"No," he said, cold, all that friendliness gone.

The shaking returned. Those numbers jittered and slipped away from her; her vision began to shake, and her heart began to pound. The earthquake returned, and she could hear her seams beginning to pull away, the rivets that held them tight creaking and groaning, ready to shear.

"I'll call you," she said and shot up.

"You don't have to go," he said unconvincingly.

She turned in his hallway, saw his naked knee, his nice arms and head hanging forward, contemplating this mess of a girl he'd shared his bed with—wished she'd *stayed* in bed, wished she *never* looked at her fucking phone. God damn Dad buying her the God damn phone. Her trying to get away, and him giving her this fucking anchor . . .

She yanked open Tripp's door, bolted out, slamming it behind her, but the hydraulics stopping it from banging, hissing gas instead . . .

* * *

IN HER DORM room she found Makayla working on a laptop, propped back against a pillow on her bed. She couldn't help an exasperated groan seeing her roommate.

Makayla detected it right away. "What's your problem?"

"Just never mind," she said, throwing her purse onto the bed, following it, and when she was up on both knees, pulling Tripp's bear from inside her purse because it shouldn't be on the bed with Harry Bear. She flipped Harry Bear face first on a pillow, got up, stomped to her dresser and put Tripp's hard-won bear in the top drawer and closed it. Makayla watched.

"You out with Tripp last night?"

"Yeah," she mumbled.

"He got tired a your ass?"

She tsk-ed, said, "Why would you *say* that?"

"Way you throwing things around, maybe Tripp see the light."

"No," she said.

"Matter of time," Makayla said and began clacking on keys again.

"What do you know, anyway?"

Makayla laughed to herself, said to the room, "Everybody like Tripp, but you . . . ?"

"What—nobody likes me? Could you just leave me alone today, please . . . ?"

"Go on talk to yourself like you do, don't let me stop you." She brushed the conversation away with sweeping backhand fingers.

"I don't talk to myself," she said, showing her back to Makayla whose fingers resumed their clatter on the keyboard. "I fucking hate this place," she spat, and swiped her phone out of her purse. She stuffed it in the front pocket of her jeans, stormed out of her dorm room.

Now her sneakers were clapping down the stairwell, weaving between slow moving idiots, getting her out into the bright sunshine. On the concrete walk she stopped, stooped with hands on knees and drew in three deep breaths.

Fucking Harrison. Fucking God damn Harrison. The worst thing she could picture was his familiar penis in some girl's hand. Some fucking skank touching her boyfriend. Harrison had only ever been with her for real. The two of them did everything together. The idea he would share that intimacy with someone else was like a stab in her heart. She growled again and fisted her knee. *Fucking Harrison.* She stood there with a cramping stitch in her side and put her hands on her waist, winced up at the bright sun. Some passing guys asked if she was okay.

"Fine," she growled, and they continued on.

The sadness came, rising out of her angry swamp, dripping, all that venom coursing off its body in splashes. The lumbering hulk made its way to the shore . . .

She cupped a hand over her mouth, stumbled off the concrete and onto a grassy patch, making her way to the tree line.

The ground sloped down toward a wooded shrub. It was there she sat down with her back to the dorm, staring into the dark of the trees. Could be anywhere sitting here. Could be back in Michigan. Couldn't see a single palm tree.

She moaned out loud, stuck a leg straight to pull her phone out of her too-tight jeans. She tapped out a phone call to Kay, cursing that it took three rings before she picked up.

"Tell me what happened," she said.

"Good to hear from you too," Kay said.

"Sorry, okay? What's going on?"

"I miss you."

"Look, I miss you too, but I'm freaking the fuck out right now."

"What do you want to know?"

"Tell me what happened . . . tell me what really happened, Kay."

"It's like I told you, he's working out with Brady. Can you fucking believe that? All that shit we planned, doing that foursome thing, your dumb ass boyfriend becomes friends with Brady . . ."

"That guy's such an idiot. Not Harrison, Brady."

"I kept that guy hanging on just for the foursome, you remember that?"

"I know," she whined.

"So your dumb ass boyfriend wants to lift weights, starts hanging out with Brady. Not just at the gym, now apparently they're going out to Scratchy's like fucking losers."

“Did you know he was doing that?”

“Weightlifting, yeah. I told him not to . . . I didn’t want him hanging out like that with Brady and those idiots . . . I told him when he—”

“So what happened, Kay? . . . ”

“I don’t know. He’s out with Brady and a bunch of his dumb jock friends. They go out to Scratchy’s late and run into some girls. Harrison got in a fight . . . ”

“What? . . . ”

“I know. Harrison . . . He punched some guy, and the cops came—”

“Oh my God . . . ”

“It’s okay. But he took off with this girl, they were hiding from the cops . . . ”

She groaned a sound of deep pain. “I can’t fucking believe this.”

“I know. It surprised me. You should see him, he’s got a shiner.”

“What—from the girl?”

Kay chuckled. “No, from the fight.”

“It’s not funny, Kay.”

“I’m not laughing, baby, believe me, I’m not.”

She hung her head, clutched her forehead and watched her long hair sway near the grass. “I’m so mixed up. I fucking hate it here so much, Kay . . . I got to come home . . . ”

“I got my arms open for you.”

She fell back onto the grass, phone pressed to her ear, hand raking through her hair while she looked at the sky. “I’m so far away,” she whispered.

“I’m a text and phone call away.”

“I’m sorry I don’t call.”

“You’re going to be extra sorry when you come back at Thanksgiving.”

She chuckled. “I’m not afraid of you.”

“I miss you so much, Taylor.”

“I miss you too. I miss Harrison.”

“That why you’re fucking Tripp?”

“God,” she sighed, “I’m such an idiot.”

“Hey, no, I’m kidding . . . I admire you.”

“I feel like I’m going to be sick,” she said.

“Let it out.”

“No, I’m serious,” she said, a real queasiness rolling and slithering inside her. “I hate myself, I hate California . . . I hate it, hate it, hate it . . .” She rolled to her side and closed her eyes, could feel them go slippery with the wet of tears. “So this girl . . . she used her . . . *mouth* . . .”

“That’s what Harrison says.”

“Think he’s lying?”

“Nope.”

She exhaled: “My Harrison . . .”

Kay was the one sighing now, saying, “Maybe this is my fault.”

“Why?”

“I let him get away from me even though I swore I wouldn’t.”

“I don’t blame you, I blame me.”

“I don’t know, Taylor—maybe we can make it right.”

“Who is the girl? I want to know her name, I want to look her up.”

“I don’t know her name yet. I’ll find out. He’s head over heels . . .”

“Fuck,” she cried, then continued to sob soft breathy sounds into the phone.

Kay soothed her, her best friend thousands of miles away, saying, “It’s okay, Tay-Tay, it’s okay . . .”

She mewled: “Do you think he’s going to see her again?”

Kay said, “I’ll take care of it,” and she knew her friend would.

But it was too late for her. “Oh my God,” she said, getting up on her knees, not believing this would happen. “I gotta go, Kay, I gotta go . . .”

“What?—don’t hang up on me . . .”

“Hold on,” she said, swallowing thickly. “I gotta go, I’ll, mm, call you later . . .”

Kay said, “Okay. Hey—don’t say to Harrison what he tells me or he’ll stop telling me.”

“I know, I know. I gotta go, I’ll call you . . .”

She got to her feet, scrambled into the woods as candy floss and carnival food came boiling up from her belly. She heaved it all out into the dank earth, sugary sweet squirting through her nose. She coughed and spewed and cried . . .

It was guilt that hosed from her, saturating the dry California ground. She could feel the shame in her pants. Could feel another man’s semen squishing. It was guilt over not using condoms. Some black magic working in the air, and this was her punishment; she wasn’t supposed to fuck anyone

without a condom and that juju got into reality, Harrison sniffing out that sneaky truth all the way back in Michigan. She'd convinced herself it was okay. If she had sex with another guy, she would use condoms for sure, but with Tripp it would be okay—because, come on, it was Tripp. *What did she think—she was in a relationship with Tripp?* It was all her fault. She hurled again, spice and sugar scorching her nostrils. Her actions here in SC put Harrison on a path where some bitch would ruin his life. That would be so fucking great to blame herself for that every day for the rest of her life. Now she could picture running into Harrison and the trashcan girl at the Dollar General, him in his fifteen-year-old Soob, doing his best to be the good guy, the trashcan girl trotting around their kids, probably only forty percent of them belonging to Harrison whether or not he knew it . . .

Now all she could think about was all of Tripp's cum sloshing around inside her right now and she wanted to squirt it out—like this new revelation to her enlightened the fact that Harrison knew what she was doing, knew she had another man's cum inside her right now. She cried again and put a finger in her throat, encouraging the guilt to exorcism . . .

Monday, October 2

Chapter Five

WHEN HIS MOTHER saw his packed lunch in three separate Tupperware containers accompanied by two protein bars and a gallon of water split across three different containers, she asked him how much all of it cost. It was 6:30 in the morning, and he'd thought he could get out the door before she came down for breakfast, and he'd been in the laundry room, returning to find his mother with her hands on her hips, disapproving of what she saw on the kitchen counter.

"It's just food," he said.

His mother was undeterred. Hand holding the lapel of her robe closed, she said, "How much *was* all this?"

"Money, or how much food?"

She shook her head, mouth pursed, disbelieving, one dubious eyebrow raised. "You're not going to eat all this, are you?"

"Yes, I'm going to eat all that."

Brow lowering, she said, "All today?"

"Yes, Mom," he said, "And I bought it myself."

"You're going to get fat. What's in here—chicken?"

"Some chicken breasts, Mom, it's not a big deal," he said, nosing his way in between her and the counter and putting this Tupperware into his zippered lunch tote.

"How can you afford all this, Harrison?"

"It's just food, I told you. I have to eat."

Lips pursed, she regarded the containers, doing the math in her head. "Harrison, that's gotta be twenty, twenty-five dollars worth of food—and

you're going to eat that all in one day? And you do that every day? . . . ”

“I told you, Mom, let me handle it.”

She put up her hands. “I’m not stopping you. This just seems like an *enormous* waste of time and money.”

“Mom, I’m not doing drugs,” he said, and held her gaze. His message held enormous weight, and he felt his determination waiver as his eyes locked with his mother’s. Both of them disregarded what it meant, his mother not looking away until he shied, dipped his chin and zipped up his bag.

She asked: “You’re leaving now?”

“Yes, mom,” he hissed, “I’m going to school.”

“What time’s class?—Oh, you’re going to the gym . . . ”

“Yes, Mom, I’m going to the gym.”

She followed him. “When are you going to study?”

“Mom, I *am* studying,” he said, tossing his gym bag onto the bench in the front hall.

In a softer voice, she asked him how school was going, folding her arms and leaning on the archway from the kitchen to the front hall.

He inhaled, held it, smiled. He said, “Why are you up so early?”

She looked to the chandelier light in the center of the hall, frowning, saying, “I have to show a house at nine, these people, they’ve got a lot of money, and they’re coming all the way from Detroit,” then went on the tips of her toes to wipe at a cobweb connecting stucco to chandelier. She dusted her hands, said, “I’ve got a busy day. We have a lot of houses to see.” Her tone would lead an outsider to believe that Harrison had booked the demanding appointment.

“That’s good,” he said, shoving a foot in his boot.

“What’s got into you recently?”

“What do you mean?”

She touched a finger under her eye, indicating his shiner. “And now with the lifting weights?—you’re too young to have a midlife crisis.”

“It’s not a midlife crisis, Mom.”

“Next thing I know you’ll be trading in your station wagon for a monster truck or something.”

“I’m not doing that,” he said, stomping his foot to get his boot settled. “And it’s not a station wagon.”

“Fighting and lifting weights . . . you’re supposed to be at school to learn.”

“Mom, I told you I *am* studying. I study all the time. I study *and* I lift weights.”

She was unconvinced, a dimple tucking in one cheek. “Are you trying out for sports?”

“Why would I try out for sports?”

“Then why would you lift weights?”

“You don’t understand.”

She said, “No, I don’t understand. Are you going to be like Arnold Schwarzenegger—is that what you want to do?”

“No, Mom, that’s not what I want to do. I’m not *trying* to do anything. I’m not competing, I’m not playing sports . . . There’s nothing wrong with what I’m doing.”

She shook her head, raised her brows, making him feel like he was ten again. “You don’t see it now, but I tell you what—the end of the month, twenty dollars on your food, then what I make for dinner on top and then multiply that by thirty days? . . . Twenty-five dollars a day? What’s that, Harrison? . . . \$750. You could just eat what I make you, I don’t know why you’d want to do all *this* . . .” She waved a hand at his food bag.

“It’s fine, Mom, it’s food—like I said a million times. I’m just eating *food*. It’s chicken, it’s rice, it’s broccoli, it’s water . . . I don’t know what you want from me.”

“Come here,” she said, and he stood, moved toward her. She held the lapels of his jacket, but if he thought she would embrace him, he was wrong. She zipped up his jacket. “Think sensibly. Promise me you’ll—”

“Mom, I’m fine,” he said, shrugging away, grabbing his book bag and his heavy meal bag, threw them over his shoulder and shoved his hands in his pockets.

“Promise me, promise me you’re not wasting your time at school.”

“Why would you say I’m wasting my time at school?” He closed one eye, the purple one, stress beginning to rouse a throb in its tender meat.

“You’re there lifting weights. You’re supposed to be studying . . .”

He threw up his hands, closed both eyes. “I’ll see you later,” he said and stumbled out into the dark cold.

Chapter Six

FOR HALF AN HOUR she thought Makayla was never going to fucking leave. On her phone and making plans with her friends saying I'll meet you at Palm Front for dinner in twenty, and then twenty would pass and Taylor was pretty sure she was going to explode, pick up a textbook and wing it at Makayla and scream how her fucking friends are waiting there for her. Like, how can you be so disrespectful? Your friends said they'd meet you, and they're there waiting and Makayla hasn't even left yet, on her phone with someone else and not even in a rush. But then finally she was gone, packing up her shit and leaving without saying a thing—oh, fuck you, too, Makayla—and as soon as the door was closed, Taylor was jumping on her phone . . . But then was too scared to make the call. It took another ten minutes to prepare, whispering in her empty room saying to herself how she just needed to calm down, how Makayla messed her up, and she didn't want to call when her fucking mind was racing because of her roommate.

What gave her the strength finally was the knowledge that another girl was moving on her boyfriend. Harrison was soft and kind and so vulnerable. Ashley Skank-whore would be getting rides in the Soob, and sucking Harrison's dick, and soon they would be fucking. God, even the word 'fucking' in the context of Harrison and some other girl made her nauseous. It wouldn't even surprise her to find out Michigan Garbage Ashley would tell Harrison soon about some baby she had with another guy, and sweet Harrison would help care for her kid, getting into it, finding meaning in it, chumming around with Ashley's mom or grandma who probably did most of the child-rearing while Ashley whored around. All that

Harrison goodness intertwined with the wrong fucking girl. Some girl who wouldn't love him the way she did, could *never* know him the way she did. It wasn't allowed. It just wasn't. No way, Ashley. Now she gritted her teeth, dialed.

Harrison answered on the second ring, his face looming large and eager in her screen.

"Hi, Taylor," he heaved as if from exertion—like he'd lunged for the phone.

She chuckled. It would be ten-thirty there, Harrison a good boy in bed, ready for school tomorrow; she could see his familiar bedroom in the background, not some pink-walled Ashley bedroom. "Hi, baby," she said softly, "It's not too late, is it?"

"No way," he said, tossing himself onto his bed, laying on his back.

"You're alone?"

"Huh?—yeah . . ."

"Good, good. I miss you."

He laughed, said, "I miss you, too, so much."

"So what's going on?" The light in his room was dim, but even with his face in grainy shadow she could see he had a black eye. She was reluctant to even mention it because it could get them on the path on how he'd been with another girl. And, all she'd done with Tripp, she knew he must be hurting and there could be a good chance he'd come at her hard, trying to hurt her with how some other girl had sucked his cock, maybe even saying how Ashley gave him pleasure better than she ever had. That would be insurmountable. If Harrison came at her like that she could break away—it could destroy her. She proffered timidly: "Hey, baby, what's with your eye?"

"My eye?" He put a hand over it, considering how he'd answer and she waited anxiously, worried what his intent would be. "Oh, it's nothing. I was out with some guys here, Saturday night, and we were messing around. I got hit in the eye . . ."

"Messing around?" She bit the inside of her cheek, desperate to get off this line of questioning. She could feel a squeeze in her stomach and didn't want a replay of hurling into the bushes.

"Ah, it was dumb." He rubbed his forehead, drew up the hood of his sweatshirt, hiding. "It was a fight. Just me and some other guys, guys you

don't know. It was dumb, like over in a couple minutes. No big deal, but, yeah, I got hit in the eye. I hit back pretty good though . . . ”

“Don't do that, Harrison,” she said.

“I didn't. I mean, I didn't start it . . . ”

“Is your eye okay?”

“Yeah, I'm fine. Really, it was nothing.”

“Be careful, Harrison,” she warned, happy but still discontent. He'd told a version of the truth, which she appreciated, and he'd left out mention of Ashley which was a relief—yet still made her uncomfortable. Did he leave her out because she was a developing thing? Did he have feelings for Ashley and he was lying to his girlfriend?

She changed the subject fast before she became grim, asked him how he was doing. He told her about his day, about school, about his mom and dad, didn't mention his fun sexual adventure on Saturday night. She'd be expected to retell how she and Tripp went to the Boardwalk, maybe some details about the sex they had, and she didn't get that, because if he tried to tell her right now about how he got a blowjob outside Scratchy's she would break down and cry, probably yell at him, hang up . . . so she would trust Kay in this, play it cool like she knew nothing and hope to hell Harrison didn't offer it up because she didn't trust her emotions to support her in responding calmly or appropriately. Even looking at his face now on her phone's screen held above her while she lay on her dorm room bed, made her think of being with him, of all the tender loving times they'd shared, how familiar and caring it was to be with him; in his bed, both of them not knowing much about sex, but figuring it out together, friends, awkward but supportive, Harrison over her like he was now, kissing her, making her feel so cared for.

“Can I tell you something?” She said it soft and caring, averting her eyes, letting him know this was going to be important.

“What . . . ?”

“It's harder and harder to be apart from you.”

“I'm right here,” he said, “any time you want to call, anytime you want to text. You just have to reach out to me, baby, I'm here for you. Anything at all . . . ”

“I know . . . ”

“But you don't.”

“I just get so busy sometimes . . . Don't you get busy?”

“Never too busy for you.”

She lay a hand over her forehead. “I walked into that one.”

“It wasn’t a trap, Taylor.”

“No, I know.”

Harrison looked away, then returned his gaze to his phone, said, “You’re all I think about.”

“I think about you, too, you know.”

“Do you?”

“Of course.” *How could he believe she didn’t think of him?*

He read her mind. “It’s hard being so far from you, hard to know what you’re thinking at all. I fucking *fantasize* you’re thinking of me, but you know how I am . . . deep down it’s so easy to convince myself I’m nothing to you.”

She blinked away the threat of tears. “How could you even say that, Harrison?”

“Don’t be mad at me.”

“I’m not mad . . . I’m—I don’t know—stunned.”

He said, “Can’t you just call me?”

“I called you today.” She gave him a placating smile, an honest one that instantly felt disingenuous despite its truth. It faded. “I mean it, Harrison, I think of you every day.” Honesty here would be so beautiful—she would tell him how much it hurt her to find out he’d been with another girl, but then the obvious path of that conversation would lead into the Garden Of What She Was Doing In Santa Cruz, and the demand she stop, that she give up Tripp. Where would that go? It would lead to them breaking up. And she didn’t want that—and yet, how did she believe she deserved Harrison *and* anything else she wanted? What made her think that was okay? But as Kay would say What would make you think you *don’t* deserve everything? Everything was so much easier when she’d decided to break up with him, but when her horse was lead to water it just couldn’t take that drink. It hurt deep and endless to think of breaking up with him. She could never be without him. So the only thing that made this possible was the absurd discovery Harrison had a certain secret part of him that loved her so much he was okay with this as long as she let him know some details. And she couldn’t even do that right . . .? She was a perfect fuck-up. The one thing that would save the most valuable thing in her life and she couldn’t even do that right. She rubbed her neck, felt her temples throb.

“It means a lot that you called,” he said, lowering his eyes.

“Why would you think you’re nothing to me?”

He looked aside. “You’re moving on. You’re afraid to break up with me, so you’re letting time apart do all the heavy lifting. You’re—”

“That’s not it at all, Harrison . . . ”

“Tell me it’s not true then.” He got strong, leveled his eyes at her. The one guy who she could trust and who ever meant a thing to her.

So she had to fake lay it on, spread it nice and thick and try to massage Harrison’s feelings. It felt good to coo and give him what he wanted, but at the same time: manipulative. A necessary evil. “It has nothing to do with you, Harrison, it’s just something I *need* to do. That *is* the truth. The hardest part is *being* away from you. I miss you so much.”

“I miss you, too.” He was quiet and morose, face down-turned. And his penis had been in some other girl’s mouth.

“Harrison, baby, this is so hard for me, too. I miss you all the time, I think about you all the time. I don’t know why I don’t call, but it has nothing to do with you. I swear I’ll try harder. It’s not like I’m out having fun and that’s not why I’m calling you, or—”

“You’re going out with Tripp . . . ”

“I’m not *seeing* him.”

“You go out with him.”

“I only care about you.”

That got him; his whole demeanor changed, and as he relaxed, she relaxed with him. His head cocked to the other side, but while he still wouldn’t look in the camera, she could see the tightness of his expression slacken. He drew in a long breath through his nostrils, his chest rising, his brow rising. He said, “You don’t care about him?”

She shook her head no, but he wasn’t looking. She whispered, “No.”

Now his eyes met hers again. “You really don’t?”

“I only care about you, Harrison,” she said, and believed it herself, even feeling her eyes begin to swell. She blinked away tears but let him see the effect her words had. He instantly went shiny-eyed too, and that got her more. “I love you so much, Harrison,” she squeaked.

“I love you too,” he said.

“I want to be home, I want to be with you . . . ”

“I miss you, Taylor, I didn’t think this could be so hard . . . ”

She chuckled as a weird relief washed through her. She meant the words she said. It wasn't a lie, it wasn't subterfuge. She missed Harrison so, so bad. Her words could be duplicitous; knowing her boyfriend had messed around with another girl and trying to say all the right things to remind him to keep their bonds strong, but what she said was at its heart true. "I know it's hard, Harrison," she said. "Can you hang in there for me?"

He laughed, rolled his leaking eyes, sniffled. "You know I can."

"Promise me?"

He met her gaze.

She said, "I'll be home soon. Thanksgiving is around the corner, it really is. Will you keep thinking of me?"

"Taylor, please, you know you're *all* I think of."

"Are you sure?"

He frowned, puzzled. "Am I sure?—of course I'm sure."

"You still want me? Even after all that's . . ."

"Taylor," he said, sensing her pull and pushing forward, being strong, "I will *always* love you. I am *always* here for you."

Nineteen

OCTOBER 13-14

Saturday, October 13

Chapter One

ONE SCHOOL DAY in the first week of October every year in grades five, six, seven, and eight, was spent at the Native Creek Nature Center out in the west end of Lansing by the Grand River. The Nature Center had what was Harrison and Kay's favorite field-trip feature: a pioneer village where the men walked around in black wool clothes and the women wore bonnets; there was a blacksmith, a mill, an inn, barns, carriage rides, an old printing office . . . Taylor always complained about the smell of horses, and tried to get them to kvetch like she did, but they weren't buying it. It had to be six years since he was last here (and he figured the same for Kay), and since he was Soobing out to Lansing from Saginaw on a Saturday, it was the best thing he could come up with for Kelsey's birthday.

The stress was huge; in fact his insides had tightened right up on the drive over, his heart rate was quick and light. But right now he and Kay were out front of the farrier's barn, elbows on the wooden barrier meant to stop all the little kids from running right in there and getting hoofed in the face by a big old Clydesdale—and Kay (thank baby Jesus) was smiling.

They each had bright red candy apples on sticks—just like they'd get when they were ten—Kay working hers over and over, peeling off the sticky candy shell with her teeth like a wolf tearing meat. It was mid-afternoon, unseasonably warm, sunny, the village paths littered with yellow leaves. Kay wore her leather jacket, pink hair pulled from her soft pretty face in a tail, showing off an ear over-burdened with silver studs and rings. The farrier was a scrawny guy in his fifties, hunched like a real old-timer (though he must have a regular modern-day job or something, they figured),

and he worked a horse's hooves, removing worn-out shoes and putting on new ones, using homemade tools and nails he kept in a beaten apron.

"First of November," she was saying while her lips tried to wrestle with a wide triangular husk of sticky red candy shell.

He asked where.

"A thousand square feet out in The Stadium District."

"Really?"

"What? . . ." She scowled a side-eye.

"What nothing," he said, "that's cool." Though he had trouble picturing bitchy-cool Kay living near the stadium and picnicking outside Lugnuts games.

She nodded, took a bite of apple, then said around it: "My offer still stands."

"Not likely, Kay," he said, "I can barely afford these candy apples . . ."

And it was true. There was a fund squirreled away in his room destined for a rainy day—and he knew what that rainy day might be—but taking out Kay on her birthday was a necessary outlay, one he *wanted* to expend. Only money *was* tight; frugality made his heart feel better . . .

"Thanks for taking me out on my birthday," she said. "You're not doing too bad."

"Thanks. You know how much I stressed?"

"Good," she said, eyes narrowed on her dwindling candy apple, smiling smugly. "Where else are you taking me?"

He chuckled, shook his head, staring at her oblivious profile. "You know how difficult you are?"

She leaned her side on the worn down wood cross beam separating them from the farrier, eyes raised as if she were considering. "Pretty difficult." Then she laughed, lowered her candy apple toward his face in an *en garde* position, tried to put a remaining curve of sticky shell against the tip of his nose. He recoiled; she persisted, chasing him around, him staying in the same spot but bobbing and weaving. He hunched over when he realized she would persist until she was successful. He submitted to her, bent over, looking at the gathered shoes of their audience—one meant for the farrier, but now surely watching their performance. Kay got over his back, lifting her feet off the ground, all her weight on him, peeping over his shoulder looking to make sticky-apple contact with nose-tip. She did, making the appropriate *boop* sound effect. Satisfied, she jumped off his

back. He stood wiping his nose, turning his face from a woman and her four pre-teen charges.

He laughed, turned to Kay. "What time is it?"

"Why?" She made a funny face. She knew why.

He checked his phone. "It's 2:30."

Kay disregarded him, said, "Think you're strong, showing off holding me up on your back?"

He put his phone in his hoody pocket but still held it. "You're not heavy."

"Good answer," she said, and lightly kicked his shin, then stared at him, not saying anything.

He waited for her to ask, when she didn't, he said, "I know what you're thinking."

"What am I thinking?"

He said, "I'm just going to the gym at school."

She closed her eyes, said, "Don't let *me* stop you."

"No, I ran out of free passes with Brady and his friends. He wants me to join . . . It's a lot of money . . ."

"Join if you want."

"I do want to. But I *really* can't afford it. Plus, there's the *free* gym at school . . . the most expensive is the food I gotta eat."

"Weight-Gain-Mega-Mass-Ass-Blaster?"

"No. Chicken and rice and broccoli."

They were quiet a moment, him looking away knowing she was watching him. The young girls with the mom sidled alongside them, getting up on their toes so they could rest their forearms on the cross brace and watch the farrier with the horse.

Kay said, "You see him there? At the gym at school . . ."

Colt. One time he told Kay about that, but she was sharp like a hawk, knowing why he was really reluctant to attend the school's gym. "I think he's just there in the afternoons. If I go in the morning, I'm okay."

"He's not going to beat you up or anything—this isn't high school."

"I just don't want to see him."

"Make a muscle," she said now brighter, changing the subject, and he caught a flicker of her pink pony tail wagging.

He looked at her sideways. "Don't be stupid."

“Make a muscle for me,” she said again, and now he felt embarrassed because all the girls could overhear.

“Don’t embarrass me,” he said, raking a hand through his hair (but absolutely beginning to flex his bicep). He’d been hitting the gym faithfully. Three times a week and on a good program, lots of water, lots of food—lots and lots of food—plenty of sleep . . . and all balanced with his school workload. There were times he wanted to give up or at least skip, but he would just think of the way Taylor reacted when she saw Colt with his shirt off on the beach up at Wolf lake; that jacked guy, Stevie, the one she messed around with; the way she was always making comments about Brady’s body when Kay was dating him; what she looked like having sex with Brady, and how she jerked the guy off onto his stomach muscles. When he looked in the mirror though, despite the effort, he saw no difference.

Kay moved forward, and he let her squeeze his arm. He’d brought a jacket but left it in the Soob, walking around the sunny paths of the old Pioneer Village in just jeans and a sweatshirt. He made a muscle while Kay squeezed him. She felt all around, taking her time, digging her fingertips into his shoulders. “Not much different,” she said.

He slumped, deflated. “Such a bitch,” he said, but laughed off the sting. He would’ve killed for her to say she’d felt something.

She batted his ribs with her cupped palm. “Keep at it. Maybe you feel a little harder . . . How does it *feel*?”

“Gives me something to do.”

“Keeps you off the streets,” she said.

“It does,” he muttered, then: “It’ll be 11:30 there.”

She laughed, sun glinting off a silver ring in the top of her ear. “One track mind,” she said.

“Give me a break,” he said. “It’s your birthday . . .”

“She’ll call *me* on my birthday.”

“Is she responding to your emails?”

“She gets back to me these days. I mean, at least better . . . How about you?”

“Yeah. I talked to her twice last week, and she’ll text back.” What he really wanted to say was What’s the situation with Tripp? These last two weeks he was just happy to hear from her and didn’t want to bring the guy

up. Truth was, though, he *did* want to know. What was the situation there in Santa Cruz? How *is* Mr. Popular? How *is* Mr. Porsche?"

"11:30 in Santa Cruz you say . . . " She brought her phone out of the leather jacket's pocket.

"Yeah, she'll be awake."

Kay raised her eyebrows in a vacillating manner, rousing her phone. It occurred to him: maybe Taylor *wasn't* awake. Friday nights in Santa Cruz—what was that like? What was Taylor doing on a Friday night? She said she'd been to the boardwalk amusement park a couple times. Was she out in the vampire house, out in the woods with Tripp? Or maybe some other guy .

..

Kelsey dialed, held the screen up but watched him. "Probably be awake."

11:30 in the morning, he would hope she would be up. Kay had them on a No Partying contract—or at least no drinking. But what if Taylor was still asleep because she'd been up all night humping Tripp's fat dick?

The microphone in Kay's phone rang with Taylor's singing voice: "Happy birth-day to *you* . . . "

Kay laughed, moved her face away from the phone, held it up and wagged it at him. Taylor was now singing the full version . . . *Happy birthday, dear Kelsey, happy birthday to* . . . Sunlight glinted off the screen so he couldn't see her face.

"Hold on," Kay said over top of Taylor's singing, and nodded her chin for Harrison to join her. They stood with their back to the farrier, leaning against the cross brace, both of them huddled around the phone. Taylor's face was on the screen. Singing over, Taylor said to Kay, "Happy birthday, KK. I can't *believe* you're nineteen."

"I don't feel a day over twelve," Kay said.

Harrison interrupted: "Hi-ii, Taylor . . . " And the sound of his own voice seemed strange and interjecting—a guy amidst girls's small talk.

But Taylor was happy to see him. "Hi-ii, Harrison," she sang, "Harrison, look at you . . . Aww, you guys are *killing* me—I wish I was home so, so bad."

"We wish you were home, too," he said, a million more important things racing through his mind, but with Kelsey beside him, and this woman and her kids, and now three more people coming up, he was trying to keep things under control.

Kay said, "Where are you?"

Taylor looked around, said, "I'm at school." Wherever she was, she sat outside, her perfect face lit by bright California sun, her long chestnut hair gleaming.

"At the dorm?"

"God, no," Taylor said.

Kay said low: "How's your roommate?"

Taylor made a face, shook it off, said, "Where are you guys?"

"Harrison's taking me out for my birthday."

Taylor made a pained expression that Harrison lamented he *enjoyed* watching. *Yeah, suck it—suck it all the way in California . . . we're all having fun here without you . . .*

Taylor said, "Seriously, it's *killing* me . . ."

"We'll see you at Thanksgiving," Kay said, "right?"

"I'm coming home at Thanksgiving, I *am* . . ." And it was the first time he feared there was a chance she may *not* come home on the holiday. She would *have* to come home . . . his brow furrowed and an anxious worry whorled just above his bladder.

Kay said, "Harrison took me to Native Creek—we're at the Pioneer Festival."

Harrison said, "American Heritage Festival . . ."

Taylor rolled her eyes, said, "I'm suddenly *less* jealous."

"They got rid of the horse smell, baby," Kay said and laughed. "You're totally missing it, sunny day here, but you don't get fall in California, you loser, we're going to go pick mother-fucking *apples* later."

Harrison winced, looked to see if the kids overheard the pink-haired girl's bad language. The mother did.

"I miss you all," Taylor lamented.

"Carving pumpkins, baking pies, jumping in leaf piles . . . the whole thing," Kay continued.

"I miss you guys," Taylor said in a soft voice, and he could see a glint of wet in her eyes that roused him.

"Soon, baby, soon," Kay said.

But *soon* couldn't come soon enough. His heart ached so hard. Standing here watching her so far away, his Taylor hurting in their absence from her life—knowing how bad *her* absence hurt *him* . . .

Taylor said, "What else are you guys doing?"

Kay said, "This is it. Mr. Cheapo here doesn't have any money."

"I have money," he said.

"You guy's going out for dinner?"

Kay nodded, gave him a sidelong glance and elbowed him. "I'm taking *him* out for my birthday. My treat."

"I have plans," he said, facing Kay and smiling, holding eye contact and a bad part of him hoping Taylor was watching and hurting even more now, seeing everyone doing just fine without her.

There was a long hairy hiss behind them—a soft but low vibrato undulating under and over it.

Kay whipped around, excited. "Tay, Tay, Tay," she hissed urgently.

Taylor was saying What? as Kay poked her elbows on the cross brace, and Harrison rolled around to see what was so important. The farrier'd stepped back from the freshly shod horse, its stringy black tail swished to the side and curled over a big strong chestnut haunch. A gibbering, chuffing sound of flatulence ceased now as a steady plopping cascade of grassy manure billowed forth in clumps and fell to the straw floor of the farrier's barn. Kay laughed so hard she had trouble squeezing her fingers on the screen to zoom in on the horse's pooping, saying, "That's all for you Tay-Tay, that's all for you . . ." while his girlfriend made wild sounds of hilarious disgust so fucking far away from him.

* * *

THE PHONE in her hand was glossy, but dead and black. Her own dim reflection stared back at her, eyes unreadable, the connection with her friends back home severed. The distance between them was enormous. Practically a tangible thing and sometimes made worse and more gargantuan with these glimpses of what life was like without her. She plucked the earbuds out from under her hair, wound them around a finger and shoved them back in her purse. She missed those two people so much. And seeing them together, Kay and Harrison, did something else . . . Something twisted and unpleasant. It felt terrible to have people you loved moving on without you. *But wasn't that what she was doing to them?* Coming out here to be separate. Coming out here to be someone else. She left them behind, how did she think it felt to be them, looking at her so far

away and wondering what the hell was wrong with her? And what the hell *was* wrong with her?

Big sneakers tapped her smaller sneakers. She sniffed, tilted her chin up to look at Tripp who sat with his back against a tree reading Moby Dick. He said, "Home sick again?"

She nodded, tried not to look too gloomy.

He said, "When it's my birthday will you sing to me too?"

She nodded more happily, said, "When's your birthday?"

"January."

"It's a deal," she told him.

She said, "Do I need to work on my singing voice before then?"

He winced, turned up his nose and smiled.

"Is that a yes?"

He shook his head no, still making a funny face.

"You can be honest. Your dad's in the business. You think I could get a recording contract?"

He said, "Do you have any original songs?" his voice amused and thin and too high.

"No," she said pretending to be serious, "does that matter?"

"It's a . . . *nice* voice," he said.

She narrowed her eyes on his. "How about a backup singer?"

He waffled, playing along, smirking. "You could sing . . . at birthday parties, maybe . . ."

She tapped the soles of her sneakers against his, said, "I'll take it."

Tripp set his book down in the grass, got on hands and knees and crawled toward her. He kissed her lips, and she tilted her chin up to receive. He touched her neck in that way that gave her goosebumps. He whispered, "Can I take you out on Saturday?"

She licked her lips, watched him as he sat back across from her. She nodded.

"That's good," he said, pleased with himself and returning Moby Dick before his eyes, licking his finger and turning a page.

She smirked, picked up her own book too, a warm *amber* feeling soothing across her shoulders now. Her phone dinged again, and she expected a surreptitious message from Kay. Some sort of update, or an explanation . . . But what was there to explain? Was there anything wrong with Harrison and Kay going out to celebrate Kay's birthday? It felt weird.

But the text didn't come from Kelsey.

Colt: what's up surfer girl 🏄

She laughed to herself, Tripp's eyes turning up to watch her for a second; she ran hair behind her ear, texted in return.

Taylor: what's up

Colt: you shooting the curl yet

Taylor: no idea what that means 🤔

He explained it was surfing inside a wave and she said that was cool. He asked her how SC was, she said hot.

Taylor: how's cold Michigan?

Colt: colder without you here

She texted a vomiting emoji and then a bunch of laughing ones. Colt sent her a gif of a guy with a leather jacket giving two thumbs up and winking, then a handful of laugh emojis.

Taylor: thought you were supposed to have game

Colt: I'll work on it

Her eyes flicked up to see Tripp with his face still down-turned to Moby Dick, sunlight over his shoulder whitening his already spotlessly white hoody; sun shone curls in his golden hair. She laughed, re-read the exchange with Colt Briggs, the hottest piece of ass a girl could imagine, all the way back in Michigan and thinking of her. Colt was her first official off-the-books fuck, and he had *wrecked* her. Sure it was the badness, the

wrongness—Harrison in the house, still in a relationship with her, and of course, her large brother (a teammate of Colt's) also lurking, a threatening presence that would have exploded in violence if he'd discovered Colt had fucked his little sister in the family lake house, right under all their noses. Colt was bad news, and there was something so *electric* about that. He fucked her anyway, even though he knew she had a boyfriend, even though his teammate would want to punch his head in. And, God, that body. And, extra-OMG, that crazy dick of his . . .

Colt: how's school?

She sat cross-legged, hunched over her phone and texted with both thumbs now, telling Colt how it was going and he asked her if she was still seeing that guy from high school, not even remembering Harrison's name.

Taylor: kind of

Colt: kind of no

Taylor: we're fine

When she looked up this time, Tripp was watching her. She smiled, nodding her chin toward her phone, saying, "Friend from high school." He returned to his book.

Taylor: how's my brother?

Colt: KC's cool we're both pretty jacked up about the season

Taylor: I know I follow along

Colt: my friends aren't in SC right now but they'll be back in like a week or two they like the winter waves and tourists gone

Taylor: cool

Colt: so you want to learn how to surf?

She smiled again, took her pen and poked it in one side of her mouth and chewed. She texted.

Taylor: yeah I do

And just like that, things seemed like they were looking up despite being so far from home.

Chapter Two

THE SLEAZE CINEMA Society was hosting movie marathons every Saturday night in the month of October, admission at \$7 per person—talk about perfect. Soob parked at the public lot on Capitol for another seven bucks, they walked to an old bowling alley on West Kalamazoo. It was a hipster venue with two bowling lanes, a separate brew pub, and two comedy rooms, a big one and a small one. The small one was rented to the film club to show their movies projected with real film onto a white sheet spread across the brick wall behind the comedy stage.

The crowd was mostly weirdos, and Kay—though not a weirdo—fit right in, and got a lot of attention from the Goth boys who he knew would regret talking her up if they ever got the nerve. It gave him a strange comforting pride to be with Kay in a spot like this. There was something about her that bolstered his confidence, made him feel secure. They weren't a couple (though they'd banged in a hard-to-believe-it-ever-even-happened event that seemed a goddam lifetime ago even though it was only a month and a half past); they were just longtime friends, and there was comfort and acceptance that came with that, a relaxing of the social protocols; and the pressure of the evening had been released after his win at selecting the nostalgic destination of the American Heritage Festival. Kay at his side felt really good in a way he figured a girl must feel when she was with a big strong man who could defend himself. If someone were to start shit right now, he'd step back and let Kay handle it.

The tables had been removed from the room and the not-that-comfortable seating had been arranged in rows like a theater. Popcorn was

served and fountain pops. The room wasn't licensed because the film club came out of the university and no establishment wanted that insurance headache, but he and Kay clearly saw flasks being passed around in the dark. They hardly touched their popcorn because they just had dinner—him refusing to let her treat and instead they went to the Applebee's on Cedar and he even got her a cake (just a plain cake, no candles, because if the wait staff arrived at the table singing Happy Birthday he was sure to be punched in the arm again).

First up was a creepy astronaut-returns-home movie. Irradiated and mutated, the astronaut goes on a murder spree once he escapes from a NASA hospital. Kinda hokey, but the effects were pretty gruesome. The guy's face was melting, eyeball falling out and everything until he's just a bunch of goo in a humanoid shape. The double bill was finished with a movie only a decade or so older but light years beyond. Also a space horror kind of thing, these Norwegian scientists in the arctic discover a UFO in the ice and defrost this life-form they find. It comes alive, murders everyone, goes to a nearby American camp and fucks things up in graphic ways he had never seen before—or at least so he thought. Part way through he realized he'd seen a remake of this movie a couple years back, him and Taylor in the Brooks basement staying up late. Then he spent the rest of the movie trying to remember if they were boyfriend/girlfriend back then or just friends . . .

* * *

SIDE-BY-SIDE, heading out into the brisk cold of the October night, he held open the bowling alley's door for Kay. She put out a flat palm held low and horizontal; he gave her a gentle five. "Good work, my man," she said, and headed outside, turning up the collar of her leather jacket.

He zipped his own jacket, drew up his hood and joined her under a streetlight where she waited for him. "Thanks for . . . holding the door?"

"Thanks for my birthday night. You did good."

He shrugged, said, "Next weekend the film festival was some of those kung fu movies, but horror ones with demons and stuff—you know the ones where they're all dubbed over."

"I don't like kung fu movies."

“You used to—I *thought* you did . . . ”

“Maybe I did. I don’t remember. I probably just said I did. Seriously, Harrison, thanks for taking me out on my birthday. Everyone I like’s at other schools . . . ”

“I guess I’ll do in a pinch.”

She frowned, her mouth tucked to one side. “No, I mean it. Thanks—I really do appreciate it, it was a pretty damn good birthday.”

He smiled, a certain mild satisfaction easing him. He sighed, looked back at the club, the other attendees streaming out, blabbering about the sleazy nonsense they’d just watched. He said, “I should probably get you back to the dorm.”

Hands in her pockets, she said, “You going to drive home?”

He took out his phone, saw that it was just after 11:00. “Yeah, no big deal.”

“You can stay at my dorm.”

“No, I should head.”

“It’s only eleven o’clock. Let’s go do something fun.” When he shrugged, she rolled her eyes. “What’s the matter now?”

He shook his head, said, “I don’t know,” jabbed a thumb over his shoulder to the movie theater. “Those movies bummed me out.”

“How’d they bum you out? They were so goofy.”

“I know. They made me miss Taylor. She should be here.”

Kay’s head fell heavily to one side, eyes still on him. “I know, but she’s not.”

“She would’ve loved those movies.”

“She might have,” she said.

“No, she totally would have. You know how many horror movies we’ve watched together?”

“Those weren’t horror movies,” she said, wafting a hand toward the theater. “Sci-fi or something . . . ”

“But you know what I mean.” It hadn’t occurred to him how much movies like that would make him miss Taylor. A malaise had settled inside him since they’d filed out of the darkened club and into the lobby. It stuck with him even in the chilly outside.

Kay stared at him, perplexed. “Now I’m definitely not letting you go home.”

“Why not?”

“I don’t want you being all sad like this.”

“I’m not *sad*.”

“Well, *whatever* you are. Let me cheer you up.”

“Cheer me up how?”

She showed a strange malicious smile. She sang, “Who wants a sun-dae?” and tweaked his nose like he was a little kid. He jumped back, shook his head, nose still tickling; he grabbed it and pinched it. At least she had him laughing. “Who wants a sun-dae?” she sang again and poked him in the stomach.

“You know I can’t eat that.”

Still singing: “You can have a chic-ken and bro-cco-li sun-dae . . . ” Her finger wound around in circles like she was going to poke him again.

“I can’t, Kay . . . ”

She scowled. “That’s kinda lame,” she said, shoved her hands back in her pockets.

“I know. That’s the way it is.”

“All right,” she said, “you can drive me back.”

They strolled their way to the parking lot on Capitol, not saying anything. In the car he turned the heat on full blast and amped up the fans, rubbing his hands together and holding them up to the vent.

Kay buckled her seatbelt, leather jacket squeaking and groaning; she flicked her ponytail so it hung over the shoulder strap. She said, “You should really think about it, getting out of your house.”

“Get an apartment with you? You really don’t want me as a roommate, Kay—and, besides, I already told you, I can’t afford it.”

“You don’t have to split rent. I’ll rent you a room.”

He chuckled, eyed her. “You’d just rent me a room?”

“Rent a room from me. But you have to do the cleaning. Like the dishes and the bathroom. And my laundry, too.”

“Kay, come on . . . ”

“Sell the Soob. Get out of the house. It’ll be good for you.”

“The Soob . . . You know how many memories Taylor and I have in this car?”

“Don’t hold on to shit, Harrison. That’s weird. You had the car like two years, how many memories are in here?”

He caressed the steering wheel. “A lot.”

Kay laughed quietly, her body shaking, leather squeaking.

He put the Soob in gear, wound his way out of the parking lot and headed across the other side of Lansing toward the campus.

Kay said, “Stay up with me and talk.”

“Where?”

“Come hang out at the Res with me.”

“You have roommates, they won’t want me there.”

“They won’t say a thing.”

“I’d have to tell my mom.”

“Do it. What were you going to do, drive all the way home to Sag?—it’s like almost midnight.”

He rubbed his forehead. “Let me text my mom . . . ”

Sunday, October 14

Chapter Three

ON THE THIRD floor of the McGuire building, in the corner down the end of the hall from where Kay's dorm room was, they hung out in a small rec room with a coffee table, four leather chairs, and an old 27-inch LED screen TV. They were the only ones present, though there were plenty of people in the halls. They watched Saturday Night Live; when it was done, Kay said she was tired.

"Yeah, me too. It's like one in the morning."

"I'm going to crash," she said as she got up and stretched. Since they'd returned to her dorm, Kay'd changed and left her jacket in her dorm room. Now she wore the same jeans with a black sweatshirt that rode up as she pushed her arms over her head and arched her back, revealing a sliver of her bare stomach that Harrison looked at then felt guilty about and darted his eyes away. Kay yawned, grabbed her sweatshirt and pulled it down, shoved her hands in its pouch. "You coming?"

"I was going to just crash here, there's a couch at the other end where I can stretch out." He pointed down the hall.

"Just come to my bed."

"You have roommates."

"Fuck 'em."

"Your roommates are girls and probably don't want some dude coming into their bedroom at one o'clock in the morning."

"They'll be asleep or writing letters to imaginary boyfriends—or who the fuck cares?"

"I should probably just sleep in the hall, Kay."

“It’s up to you. I got the top bunk, we can go up there, talk, watch some dumb kung fu movie on your iPad or whatever.”

He muttered, “I swore you liked kung fu movies.”

“You know what it was?—Jackie Chan.”

He laughed, said, “Yes—that’s what it was.”

“Yep—that’s not really kung fu movies.”

“Doesn’t he do kung fu?”

“I don’t know. I like how he runs away from people and jumps on stuff.”

“Oh . . . ”

“They’re not going to care, Harrison—one of them had a boyfriend sleep over already.”

“Are you sure?”

“I swear they’re not going to care. What’s it matter?—I’m moving out of there in like two weeks.”

“Yeah, okay,” he said, the idea of getting into bed with Kelsey Kay a lot more appealing than falling asleep on the questionable-hygiene couch shared by about a thousand students, probably waking up with a penis drawn on his forehead or something, some dumb ass dudes coming in drunk from a party.

Kay strolled casually, and he followed. He expected her to slip into the room quietly, but she didn’t. Kay opened the door, flipped on the light. One girl moaned; two of them stayed asleep, heads down, but the third one squinted and looked up, hair tangled and bed-heavy, trying to see who’d come in the room and did the jerkiest thing possible, turning on the light. He forgot the girl’s name, but she was here the day Kay introduced him as her boyfriend, then said she was kidding, Harrison was her best friend’s boyfriend. What were they going to think now, him getting into bed with Kay?

She pointed to the top bunk, said, “Up there.”

“I know,” he said, “you don’t have to turn on the light,” and turned it off for her.

He whispered *Sorry* into the darkness for anyone who might hear it, felt around for the ladder at the foot of Kelsey’s bunk bed. He hoisted himself up, climbed onto her double size mattress, and lay against the wall waiting for Kay. He heard her unzipping her jeans, and a strange carnal knot formed in his stomach. A weird and uncomfortable feeling that he liked despite its

greasiness. It suddenly excited him that he was going to be sleeping next to a girl even though nothing was going to happen, and she was just his friend. He began enjoying the anticipation her bare legs would be touching his, unzipped his pants and pushed them down. It was likely she would scold him for this, make fun of him, but it wasn't unreasonable to sleep in a T-shirt and underwear so he kicked off his jeans and threw them down against the footboard.

Kay climbed up, and he slipped under her sheets. As she joined him, he whispered, "I took my pants off, is that okay?"

"What were you going to do, sleep in your jeans?"

"I dunno, I just didn't want you to get mad at me."

"I'd be mad if your jeans were scratching my legs or something."

"Okay," he said, "just don't take advantage of me," joking.

Kay laughed. Then they were quiet, both of them laying on their backs and looking up at the ceiling. She said, "Put on a movie, if you want. Want me to grab my iPad?"

"My phone's here," he said.

"You want to watch a kung fu movie?"

"No, I just want to sleep, but my eyes won't close."

"Mine either."

After a long while the silence got weird knowing she was laying awake too, and he sighed, "Shit."

"What?"

"I just can't shake that feeling."

"What feeling?"

"Missing Taylor. Watching those movies . . ."

"Yeah, I know, I miss her too."

"You don't miss her like I miss her."

"You don't know that."

"No, you know what I mean. I miss her in a way a guy misses a girl, no offense . . ."

"It's been six weeks."

"It's the longest six weeks of my life. And she's . . . you know . . . fucking . . ." He let it go unfinished.

"Tripp's not her boyfriend."

"He's practically her boyfriend."

"So what?"

“I don’t know, I guess when she went to California, I was just kind of figuring she was going to mess around. Have fun, you know . . .?”

“Like with different guys.”

He clucked his tongue. “Don’t say that.”

“But that’s what you meant.”

“Yeah, that’s what I meant.”

“And you’d prefer that,” she said, turning onto her side and slipping her hands under her cheek. He glanced over, saw her watching him, an orb of moonlight glimmering on her open eye.

“I don’t want her to have feelings for someone.”

“Just empty sex,” she said softly.

“Totally empty sex. Totally.”

“You can handle that?”

“Like, what if she falls in love with this guy?” he said and could hear the sadness creeping into his voice and tightening it.

“It could happen,” Kay said.

“Thanks,” he said, put his hands up under his head.

“Your underarm stinks,” she said.

He laughed, put down one arm, said, “Thanks a lot, Kay, I really mean it, you’re the best. Thought you were going to cheer me up?”

“Turns out it’s impossible.”

“It’s not impossible . . . I just can’t wait for Thanksgiving.”

“You have to hang in there, Harrison, you’re doing really good.”

“I think about her like a hundred times a day. She thinks of me once every three days.”

“You don’t know that.”

“That’s what she makes me think.”

“I don’t think that’s true.”

“She’s not thinking about me because she’s got someone else. She’s got all those feelings . . . those great feelings for some other guy.”

“You think they’re dating?”

“What did she tell you?”

She poked his shoulder with a fingernail and he looked over. She said, “I was only joking about your underarm.”

He eyed her, his vision getting adjusted to the dim and registering her features. He lifted his arm again, put both hands under his head. “Like, this guy, he’s rich, he has a fucking Porsche on campus. On campus this guy’s

driving around in a Porsche, and she's telling me how popular he is, telling me, like, dirty details . . ."

"I know."

"Did she tell you, too?"

"Yeah. She also told me *you* told her to tell you those dirty details."

He made a low groaning sound.

"Did you?"

"I guess."

"Then don't be mad at her for telling you."

"I don't know. It would kill me to *not* know, but then she tells me things that I can't stop thinking about."

"Like what?"

He made that low groaning sound again. "Like, about the guy's dick."

Kay said, "I know, she goes on about it."

His stomach cramped, hard and sudden, and he winced in the dark.

"Jesus, Kay, does she really tell you all that?"

"She does."

"What—she told you about it?—what did she tell you?"

"Probably the same things she told you."

"What does she tell you?"

"I don't know, Harrison, talk to Taylor."

He thumped his head back into the pillow a few times like he was trying to get comfortable but hoping a little he'd knock himself unconscious. They stared at the ceiling together for a few more breaths. "You know she told me she thought mine was bigger. Did she tell you that?"

"No."

"She didn't?"

Kay shook her head. "She said you were bigger?"

He corrected himself. "Longer."

"She told me Tripp's really thick."

He whined, "She actually told you that?"

"Sorry, yes."

"You said she goes on about it . . ."

"She likes it," Kay said shrugging one shoulder.

"Ah, fuck, Kay—I should have just gone home . . . God dammit," he said, beginning to twist in the bedding.

"Relax, relax," she said.

“I’m never going to get to sleep now, it’s all I’ll be able to think about.”

“What does it matter?”

“I just told you the things that bug me but I can’t stop thinking about, and then you make it worse . . . ”

“It’s not worse, Harrison—you watched her with Colt. She said his dick’s not as big as Colt’s.”

“You guys are really talking about dicks?” His hissing voice rose above a whisper and a girl in the room made a sleepy moan.

“Jesus, Harrison,” Kay sighed, rolled to her back, put a hand over her forehead. He stared at her, felt stupid now. “We talk about dicks,” she whispered, “we’re not obsessed with them, like you are . . . ”

“My fucking stomach hurts so bad right now,” he said.

“Sorry,” Kay said, her own voice thick and sad.

“It’s not your fault,” he said.

He lay there listening to his heart beat hard and heavy in his chest. Couldn’t even close his eyes. Gradually, the ceiling of Kay’s dorm room came into focus; the pale color, black marks up against the paint there, the edge of the wall where it met the ceiling. Try as hard as he could, he couldn’t stop thinking now about Taylor cooing on the phone with Kay about how amazing Tripp’s dick was. Just the thing that worried him, now proven to be true. He shook his head, trying to break the thoughts away, narrowed his eyes. But they wouldn’t go away. Taylor right now probably out with Tripp on a Saturday night. Driving around in the guy’s Porsche. When she came back at Thanksgiving, she’d tell her old buddy Harrison it was over. Could he even be friends with her anymore? If she came back and broke it off, it would be the end. They would say Hey every once in a while over their phones, then eventually those instances would come farther and farther apart. Then six months would go by and he’d never talk to her. She would be off with another guy, maybe Tripp, and he would be heartbroken. Kay nudged his hip.

“What,” he said, “you want me to move over?”

“Roll on your side. Away from me.”

He sighed with discontent, huffed, bounced around, got on his side. Only Kay didn’t want more room—now she curled up against his back, put her arm around him . . .

And his heart just about *burst* out of his chest. Tears rimmed his eyes. It was as if he hadn’t had human contact in years, some survivor of war, out in

the bush living on scraps that he'd gathered himself, a news crew discovering him, bringing him back to civilization . . . He sniffled, wiped his eyes. Kay hugged him harder. He mumbled a sad sounding *Sorry* again, hating his tears and sniffles.

"It's okay, buddy," she said, and now his heart swelled so big he couldn't draw in a breath—even if he was successful there was a good chance it could become a loud sob. He needed to be loved, needed to be held. The most amazing thrilling feeling raced through him, soothed him, golden light shining up his insides. He smiled in the dark. He even chuckled, and Kay snuffled against his back too. How could she know how well to help him? Whoever could think a hug could mean so fucking much?

Now her hand went down, touched his hip, and his heart thudded again. A thumb slipped under the waistband of his underwear, pushed them downward. He whispered a tight: "What are you doing?"

"Taking your underwear off. You know what you need to do . . ."

Chapter Four

AS THE RETRACTED front of his underwear exposed his pubic hair, and chillier air braced his genitals, he grabbed the front waistband to stop her removing them. “We can’t do anything, Kay.”

“We’re not doing anything.”

“I can’t . . . ”

“You need to . . . ”

“What are you talking about, Kay?”

She persisted, pushing down his underwear to mid-thigh, and he adjusted his weight so they could come down, but clutched a hand over his privates. “What are you doing?”

“Tell me what you miss about her,” Kay whispered next to his ear, the softness of her voice and the touch of her breath against his skin hardening his nipples, giving him goosebumps. He could feel his pulse in the cup of his palm, his cock coming to hard life fast.

“Kay . . . ”

“Tell me what you miss,” she said, and placed her warm palm on his naked hip, her fingertips just inches away from his privates.

“Jesus, Kay,” he said.

“Come on, entertain me—what do you miss about Taylor?”

Even aroused, he went sullen. “I miss *everything* about her,” he said.

“When was the last time you were *with* her?”

He groaned. “The bathroom,” he whispered, “at that place, that gas station, on the way back from Wolf Lake.”

“I knew it,” she said, laughing against his neck.

"I know you knew it," he said, "God, we did it in that bathroom, and she looked deep in my eyes."

"She loves you so much, even if she's not with you, she loves you . . . and she's scared."

"God, Kay," he said, her words wrenching on his heart.

"She does," she said again, wriggled herself tighter against him. "She'll always love you, no matter what."

Talking about Taylor, being exposed like this from the waist down, and the light, soft, *feminine* feel of Kay's body pressed up against him had him erect and throbbing already. "Ah, shit, Kay," he sighed.

"Just do it."

Still uncertain what she intended: "Do what?"

"You need to . . . Thanksgiving is a long way away."

"I can't, Kay."

"This is your chance," she said, then in a softer whisper: "I don't even know what I'm thinking."

"You're crazy."

She laughed again, and the sound of it was blissful.

He whispered, "We did it in the bathroom right after she'd been with Colt. Right after she'd been with . . . you know . . ."

"Brady," she said.

"But it was *so* different. She was . . . I don't know . . ."

"Tell me."

"Like . . . *Desperate* for me."

"I told you she loves you."

"God, I wish she was here."

"Pretend she is," Kay said, and it shivered him. What *was* she suggesting? He thought he knew, but that would be astounding. Kay would be Taylor's surrogate, press herself against him while he masturbated . . .?

"You want me to do . . . *that*?"

"I want you to not hurt," she said.

He laughed. "Really?"

"Come on, buddy, before I change my mind," she said and ran circles over and over on his hip.

"I don't know . . ."

Kay's hand traveled up to his elbow, found his forearm, slid down to his wrist. Thumb and middle finger circled on him, index finger braced against

the back of his hand; she guided it between his legs. He put his hand around his hardness.

Having a grip on himself—and having Kay with a grip on his hand—got his eyes widening and his heart racing.

“She misses you too, Harrison,” Kay whispered.

“I hope she does.”

Her hand moved his. “Just do it,” she said again.

“In your bed?”

“Come on, Harrison,” she said, rubbing his arm.

His grip squeezed, his hips tightening, cork-screwing the end of his cock through his hand. He reeled at the whiplash of pleasure. “What if I . . . what if when . . . ”

“Here,” she said, “take off your shirt,” gripped the hem of his T, began to pull it up his body. He let her do it, and Kay pulled it up over his head. As he lay back in the pillows, his eyes searched for hers, hips opened, exposing his arousal to her, wanting her to see it. And Kay did, her eyes then moving back to his, and they met for too long a moment. Kay whipped her gaze away, shoved his balled-up shirt into his face. As he grabbed the cotton, clearing it away from his mouth and nose, Kay said, “Do it in your shirt . . . But you’re taking my bed sheets to the laundry tomorrow.”

With the shirt pulled free, he averted his gaze too, kept his eyes open, though, staring holes down toward the footboard as he rolled over on his side again, showing Kay his bare back. And now when she scooted behind him and curled her warm feminine body against his, he could feel the shape of her against his skin. She still wore her shirt, but he could feel the places she was soft (her ample bosom), and where she was hard (the edge of her rib cage). The hug she gave from behind had his heart swelling large and full. He drew in a long breath, hand returning its grip on his erection but reluctant to stroke. Kay took his wrist again, then her hot damp palm slipped over the back of his hand and curled over his knuckles. Her hand over his hand over his hardness . . .

She guided him to stroke, and his eyes fluttered. His heart pounded in his ears; still his movement was stiff on himself.

Kay whispered, “Do you need me to teach you how to do this?”

He couldn’t answer. The answer was *No, he’d been masturbating for a long time*. The answer he wanted: *Yes. Keep your hand on mine while you teach me how to do it*. He drew in a long inhale and held it.

Kay whispered, “You need me to show you how to jerk it, teach you like how I taught your girlfriend?”

His heart jumped, and he exhaled the full volume of his lungs, drumbeat pulse riding underneath it.

It was lewd. It was about Taylor. Her breath was in his ear . . .

“What do you mean?”

“I taught Taylor.”

“Taught Taylor what?”

“Taught Taylor how to jerk a guy off.”

His whisper high: “You did?”

“I taught her how to do it all.”

“All what?”

“Everything. I put a banana between my thighs and sat on the couch with her. We kissed, and I showed her how to give a guy a hand job.”

“Oh fuck, Kelsey . . .”

* * *

KAY CHUCKLED NEAR HIS EAR. “Oh, you like that?”

“No.”

“Yeah, you do.”

It hurt his heart to think of Taylor in a time before they were a couple, curious and experimenting, her best friend Harrison right next to her secretly wishing it was him. “Who did she do it for?”

“The first time?”

“Yeah.”

“Jamie Roth.”

“Jamie? Cookie’s Jamie?”

“Uh-huh.”

Jamie’d been at Wolf Lake at the end of this summer, dating Cookie. Taylor’d never even given the guy a look. *They’d messed around together?* “He’s older.”

“He is.” Kay guided him to stroke himself because his hand stilled.

He said, “When?”

“You don’t want to know.”

“High school?”

Her chin rocked its point on his back as she shook her head no.

“Before . . .? Oh, my Taylor . . . I miss her so much . . . I just want to hold her.”

“Me too.”

Kelsey’s arms snaked around his neck, and she squeezed him tight. It hurt—she had forearms like fleshy crowbars—but he caressed her wrists and tried to picture it was Taylor behind him.

“Face me for a second,” she whispered.

“Are you sure?”

“Don’t let your dick touch me.”

“I won’t,” he said, flipping over, anxious to hug her; needing to put his arms around someone right now.

They came together carefully in the middle of the bed, and he held Kay. She put her arms out to be held and she wriggled against him. Though he kept his hips back so his cock wouldn’t touch her, soon it was pressing into the fabric of her T-shirt and her soft tummy underneath. She didn’t pull away.

After a long, powerful moment where his heart thudded scoring pleasure through his veins at the feel of a girl in his arms, he said, “You taught her to give blow jobs, too?”

She snuffled a wet warm laugh into his neck. Her hot hand circled his cock and his body seized with electric current. “Oh hey,” he murmured.

Two pumps was all she gave him, then cradled his balls. “Turn back over,” she said.

His penis and his heart were reluctant all of a sudden, but he complied, turning over to face the wall again. Kay pushed herself against his back. Her hand slipped over his thigh, and she dragged the backs of her fingernails over his scrotum and it got his body trembling.

“I showed her how to use her mouth, yeah.”

Now the troubling thought came out in a question. He feared the answer. “Was I . . . really her first?”

She breathed against his back; her hand found his and guided it to his cock. He gripped it, and she went over his hand and encouraged him to jerk himself again. He did, and she withdrew her hand, put it near her mouth, and when it came back, she swiped her fingers over the ticklish head, mushing his sensitive urethra, bringing him more saliva lubrication to ease his stroke.

“Oh fuck, Kay,” he groaned, “please tell me the truth.”

“You were. Without a doubt you were, Harrison. Taylor took her virginity seriously. She gave you a gift. Taylor trusts you completely.”

“She does?” He felt his jaw shake as he held back tears. “Kay, God, really . . . Oh Kay,” he said, hunched over, jerking himself steadily, aroused and wild, embarrassed and full of shame . . . yet somehow *understood* . . . somehow *supported*. Her body against his was incredible. Human contact sparking off those emotions so close to love. His body was effervescent with that pleasure-chemical, like a fresh poured soda pop. In his heart, he held the love for Taylor, and in the strangest wildest most bewildering expansion of emotion, he could feel *himself* squeezing in—love for himself, and love for Kay, too. *Where would he be without her right now?*

“I feel your muscles now,” she said, squeezing his shoulder and then his bicep, his arm flexing over and over again as his hand jerked up and down.

“It’s all for her,” he croaked.

“She’s so hot she’s worth it, don’t you think she’s hot?”

“So hot,” he groaned.

“Those long legs, God, those legs, Harrison . . . ”

“She’s so beautiful . . . ”

“She looks good in sneakers, sneakers and shorts . . . ”

“Short shorts,” he said.

Kay bit his neck, whispered, “You’ve seen her naked . . . ”

“God,” he groaned, jerking faster, not caring Kay was watching him, “she’s so amazing.”

“She’s got a tight ass, a bouncy one, think about it right now . . . ”

“I fucking love her so much,” he said, picturing his Taylor’s bare behind, how she used to cover it, shy, walking around his bedroom when his parents were out.

“I love her too,” Kay said, and bit at his earlobe. His heart did a Jumping Jack, he felt himself stiffening, all the muscles in his body contracting.

“When she sits down, how flat her tummy is . . . ”

“I know,” he groaned.

Kay whispered near his ear, “He won’t love her the way you do.”

He blubbered, drew a sharp inhale, a scary spike stabbing through his heart.

“He could never love her the way you do, Harrison.”

“He can’t,” he cried, “he just can’t . . . ”

“All Tripp can do is fuck her . . . ”

“Don’t, Kay . . . ”

“You know what I mean?”

And as much as he hated it, he responded. “He fucks her all the time.”

“Fucks her with that fat dick, Harrison.”

“Jesus, Kay,” he said, fireworks going off behind his eyes, but his hand jerking faster.

“She told me she loves his foreskin—can you believe that?”

“Ah,” he gasped, his stomach squirming in a hurtful erotic vice, “she’s such a bitch . . . ”

It felt like Kay licked his neck, and his eyebrows raised high above his closed eyes as the pressure built in his balls jiggling below his stroking hand. She whispered, “It’s so gross, picture her pretty mouth on a fat dick with a whole roll of disgusting foreskin . . . ”

“Oh God . . . ”

“I mean, she says she likes it, I don’t see how . . . ”

“Oh, Kay, you’re so fucking crazy . . . ”

Kay humped her stomach against the small of his back, whispering, “Tay likes to fuck, Harrison, she really likes it, you just gotta let her fuck . . . ”

“Stop, Kay,” he said, groaning and twisting, but jerking faster, his grip getting slipperier.

“She likes to fuck, Harrison, let her fuck, you keep loving her . . . ”

“That’s what I’m doing,” he said.

“Let it out, Harrison, let it go, let it all out,” she said and her hand slipped from his hip down the front of his thigh, his wrist bumping against her forearm. The proximity of her fingernails dragging on his sensitive inner thigh had his balls clenching and rolling over.

“Mm, oh shit, Kay, oh shit . . . ” He couldn’t breathe, everything inside him, asshole to brain stem, was being wrung like a dish rag; the top of his mind threatening to pop off.

“When she fucks Tripp, she’s thinking about you,” she said practically purring in his ear, scratching his neck with a fingertip as he burst into his orgasm.

He bucked and jolted, thrust his hips so his cock speared through his tight grip. “Mm, shit,” he hissed, his hand smushing down his bundled T-

shirt so he wouldn't mess Kelsey's bed, but a sudden fear cinching on him that he missed and was sending his passionate ropes all over Kay's sheets. He mashed the balled T-shirt down on the head of his cock and squeezed with his other hand as he kept ejaculating. Six weeks worth of pent up angst came gushing out of him. He wanted to bellow, wanted to burst out crying at the immense feeling of release, but he kept it all in, tried not to make a loud male noise in this room with four women.

He gulped, coughed, let out a thin croaking groan as he doubled over. As the tension tightened to snapping, he let out a creaking hiss of profanity. "Shit, shit, shit," he said, stomach tightening like a cord, his body shaking. The experience left him panting in a face down heap, one knee out, his dick and hand enshrouded by his T-shirt, slick with his ejaculate.

* * *

HE DREW LONG INHALES, exhaled, dragged deeper and held it. Waited for his heart rate to slow down. As it all subsided, as the pleasure and wildness ebbed from him, he was painfully aware of Kay's absence. No longer clutched to his back, no longer whispering in his ear.

Up on one elbow, he squeezed his dwindling erection in the bundled shirt, feeling the cold wet mess he'd left inside it. Kelsey was next to him, on her back, elbows pointed to the ceiling with her fingers combed into her hairline. She regretted it. It was written all over her posture. And he regretted it too. Wished now he'd been stronger refusing. He shouldn't have done that. She shouldn't have done that. This was way, *way* wrong. Never mind that it was a weird kind of intimacy, and it was with Taylor's best friend, Kay and him were forbidden from this sort of thing. They were only supposed to be friends.

He watched her for a while, the edges of her body lit up, the shape of her dark against the white of her dorm room bedding. Her eyes were open, looking straight up. He could see her stomach moving in and out, her breaths coming hard and heavy. There was nothing he could say. Everything he came up with would be unwelcome. So he watched her, tried to send out supportive vibes. How mad was she going to be? He hoped and prayed—God the most important thing—this wouldn't end their friendship.

Her elbows lowered, arms slapping outward, her hands hitting her thighs. She clutched them. He recoiled, this display of anger frightening him. He was on the verge of babbling apology, telling her he would just get outta here, when he realized it wasn't anger that harried her right now, it was frustration. She dragged her nails up her thighs, then her hand slipped under the bedding and her knees rose points in the duvet. Her hands went between her legs, her head rolled to the right side looking away from him into the emptiness of the room and across to the other bunkbed where hopefully whoever was there was sleeping.

The room was quiet, but now he could hear the movement rustling under the sheets. Kay's hand moving around under there, a soft click-click sound of wet sex membranes. His heart was jumping again, but now he was wild with fear. He was stuck here watching Kay do this. Too afraid to help her out . . . what was he going to whisper in *her* ear? What could he say to arouse her? And how hard would she punch him in the face if he even tried? So he lay there mute, watching this hot young friend of his masturbating right next to him on her nineteenth birthday. Not caring that he was there. The sticky sound between her legs grew wetter and her movements faster.

She whispered, "Don't look at me," the tendons in her neck flexing, her silver-to-pink hair stretched over the pillow.

He thumped his chin down on the mattress, his cheek very near her shoulder, practically touching her head. His cock grew to hardness again listening to her sounds, sharing the strange sexual experience, knowing somebody he cared about was pleasuring themselves right next to him . . .

His hand crawled, fingers walking the bedding, timid but somehow suddenly brave in a moment that would normally terrify Harrison Wade into inaction. His hand bumped against her waist, and she flinched. The hand slid up her hip, over her waist, headed nowhere near her sex place, and he wanted her to know that, the hand turning to a shovel trying to slip upward over her stomach and under her arm. Kay lifted, let him. He rested his hand over her bellybutton, the fingers spread out, tips pressed into her soft flesh. He just wanted to support her, that was all. He kept his hand there, gently massaging, always teasing like he would move lower, hoping the taboo threat of his hand moving lower would help her get over the edge.

"Go lower," she said, but as his hand moved, she pinched it against herself with her forearm. "Not your hand," she hissed.

"What?"

“Jesus, Harrison, fucking go lower, *you* go lower,” she spat.

“I’ll do whatever you want,” he said, moving his body downward on elbows and shifting knees. He grabbed the bundled T-shirt, and tossed it against the wall, shifting lower, looking up her body. Kay wore a T-shirt and (he figured) a bra underneath as well, but the points of her nipples humped the fabric out; her back was arched, one knee up, the knee closest to him flat. What did she want?

Chin tilted, their eyes met—she turned away. “Don’t look at me,” she said, “get under the covers.”

Fabric whisking around him, he threw sheets over the back of his head like a hood, wormed under the covers, not knowing what she wanted, heart racing somewhere between passion and fear. Her shin pushed against him and he shifted to the side. She opened her legs wider, and he bit his lower lip, lifting his head and getting a peek under the bedding. He’d been in the dark so long that even under this tent of dorm room fabric, he could make out the shapes moving around under there. Kay wore black panties, her hands were underneath them, both hands in there wiggling and jiggling. Her pussy gushed wet sounds around her manipulations, one pinky finger peeked out from the panty’s black, silver skull ring, nail painted matching black.

Bite my thigh. At least that’s what he thought she said. Cotton rustled and blood pounded in his ears. Her shin pushed again, and he moved away.

“Harrison,” she said, angry.

Now he moved toward her instead. She pushed her shin against him again, foot going sideways and shoving underneath his body. She wanted him between her legs. His eyes were wide and petrified, trying to read as much crazy information as they could.

“Bite my thigh,” she said again, still a whisper but her voice hoarse enough she could be heard by everybody in the room.

He worked higher on his elbows, getting between her open legs. His eyes watched Kelsey’s hands under the black of her panties, watched how fast they moved; he kissed the inside of her knee and she struck him with it, flapping her legs closed, his cheek mushing a wet sound against his teeth.

“Don’t kiss me,” she hissed.

“Sorry,” he whispered, worked higher, and now his face was right between her legs. He could *smell* her. Smell that humid earth smell, that woman *sex* smell; he wanted to pull down the front of her panties, breathe

her in . . . he was hard aching steel again. This was so wrong, so, so wrong, but he owed it to her . . .

“My inner thigh,” she said through clenched teeth. That click-clicking getting faster and faster as she beat herself off. He stopped biting his lip, tore his eyes away from watching her hands move, opened his mouth and sunk his teeth into the inside of her thigh, grabbing soft cool perfect flesh and holding it.

“Harder,” she said in a high tight voice, and he bit her harder. “Higher,” she said, and he did what she told him. His teeth clamped down again two inches higher up her thigh, his cheek being nudged by her moving hands. She tightened. Squeaked. Puffed and huffed, bucked against him. He clamped his teeth harder. The wet sounds grew fast, stopped, returned, slower, stopped. She began to moan, and gyrate, and he still held her flesh in his teeth. He stayed with her while she rode it out, Kelsey humping her hips, his head riding up and down, cheek in her crotch, her flesh in his mouth. Saliva ran down his chin.

When he was pretty sure it was over, his clamp lessened on her thigh. He let his jaw unclench, wanted to kiss her but knew he would be in trouble. He licked his own lips, wiped his mouth, rose. He looked away from her, removed the covering, returned to his spot on the bed, lay on his back. Kelsey lay panting next to him. When he looked over, she rolled to her side and showed him her back.

Chapter Five

WHEN KAY CALLED in the morning, she knew right away something was wrong. There were minute tells: the distance which Kay put the camera from her; the way she sat; Kay's slumped shoulders, one crossed leg. It looked like Kay was in her dorm room because she was close to a ceiling. Kay had a top bunk in res. It was in her expression too, or more accurately, her *eyes*. The way they reluctantly met the camera then looked away again. Taylor said, "What's up? How was your birthday?"

Kay sighed, said, "It sucked because you weren't here."

"I know. I wish I was. We can do your birthday up when I come home, okay? You and I will go out, just us, we'll party, I'll get you a cake . . ."

Kay nodded, and Taylor got a sick feeling seeing her this way—Kay was rarely affected by anything. Her upper lip got sweaty like there was an oncoming food poisoning. She asked, "What's wrong, Kay?"

"I think, uh," Kay scratched her neck, didn't continue.

"Think what?"

Kay nodded, swished her mouth side-to-side. "I think things got fucked up last night."

"Why—what happened?"

Kay said, "With Harrison."

"What's wrong with Harrison? What happened?"

Kay looked down and to the side. "He's fine," she said.

But that wasn't the question. She said again, "Something *happened*?"

"We . . . uh, he took me to see some movies, bunch of geeks in a weirdo film club. Dumb shit, you know, stuff that you like."

“Horror movies?”

“Not really, but yeah. Kinda neat, I liked them. Sci-fi. Horror, I guess. But then he got all . . . I don’t know . . .”

“All what?”

“Mokey. Sad.”

“Sad about what?”

“Jesus, Taylor, about *you*, what do you think?”

Her heart sank; now she slumped too. Two girls sitting in their dorm rooms a couple thousand miles apart. Longtime friends, the closest of friends. The things they’d shared . . . But here they were separated by distance and circumstance, all of her own design. Every day here was a struggle. Nothing about this was easy, if she’d wanted to suffer she could’ve stayed at home in Michigan, at least done it with people she knew. *But that was a different kind of suffering.*

“Anyway, it was late, he came back to my dorm.”

Now her head popped up, a new pathway emerging in the realm of possibilities. She frowned, said, “He went back to your dorm?”

“It was late, it was stupid to go all the way back to Sag.”

“Where’d he sleep?”

Kay looked surprised by the directness of the question. Her lips pursed, and her eyes widened. She cocked her head, ran her hand through her silvery hair. “God,” she exhaled.

“What are you trying to tell me, Kay?” She could feel a growing tingle in the tips of her fingers, and clenched her hands to squeeze it away.

“Nothing *happened*, if that’s what you’re saying . . .”

A tidal wave of reality hit her and all she wanted was to be restored to the fifteen-year-old version of herself where all her friends were also fifteen and everything still made sense. “Is everything okay?” she said, “I just want to know everything’s okay . . .”

Kay sighed, “Just relax. Hey, I told you let me handle it.”

Her demeanor—as minimal in strength as it already was—crumbled. “I . . . I don’t like it when you’re not . . . I don’t like it when you look like this. I don’t like to see you like this . . .”

“Like what? . . .”

She said, “I don’t know . . . you look *shook*.”

“I’m not shook,” Kay said, drawing up one knee and hugging her arms around it, resting her chin on its point, and looking into the camera.

She worked her mouth around fearfully. “Did you . . . *sleep* with him?”

Kay said, “No, baby.”

“Are you sure?”

Kay tilted her head. “Not entirely sure,” she said.

Her scalp tightened and tingled. “What did you do? . . . ”

And now all those images of seeing her Harrison with Kay in his lap, having sex, living out some weird vindicating foursome, one that was meant and planned to be an extraction of her from the relationship with Harrison—one that would ameliorate her best buddy . . . Make him okay. It was dreadful . . . and in the end they’d stayed together, anyway. All that planning for what?

Kay pursed her lips, frowned. “You know he misses you so bad, baby.”

She whispered, “I miss him too.”

Kay nodded her head in long elaborate lines, then said, “How’s your California boyfriend?”

“Fine,” she said, “don’t change the subject.”

Kay sighed. “Things got fucked up, Taylor, I’m not gonna lie. It was *not* my fault . . . ”

“What do you mean? Whose fault is it? Harrison’s?”

“No. Yours.” Kelsey shook her head and threw her hands up. “It’s impossible trying to keep Harrison wrangled. Girls are interested in him. That fucking Ashley all the time. And the way you make him feel . . . ”

Her voice was quiet: “How do I make him feel?”

Kay changed her mind, acting like she didn’t want to talk about it, saying, “He’s all right.”

She looked down, then up again, “He’s not, is he?”

“He’s doing better than I thought.”

Now she moaned, shook a hand through her hair. “Maybe too good.”

“All he thinks about is you.”

“Does he still talk about Ashley?”

“She sucked his dick, Tay. The guy lives at home with his mommy and daddy, his girlfriend is fucking another guy, he’s so . . . *sensitive* . . . You imagine he *doesn’t* think about the one girl who showed him the slightest interest? And sucking his dick, let’s be real, is more than a *little* interest . . . ”

“You’re killing me . . . ”

“I mean, Harrison’s an idiot, he brought this on himself. I’m not blaming you for that . . . but you . . . You know what?—shit, it’s all *his* fault. No, it’s *not* you, it’s *him* . . . ”

“Was he crying?”

“Practically. I had to console him.”

“Where?”

“Here,” she said, looking up and around.

“In your dorm room?” Kelsey nodded, looked away again. “What happened?”

“It was really weird. He’s . . . he really is *pining* for you.”

“He is?” It was somehow uplifting even though it would mean that Harrison was hurting.

“Yeah, he is. But it’s a long time to Thanksgiving, you know what I mean?”

“Please, just tell me you didn’t sleep with him again . . .”

“I didn’t. I don’t like Harrison that way.”

“Then what *happened*? Jesus, Kay, when you came on the camera it looked like your dog died.”

Kay sighed then growled again, ran fingers through her hair, pulled it all back from her face and held it tight in a pure pink tail behind her, eyes burrowing into her phone’s camera, Taylor receiving the image so far away.

“What did you do?”

Kay let her hair fall, spoke earnestly. “Look, if I don’t do something, your Harrison is going to curl up and die, or some other girl’s going to insinuate herself into his life. You don’t want him to die, I know that, and you don’t want him to be with somebody else . . .”

“So what happened?”

“I made him . . . feel *better*,” she said, “for lack of a better phrase.”

Her shoulders grew heavy, and a sudden feeling of betrayal widened inside her, pushed her insides apart. But she would never say that to Kelsey Kay, never say something that would make her mad. Kay *wouldn’t* betray her . . . but the feeling was impossible to ignore. “Did you jerk him off?”

Kay shook her head. “Didn’t touch him.”

“Are you serious?” Her eyes brimmed with tears

“I didn’t touch him, okay, Taylor?”

“Swear you didn’t touch him.”

"I mean, I touched him a *little*, but I didn't jerk him off or anything, it wasn't like that."

"Oh my God," she said, and buried her face in her hands.

"Hey, I did it for you, Taylor."

"I know, I know," she breathed into her palms. "I know you did, okay? . . . I know . . ."

"And I didn't *touch* him, you hear me?"

She nodded, got strong. "What did you do?"

"Sure you want to know?"

Now she was sure it was bad, and she deflated. "Aw, come on, Kay, what did you do?"

"No, Taylor, I mean, not because what I did was *wrong*, but what I did was . . . *sad*? Or what *Harrison* did was sad . . ."

Taylor sighed, eyes blinking away the wet in her eyes. She sniffled, told Kay to hold on, leaned to the side, snagged a tissue out of her tissue box and blew her nose.

Kay said, "Harrison doesn't have it so good, you know."

"I know," she said and held the balled Kleenex to her cheek.

Kay cocked her head, looked up. "I just . . ."

"Just what?"

"I hugged him . . . we were in bed. I told him to pretend it was you behind him . . ."

Taylor held her face stony as long as she could but her lips wriggled, then her eyes squinted with a flooding wet. She began to cry.

"He's so sad," Kay said while she cried.

"I'm so sorry . . ."

"Don't be sorry. I don't mind him."

"Thank you," she said, drawing a long inhale and collecting herself, trying to be strong.

"Don't thank me, it's not my *pleasure*, but I'd do anything for you . . ."

"Thank you, Kay," she said.

"I told him to . . . you know . . ."

"What?"

Kay swished her mouth to one side, looked away again. "Jerk off."

"While you were hugging him?" Her voice had thinned and went whiny.

"Pretending it was you in bed with him—if he doesn't do that, if he doesn't feel like he's got any hope in hell, some girl's going to put her

hooks in him, some fucking Ashley or somebody like her, some useless slut who'll open her legs . . . he'll end up with three kids and a wife who cheats on him, in a fucking dead-end job . . ."

"Stop, Kay, stop . . ."

Kay was quiet a moment. "It's not your responsibility, Taylor."

"It's not," she said, "I know it's not."

Kay smiled a little, said, "It's tough having everything."

"I don't have everything," she murmured.

"You *deserve* everything."

She shook her head. "No, I don't—I'm worthless."

"Hey, shut the fuck up with that," Kay said, and now she picked up her phone, brought it close. In Taylor's screen, Kay's face loomed large. "Don't *ever* say that."

"I know—I'm not . . . I'm not worthless."

"You're definitely not." Kay was firm, brow lowered.

"So that's it? You hugged him while he jerked off?"

"That's it. Like, there's a bit more, but it's not important."

"What is it?"

"Just weird shit, Taylor, don't worry about it."

"You didn't touch him down there, or anything . . .?"

"No. I didn't. Harrison just needed to do . . . *that*."

"You slept in bed with him?"

Kay nodded. She chuckled, said, "He can be so pathetic sometimes," then the smile faded. Serious, she said, "You know what that did for him, laying in bed with me?"

Taylor nodded, sniffled and blew her nose again. "Is he okay?"

"Yeah, he's okay. Shit is weird as fuck between us now. Woke up this morning, none of us knew *where* to look."

"When did he go home?"

"About an hour ago. I made him do my laundry."

The ridiculousness of it all made her laugh unexpectedly. She could picture stern Kay demanding action from Harrison, and her meek friend obeying without the hint of denial. It was a funny picture, a caricature, Kay with her hands on her hips, Harrison nodding and obeying, bowing with sheets held against him, eager to please.

Kay said, "He messed up my sheets."

Taylor clucked her tongue. "Hey, come on, don't . . ."

“Sorry. I mean, he did, and I’m not going to do my laundry because of him.”

Taylor shook her head to clear it, sat up, said, “Okay—I’m okay,” then brighter again, posture straightened even further, “Yeah. I’m okay . . .” She tossed her Kleenex aside, said, “That’s it?”

Kay said, “That’s it. Unless you want to talk about the future . . .”

“What’s the future?”

“That’s why I asked you how Tripp was . . .”

“He’s fine. Things got weird, I told you . . .”

“Yeah, you’re an idiot and told him about Harrison.”

“I think he’s over that now. Things were weird for a week . . . I think he’s okay, but I don’t know . . .”

“Don’t get attached, anyway. Guys are jerks.”

“He’s totally not a jerk, Kay, he’s actually really nice.”

“Good. Have fun. Anyway, what I was talking about was Harrison’s future.”

“What’s in Harrison’s future?”

“I don’t know if he’s going to make it to Thanksgiving . . .”

She’d known Kelsey Kay her whole life and could see in her best friend’s blank expression that Kay had more in store. “What are you thinking? . . .”

Trap King

OCTOBER 19-20

Friday, October 19

Chapter One

TRIPP'S PORSCHE WAS A HAND-ME-DOWN, and what was cool was he never made a big deal about it even though everyone else thought it was awesome. The car belonged to his grandfather (who had four cars in total) and when he died, Tripp's dad was in charge of the estate. Tripp was sixteen at the time and needed a car and his dad just popped it over to him. It was nice to ride in, though she didn't really care so much about cars. Tripp's was nice because it was a convertible, and there was something about going out in it that always made you feel like you were on your way somewhere fun, like you were in a car commercial. So, put her in sunny palm tree California, sitting next to a rich, good-looking guy with blond hair, and, yeah, maybe it was silly, but there was an excitement in being seen with him.

But five minutes down High Street they came to the lights at the intersection at Bay Drive, and Tripp kept the sports car in the straightaway lane instead of the right-hand one. A right turn would take them into Santa Cruz proper, down to the ocean and the Boardwalk where she assumed they were headed yet again.

Thumb jacked to the right, she faced him, her handsome dude with shower-wet hair combed back, sly smile, looking straight ahead and ignoring her. The sky was drained of light but still buoyant in blue; beyond Tripp was an old barn converted into a theater, a show tonight, the parking lot half full, people filing toward the open doors under strung lines of lights; Tripp glowed in soft stoplight red.

She said, "Where are we going?"

Now he faced her, cupped a hand to his ear, gave her an expressionless *Can't hear you* face. She laughed, turned down his stereo with some taps on the screen, repeated her question.

The light changed to green, he geared the car to drive, and they accelerated straight, deeper down High Street. "It's a surprise," he shouted over the motor and music and rushing wind.

She crossed her arms, smiling, hair whipping around. An excited tingle began. It didn't matter if they went to the Boardwalk again, as long as they went out together.

As they raced down High, she couldn't stop smiling. The car growled at low speed now through residential streets, turning sharp right, then sharp left, then in a calm woman's voice the car's navigation system said In twenty yards turn left for Cabrillo Highway.

At the stop sign, waiting to turn left, she said, "Can I ask your car where we're going?"

He gave no answer, tapped the screen a few times, going through menus. "She knows nothing, Taylor." The light changed, they headed onto the narrow highway.

Soon they were on the busy roadway, passing under an overhead highway sign reading North 17 San Jose Oakland.

"All right, seriously," she shouted, pivoting, "where the hell are we going?—we're leaving SC . . ."

He laughed, throwing his head back, the wind tangling and whipping his hair. He said, "Taking you to San Jose, taking you to the Shark Tank . . ."

* * *

THE SHARK TANK wasn't what she expected at all. Most of the almost hour-long drive up north to San Jose she considered it must have something to do with swimming, maybe waterskiing, or even surfing, Tripp knowing her love for the water. They'd stayed quiet in the car, listening to loud music with the top down and the wind whipping their hair. Sometimes he would reach over and hold her wrist, she would put her hand over his. Once in San Jose, they rolled off the highway on a looping exit right downtown and lining up in bumper-to-bumper traffic.

She turned the music down, asked him: “What’s the Shark Tank?” When she’d tried to look it up on the highway using her phone, he’d laid out his hand for her to surrender it. When she was hesitant, he gave her an earnest face and said, “You’ll ruin the surprise.” She gave the phone up, but mock-scowled at him.

“You’ll see,” he said, smirking.

She said, “Am I going to enjoy it, or not?”

“You’ll enjoy it,” he said, “I wouldn’t drive all this way for something you *didn’t* like,” then turned up the stereo. At first she thought it was rude, but it didn’t occur to her until later that *was* the answer—he was giving it right to her.

They turned right onto a street called Santa Clara, driving underneath tall palm trees lining one side. On the opposite side loomed a huge convention center or a stadium lit up with red and blue spotlights. That was when she noticed the huge shark printed on vinyl alongside the building. There was the thump of music, and young people swarmed around the concourses, stairways, and sidewalks.

She said, “This is the Shark Tank—what the hell is it?”

“The Shark Tank,” he said, waving his hand to the left, “where the San Jose Sharks play.”

“Hockey?” She said it with hidden disappointment, thinking he brought her here because he thought people up north liked hockey.

“It’s the SAP Center,” he said, indicating right and pulling into a parking lot almost directly across. She looked over her shoulder and behind her, said, “You mean a concert? Who? . . .”

He laughed, said, “We were listening to the album the whole way up here . . .”

* * *

OUT OF THE CAR NOW, Tripp held out a hand for her to take, and they walked together through the parking lot and toward the stadium. They’d parked in VIP, a special section of half a dozen spots in the open-air lot underneath tents with sun-bleached green canvas points.

She said, “Tripp, you could’ve told me, I’m dressed for the Boardwalk . . .”

“Taylor, look at yourself,” he said, “look then tell me you’re not the hottest girl here tonight.”

She laughed. “That’s the lamest thing you ever said to me.”

Tripp tipped an imaginary hat then bowed elaborately making her laugh harder. “M’lady . . . ”

* * *

THEY WALKED QUICKLY across the packed parking lot, headed for the Shark Tank, laughing and looking up at him as he texted on his phone, big smile on his face too. She bumped his hip with her hip. She might’ve dressed differently if she’d known she was coming to this concert, but what she wore wasn’t out of place; a black skirt that ended mid-thigh, ultra bright-white Filas and a black short-sleeve top. Her hair was down; she’d showered and even took an extra ten to razor her lady parts. Tripp wore good-looking jeans, and a plum and gray V-neck sweater that looked incredible on him.

He put his phone away, said to her, “You excited?”

“It’s a *crazy* surprise.”

They crossed the street together, and he led her away from the ticket windows, around the corner and down the far side of the building to a small kiosk set in the stadium’s side where there was a lineup of only five people. Still holding her hand, they waited in line, which moved fast, and at the kiosk he asked the Latino guy with the shirt and tie behind the Plexiglas if there was a ticket for him. “Tripp Heavens for Greg Heavens. Just two.” He held up a peace sign for the guy.

The attendant was expressionless but polite, tapping on a keyboard and looking at the screen. He hit some buttons, turned, grabbed two long paper stubs that were printed from a machine behind him, grabbed two plastic passes on royal blue lanyards and passed them all in the stainless scoop underneath the Plexiglas divider, smiling finally and saying, “Enjoy the show, Mr. Heavens.”

As they stepped away from the kiosk, she watched him reading the passes and tickets, and asked him: “Backstage?”

“Here, come here,” he said, in a strong, calm voice, and moving them so they stood face to face. He looked down into her eyes; she could see

happiness there inside him. Some sort of pride, or some sort of enjoyment in providing this pleasure for her. It was a strikingly masculine and nurturing sort of pose. Fatherly in its way, but not like he was her father, but more like he would make a good father. A daughter would love to have him as her dad.

“You’re amazing,” she said, and he hooped her lanyard over her neck; she tilted her chin up, and they kissed.

* * *

THE LANYARDS COULD GET them backstage, but she wanted to be up front so they used the tickets at the door and were led by an usher giving them the VIP treatment, escorting them into the front open-area seating. The music pounded and lights flashed. They were late, the show’d started maybe thirty minutes ago, but there on the stage was Kendall Limerick, one lone performer in a green velour sweat suit with yellow stripes, huge sneakers, gold jewelry, with a white du-rag, the ties swinging left and right as he barked into a wireless mic. Behind him on the hugest projection screen she had ever seen were the images of what must’ve been civil rights stuff from way back in the 60s; police versus the black population, hoses and dogs . . . It was bewildering, the music deafening, throbbing in her organs, her whole body vibrating. Kendall was doing his hit song Trap King, a song she and Shelby had blasted all summer before the last, and she knew every single word. Its syncopation was slow but powerful, leaving her a long beat anticipating the next whomp that would shock her body. On the far left of the stage were tiers of gospel singers in satin robes, chanting out the hook—but other than them the stage was a massive empty space, the projection screen doing all the storytelling, emphasizing the words of this bad guy from Compton made good by poetry.

They were abandoned then by the usher, the two of them alone, Tripp taking her hand and leading her into the edge of the gathered throng at the foot of the stage, everyone bobbing, cheering, pumping fists or gun hands, most with their phones thrust up. The colors swirled psychedelic now; smoke began to crawl the stage, shrouding Kendall.

Taylor thrust her hands over her head, dancing with Tripp, carefree and jumping, arriving at her spot front of stage with perfect timing . . . the

wall of massive sound dropped away, and the stadium was left in sudden enormous silence; the lights flared up, the rolling smoke came off the stage and tumbled over the crowd; cheers began, hesitant, whistles too, someone shouted, “Do it!” Kendall stood with mic arm up and out, finger pointed over the crowd . . . She waited, an expectant smile spread wide on her face, feeling so out of this world in this moment, so different from the Taylor she knew, everything inside her tingling . . .

Kendall whispered, “Pop . . .”

And at last came the absolutely *massive* bass drop everyone begged for, the ferocious power of the sound alarming her, shaking her to her core, the whole stadium grinding with explosive vibration around her as everyone went out of their minds and Kendall punched the hook, the tempo faster, growling how he was the king, head shaking, flashing gold jewelry. *Holy fucking shit* . . .

Both hands over her head, she whooped and screamed as loud as she could, her voice lost in the crowd.

* * *

TWO SONGS IN, Tripp told her he needed a water. Now both of them stood in a passageway outside of the arena again, and she chugged Evian from a plastic water bottle.

“I’ve got another surprise.”

She tipped forward and covered her mouth. When she swallowed, she said, “*Another* surprise?”

“You trust me?”

“Of course I do,” she said, but now that he was asking she was wary. They’d danced up front row for maybe ten minutes; not long, but they both shone with sweat. Her hair clung to her face, and she ran a finger to free the locks. She passed Tripp the water bottle, saying, “*Should* I trust you?”

He smiled, took a quick drink and said, “Have I ever let you down?”

Something about his confidence drew her in, and she fell against him, their bodies feeling good together, warm and damp, making her kind of think it would be nice right now for there not to be clothes between them. He put an arm around her, tilted the water for her to drink, which she did trying to form the prettiest mouth possible before he touched the rim of the

bottle to her lips. It tapped her teeth, she laughed, took control of the bottle and stood apart from him to take another drink on her own.

"It's so hot in here," she said when she was done, passing the bottle back.

Tripp finished it, tossed it in a recycling bin where it bounded around before settling. He clapped his hands, said, "Ready for your surprise?"

"Yeah," she said, looking up and down the long concourse that ran outside the stadium seating. They were in a restricted area but there were plenty of concertgoers milling around, clutches of people with lanyards around their necks and security personnel interspersed in fairly equal sections down the hall as far as she could see. "What's my surprise?"

"I'll take you there," he said holding out a hand, which she gave him.

He led her further down the hall, looking up and reading painted numbers at doorways, then saying, "It's up this way," and leading her further. They passed into a stairwell, headed up three flights where they had to flash their lanyard to a security guy.

Now they were in a hall that was furnished differently than where they'd come from. Not a cavernous metal and concrete hall, this one was small, more at human scale and furnished like a hotel; carpeted, trim on the doors in wood rather than steel. She asked where the heck they were.

"Backstage suites," he said.

"Are you serious?" She continued, "Like, we're backstage, like we can meet Kendall? . . ."

"You can if you want, but you know he's kind of doing a show right now . . ."

She laughed, bumped into him looking to get an arm around her shoulders. Tripp did, hugging her while they walked. There were more security guards up here, these ones in suits rather than looking like Navy SEALs.

As they got closer to the next door where a tall black guy in a blazer and gray pants stood wearing a headset, Tripp turned, took both her hands, walking backward saying, "You sure you trust me? . . ."

She said, "You're really making it sound like I shouldn't trust you . . ."

"Come with me, Taylor . . ."

"Where are you taking me?"

He stopped just before the door, the security guard looking their way but saying nothing. Tripp smiled, said, "You think you can sing?"

She frowned. "I don't think I can sing."

"This is your chance, Taylor," he said, "you trust me?"

"No," she said defiantly, putting on the brakes, Tripp still pulling her but her heels dug into the carpet. "What are you talking about?"

He was still smiling; her heart raced. "Backup singer," he said, "remember?"

"I don't want to be a backup singer, Tripp,"

"You ask for something, Taylor, I get it for you . . ."

"Tripp, I'm *not* a singer—what the hell? . . ."

"You trust me?"

"Yeah, but . . ."

"Come on," he said, "nobody's going to notice you, Taylor. They're going to put a smock on you, and you're going to sing along with that chorus . . ."

"Tripp, are you . . . you've got to be fucking kidding—no *way* . . ."

"Taylor, if you trust me, you'll come with me," he said, and his words did get her feet moving, although reluctantly.

The security guard nodded his head toward Tripp and said, "This the singer?"

Tripp said, "They have her stuff ready?"

"You go through here," the guard said and pushed open the door.

"Tripp, there's no way," she said.

"Trust me . . ."

With her weight leaned backward, their grip on each other's hands pulled taut and she could feel her face muscles tighten, could feel a hot riling panic wavering up through her core. Tripp took a step backward into the dark room, and she followed, putting one foot ahead, the same time as her muscles in her arms quivered as she attempted to pull him back into the hallway . . .

"Tripp, there's no way, Tripp . . . seriously," she whispered, abject fear beginning to creep up her scalp now. *In front of all those people—what would the other singers think of her?* . . . "No fucking way, Tripp, don't make me . . ."

But now they were stepping in the dark room, she saw they weren't backstage at all because they were in an unlit space looking through a window high and above the stage. Limerick was out there performing, the vibrations of the music buzzing in the glass. It looked like they were in a

hotel room; kitchenette on the left with under lit cupboards; the main space arranged with leather couches, leather chairs, she could see the rectangles of glass table tops reflecting the flickering winks of the stage lights.

“What the hell, Tripp? . . .” she whined, mad but bewildered, turning back as the door closed, seeing the amused face of the security guard in profile; a guy thing, this one playing along for the guest tricking his girlfriend . . .

“Get in here,” Tripp said and pulled her with both hands. She fell against him, relief washing up through her, making the tendons in her neck bulge. There was also anger though—mad that he would treat her like that.

“You’re such an asshole,” she hissed and squeezed both her hands on his ribs. He hugged her tight and kissed the top of her head.

“I wouldn’t do that to you, Taylor.” In her arms she could feel him chuckling.

“My heart is racing right now . . .”

“Check it out,” he said, gesturing toward the room. He moved to the end of the couch and turned on a table lamp, saying, “Executive suite.”

“Are you serious?” she whispered.

“My dad called today, he’s got this band from France who were coming to the show, Thot Bubble—like a white Tribe Called Quest collective, but with made up personalities, you know, like Gorillaz or Die Antwoord . . .? Anyway, his company signed them like six months ago, and they were coming to San Jose to see Kendall but they were detained in Tokyo . . .” He took a puff from an imaginary joint. “This box is booked, it’s meant for Thot Bubble . . .”

“Only Thot Bubble’s not coming . . .”

“It’s ours now,” he said, regarding her in the dim, his smile reassuring and confident.

* * *

THERE WAS something really masculine in the way he’d orchestrated her journey here. Maybe even paternal, like a good-natured ‘*I got your nose*’ trick. Masterful but caring; she felt like the center of his attention. Everything he’d done here tonight was meant to entertain her. And while Limerick prowled around on stage, his words quiet but the beat of the music

pounding in the room, she was suddenly uninterested in the show. She looked at Tripp, going from his eyes down his body then back up again. He soaked it in, and she loved to give it to him. There was a certain admiration inside her for being his focus.

“You really got me,” she said.

He came to her, slipped his fingers between hers, and she fell against him again, their chests colliding then their mouths coming together.

“It’s just you and me here?”

“Just the two of us,” he said.

“Those French guys aren’t coming?”

“Just Tripp and Taylor. We’ve got the place to ourselves.”

“How come we can’t hear the music?”

“Want me to turn on the speakers?”

“Not really,” she said, meeting his gaze, letting him read her expression to know exactly what it was she meant. In the absence of that cliff wall of anxiety, that teetering Pisa tower looking to topple on her and crush her with panic, she felt decidedly . . . *horny*.

Tripp took her neck then, that big hand gripping her, excitement twirling up from her toes as he guided her mouth to his. She slipped him her tongue, breathed him in. They were both hot and sweaty, and they were going to get a lot sweatier . . .

She pulled back, looked in his eyes. She bit her lower lip, his little girl asking for another gift: “There’s something crazy I want . . .”

Saturday, October 20

Chapter Two

AFTER THE SECOND round of doorbell-ringing he wasn't sure anyone would answer despite the car present in the driveway. Prepared to leave, he hesitated when he thought he saw movement inside the house, someone coming toward the front door. He stepped back and out of the shade of the portico so the sun would light him up to the person coming and show him as a friend. The door opened.

"Harrison? Oh my God, kiddo, what are you doing here?" Trish stood at the open door in a white tank top and fancy sweatpants, black and red with red drawstrings.

"Hey, Mrs. Brooks," he said, "how's it going?"

"It's going fine Harrison, my boy," she said, almost bubbling seeing him which provoked a warm and welcome feeling deep inside. She smiled wide enough to show her teeth. "What can I do for you?" He could see Taylor's beauty in her mother. Trish had to be, what?—forty-seven, forty-eight years old . . . but the woman was stunning even in her around-the-house sweats and not made up.

But now he'd lost his nerve, a foolish feeling tickling up his back. He rubbed his neck, had trouble meeting Trish's eye, and knew for damn sure he was looking like a little kid to her—exactly the way she probably already measured him. "I . . . uh, I was going up north, and . . . uh, well, I was—"

"Hey, come in," she said, leaning forward to hold the door wider and scooting aside so he would come in the house. "Come in, Harrison, can you sit a minute?"

“Uh, yeah,” he said, stepping into the house and into the front foyer, already feeling more grown up—as kids they were always instructed to use the garage entrance or the side one that went to the kitchen.

“Take your shoes off,” she said passing by him and heading down the hall toward the kitchen. “I was making breakfast—you hungry?”

“I ate already,” he said, slipping his shoes off, putting his hands in his pockets and following Trish’s trail, catching up with her in the kitchen where he found her pulling a pan of bacon out of the oven. She slid it over the stovetop, said, “I’m going keto, in case you’re wondering why I’m by myself with a big tray of bacon.”

“I didn’t think anything,” he said, but now her impromptu story had him looking for her secret—was bacon-hungry Steve Sanders up in her bedroom and she didn’t want innocent Harrison to know?

Trish said, “Been a few weeks now, I just feel so guilty eating all this bacon and meat.” She put her nose over the steam rising from the tray and an honest and happy smile appeared on her face.

He said, “I think it’s doing you good.”

She opened her eyes and regarded him, and now he felt like she thought that was some weird come-on from her daughter’s kind-of-boyfriend. He made a funny face, said, “I mean, you look really happy.”

She put a hand on her hip and studied him a moment. She smiled again. “You know what—*thank* you, Harrison. I feel like I’m finding my happiness.”

“I just mean—”

“I was up early, did yoga, worked out, now I get to eat some delicious food—you’re going to have some with me—and I know what I’m doing with the rest of my day and all . . . I don’t know, maybe I sound crazy, but I’m glad you think I look happy.”

“You do,” he said, trying not to sound too eager.

She still smiled, nodding, regarding him. She said, “You look good too, Harrison. Grown up. College life agrees with you.”

“It’s been okay,” he said.

“You look like you lost weight.”

“Lost weight?” Jesus, all the food he was eating, he shouldn’t look like he was losing weight.

She squeezed her own cheeks, said, “In your face. You look grown up.”

“Thanks,” he said, thinking how they were two people looking for happiness in Taylor’s absence. Looking grown up and thinner in the face would be compliments he’d take. And, hey, he hadn’t seen Trish in only two months, so for there to be any noticeable change there must be good things happening in his body. New muscles, maybe a hot surge of testosterone . . .

Trish told him to have a seat, and he did, turning a kitchen chair around to face her while she prepared two plates with bacon and scrambled eggs. His macros could accommodate this—some black coffee too—according to Brady, protein would his best friend over the next year.

He said, “So, yeah, I’m going up north today, like kind of near Wolf Lake and I was wondering if you needed anything done. Like for winter, or for anything . . . just check on the place.”

“Where are you going?” She had eyes down, getting cutlery out of the top drawer.

“West Branch, to visit my aunt.”

“Isn’t that out of the way?”

“Just a detour, Mrs. Brooks.”

She chomped a piece of bacon, crunched it, said, “Might be ‘Call me Trish’ time.”

“That’s weird,” he said, though a lot of Taylor’s girlfriends had been calling her Trish for a long while. He sipped black coffee, sniffed, continued, “Trish.”

She laughed, said, “You make it weird, Harrison,” and then brought two plates to the table. He jumped up to help, but she didn’t need any; instead he went to the counter and got a coffee, asked her if she wanted a refill to which she agreed. Once they were sitting again, he asked her: “Can I do anything for you up there?”

“I’ve got a guy who winterizes it for me, lives in Walker City . . . but, it’s kind of weird timing . . . I cleaned out KC’s room, and Riley’s too . . .”

Please don’t say Taylor’s . . .

Trish frowned a little, deep in thought, and he could see she hadn’t enjoyed cleaning out her oldest kids’s rooms. “I have some bins with old board games and stuff, you know, puzzles, arts and crafts from when you guys were younger. Could you take that up with you? . . . I was going to put it in the garage, but maybe Wolf Lake would be better. Probably have grandbabies in a few years, might be a good place for it.”

That sunk his stomach. It was terrible to think of one of the neighborhood's hottest moms getting older, and also to think she probably wasn't far off . . . Riley and KC would be settling down soon enough most likely. There were weddings and babies in Trish's near future. And Taylor wouldn't be too far behind.

"I'd love to take those things up there for you," he said. And the chore was almost too good to be true. The perfect thing he'd hoped for . . .

Trish forked a mouthful of eggs, and he joined in, both of them quiet a moment as they ate. Trish asked him if he was sure he had enough room in his car for a few bins.

"Yeah, sure. The back's empty. You know I'm selling the Soob?"

"Oh yeah?"

"Moving to town where school is, Lansing . . . Kelsey Kay and I are getting an apartment."

Trish kept her head down, chewing, but slowly looked up, examining him.

"Just friends, Mrs. Brooks. *Trish*."

"I know. I bet Taylor wants Kay to keep an eye on you . . ."

"Make sure I'm doing my homework."

They were quiet again, and his decision to move in with Kay became very present in his mind. He wondered what Trish really thought of it—because he wasn't sure himself, really. The act of commuting had seemed so sane when he was in his last year of high school; home was where he was familiar. He could be at home and still go to college. But in practice it was *hard*. No one else was *here* anymore. It was just him alone at home, no Taylor. What was the Soob for, anyway? Kelsey was right. And being with Kelsey was a path to being with Taylor, staying in Taylor's life, being connected. A sliver of contempt pained him every once in a while, like maybe his decision to move in with Kay was a result of that feeling he'd detected when he and Kay face-timed Taylor from Native Creek. Him and Kay together was a punishment for Taylor in some small way—a veritable *Take that, you bitch*. Only he wasn't mad at Taylor. She was all he wanted. There was another sliver: a funny ache just below his stomach when he thought of being in bed with Kay, her arms around him, the consideration in allowing him to do something so awful in her bed. It was an uncomfortable feeling, but darkly alluring, too. When he'd texted her a few days later it was almost to make sure they were still friends. The morning aftermath had

made him want to squirm out of his skin. Waking up with Kay, worrying if she would have so much regret she would never talk to him again and then they wouldn't be friends anymore . . . he needed her in his life so bad right now—if he didn't have Taylor *and* he didn't have Kay . . .? So he would move in with her. He'd texted to see if she'd still allow it, she texted back she was glad he was using his brain again.

Trish was on to new things. "You talk to Taylor a lot?"

He nodded, chewing. "Not as much as I'd like, but yeah."

"She doing well?"

That was a good sign Trish was also out of the Taylor loop. He wondered how long Taylor let her mother's texts hang unanswered. "Stressed sometimes. Happy others."

Her eyebrows tented, two lines furrowing above the bridge of her thin nose. "Normal?"

"Yeah, I think so." And now he didn't want to leave Trish thinking that Taylor was being weird at school, so far from home, or needed her mother's concern if she was normal or not. He took a sharp breath, then let it out. "She's seeing a guy."

Trish made a serious face, moved closer abruptly. "She *is*?"

He nodded, raised his eyebrows, sipped his coffee and avoided her gaze. He could see her looking around the kitchen, aware she looked bewildered. She returned to him.

"I'm sorry, Harrison."

"I'm good," he said, smiling and regretting ever mentioning him and Taylor weren't really together anymore, the whole thing crystallizing into harsh reality now. "We're best friends."

With her mouth hung open she still stared. He couldn't look at her. "Shit, Harrison. I am so sorry."

"I'm really okay," he said, Trish's compassion somehow making him feel like it really *was* over between him and Taylor. But it wasn't. It just wasn't. What they had in high school was over, but not them as a couple . . .

Trish said, "You seeing someone?"

He shrugged. "I'm going out. Having fun."

"You're such a great guy, Harrison."

They were quiet a long time then; their plates were finished, scraped of Trish's keto breakfast, plates gleaming with grease. Occasionally, Trish would shake her head, lost in thought, probably measuring her daughter's

behavior in California. She let out a quick, heavy sigh and collected their plates.

As she went to the sink, he swished back his coffee and brought the cups along behind her, saying, "I'm looking forward to seeing her at Thanksgiving."

"Me too."

"Four more weeks."

Trish set their plates and cups in the sink and blasted the tap to hot, turned to face him, hand on her hip. "Let me make you lunch. Can I do that?"

"I can get something on the road."

"Like old times," she said, and she rubbed his arm, a weird sort of feeling, being face to face with her. He was taller than her and he'd always thought of her as being *above* him. "P, B, and J."

"Like I'm going on a field trip," he said which made her laugh. She rinsed the plates, and he took them from her, loading them in the dishwasher.

When he closed it, he looked at the control panel, not looking to run it because it wasn't full. He said quietly. "The guy she's seeing's named Tripp."

Trish was spraying the sink with the hose from the tap and she paused, water hissing against stainless. She levered the tap off, recoiled the hose. "Yeah. Tripp. I met him."

He turned to face her. "You did?"

"Sure. When I moved her in."

"He was in her room?" His voice had gone high and tense, and he instantly hated the sound. It was weak. He imagined Kelsey behind him rolling her eyes.

Trish said, "In the hall. It was crazy that day, so many kids. Not kids, sorry. People your age."

His mouth twisted to one side. "What's he like?"

She raised her eyebrows, tried to smile. "He seemed nice, Harrison."

He crossed his arms over his puffed out chest, put on a strong face. "I hope she's happy." It sounded stupid, but he was fighting feeling sad, struggling to be strong.

"I hope she is too. I hope it every day. I worry about her. She's my littlest baby."

“I worry too,” he said, scowling at the tile floor. Trish chuckled, and he looked at her sheepishly.

She narrowed her eyes on him in what he’d like to cling to as admiration. “You’re ten times the guy Tripp is, I can guarantee it.”

He smiled. “I don’t sound like a lost puppy, do I?”

She shook her head no, her mouth slimming. Her arms went around him—God, why did hugs feel so fucking good these days?—and she patted his back. She said, “You come by anytime, Harrison, just to talk or maybe just a plate of bacon.”

“I will,” he said, “thank you.” Their embrace parted, and he still felt tingles in his chest; glad now he’d come here even though he was being a sneaky devil.

Trish said, “Come upstairs with me, we’ll grab those things . . .”

* * *

IT WAS an over two hour drive north to Wolf Lake, and he stopped at the Citgo gas station in Whittemore on the way, peed in the same toilet next to the sink where he’d last had sex with Taylor, side-eyeing the spot while managing his stream. It was a beautiful fall drive, probably the last one in the car he’d bought in high school, and the place where he’d enjoyed many life experiences with his girlfriend. Maybe Kay was right. He’d bought the car to be independent, and it had worked. But now he was the only one left living in Sag, everyone else gone, just Brady around, all his *school* friends away in different states, or down in Lansing. So it pained him, but come Monday he would list the Soob and see what he could get for it.

In the back cargo, he had four Rubbermaid bins loaded with a bunch of outdated stuff Trish didn’t want in the house anymore. It was weird to be headed to Wolf Lake by himself, but there was a sense of independence again, and duty and responsibility. He had purpose here. Like he knew better for Taylor what was good for her. He would do the right thing, be the guy she needed.

It might take a while, but he was determined to be the guy who soaked her panties, too. If he could run both tactics, he would be unstoppable.

So he transferred the Rubbermaid bins into the basement of the Wolf Lake house then walked a tour around, taking his time and reflecting on this

last party just a few months before, the one that changed his life. They'd gone to Wolf Lake one too many times, maybe. The place held the charm of his childhood, but that last trip should maybe never have been taken. It had forever changed this place.

Now when he walked through the halls, he didn't think of Mr. Brooks in his fishing hat, or the awesome way young Taylor could ski, or the fun sleepover stuff. All he could think of were the bad things that had happened here.

He went to Taylor's bedroom and sat on her bed. The place where everything had changed. The place where he'd watched her with another guy. Had let it happen, just an arm's length away beyond the window, on the dangerous precipice of the sloping roof where their friends sat by the campfire below. Taylor had lured Colt Briggs up after a long evening of back-and-forth with him, practically begging the guy to make a move; Colt had come in, and the two of them got the dirty deed done fairly quick. Because, shit, Taylor had a boyfriend. And, shit, Colt was older. And, shit, Colt was her brother's teammate. And KC would've bashed Colt's head in if he found out the asshole had fucked his little sister. And that was the thing Harrison should have done. But instead he watched. And what did that mean?

He ran his hand in circles over her bedding, thinking now it hadn't even been changed since the party. These were the same sheets were she'd fucked Colt. And then, later, fucked Brady, too. And what else happened here? . . . Right on this very spot, Harrison Wade had sex with Kelsey Kay Miller. Pretty Kay, confident and dominant, sitting in his lap, riding him while his heart pounded in his throat. Was he good enough for Kay? He wasn't even good enough for Taylor. But they'd had a foursome. That had to count for something . . .

In many ways, he thought, looking around the room, everything had changed in this room that night, and he'd probably been the last of his friends to mature out of childhood and dive screaming on fire into adulthood. From 0-to-60. Only ever'd been with one girl, by night's end everything had changed for all of them.

No tears came, because he was just dead and dull, but he buzzed with *something*. It was proof he was alive.

He sniffed, stood, moved to the window and looked out at the lake beyond. It was cold out there, but there was something he'd come here to

do . . .

* * *

WHAT A WASTE OF TIME. Totally fucking freezing, and there was a good chance he could die. And it was for nothing.

The hot water better be working back at the house, because he was at the edge of hypothermia, all alone on the lake. He shook all over, and even though he'd tried to stay dry, he was pretty much soaked head to toe. Hair dripping wet, scuba mask pinched to his face, shirt off but wearing his jeans still. He'd taken a boat from the Brooks's boathouse, rowed out to the old dilapidated boat house on the island across from the Brooks's beach. This was the place where Taylor'd gone and used her hand on Stevie. Until he'd pinched her toe, and she'd reeled thinking it'd been a fish biting her. It'd ended the first of his girlfriend's dirty dalliances with other guys. But it hadn't stopped her desire for them.

Nobody even knew he was out here. If he pitched off the boat, they'd find his bloated corpse a week from now on some far shore. And it'd futile. A pipe dream. He'd scanned the boathouse's bottom with a flashlight, looking through the scuba mask and hanging over the decking that ran around the old boathouse's interior, dipping his face into the water, shining the light, looking for a glint in the depths.

It was too late now, 4:30. He'd have a hot shower, get back hopefully in time before his mom blitzed him about missing dinner.

He sat shivering on the deck, hidden in the abandoned boathouse, tossed the scuba mask aside, pushing wet hair back from his face then turned to grab his things to load them back into the boat.

But next to the scuba mask, in a gap in the planks he saw a reflective wink . . .

Chapter Three

WHEN HE GOT to Kay's house it was after ten o'clock and all the lights were off. She lived in a huge house that had probably been his favorite of all his neighborhood friends though he was in it the least. Gray brick, Gothic style—a McMansion with Tudor style wood slats on the second floor, and a black slate roof with a single turret. There were times when he was little that it made him think of vampires. He made his way through the dark to the path that led up to her front door and rang the doorbell. He heard it chime inside, stepped back. No sound, no sign of anyone home. He could be convinced she'd gone back to her dorm if he hadn't been texting with her half an hour ago.

Kay: I'm home come over

Harrison: what for

Kay: hang out

Harrison: okay

Now he heard the clack of the lock as it was switched over, and the door drew inward. It was Kay, her pink hair hanging down, black jeans, black Misfits T-shirt and bare feet. She was unusually quiet.

He said, "Why is it so dark?"

“No witnesses. Going to murder you tonight.”

“Shit, Kay,” he laughed, “that actually gave me chills . . . ”

She laughed, said, “Get your stupid ass in here,” and stepped back and waved her hand into the tiled foyer for him to join her.

He stepped inside, she closed the door behind him. “What are you doing home?”

She said, “Packing things from my bedroom so that I can bring them to the apartment.”

He said that was a good idea, and she asked him if he’d been packing.

“No, I don’t need anything.”

She nodded, said, “Where were you today?”

Knew she’d ask, and he had his story ready: “My mom needed me to do some shit up north, go visit my aunt, I went over to see Taylor’s mom and asked her if she needed me to do anything up at Wolf Lake, I’d be going pretty near.”

Kay smirked. “How near?”

“Kind of near,” he said, disarming her by admitting to one small truth at the heart of the story. “I went up, did some chores for Trish.”

Kay raised an eyebrow. “Really?”

He shrugged. “I like to be helpful.”

Kay laughed. “You like to be close to Taylor.”

“Driving further north, Kay, is actually getting *farther* from Taylor.”

She rolled her eyes, said, “Yeah, sure, *that’s* what I meant,” she said, tucked her hands into the pockets of her black jeans. “You want something to eat?”

“I already had dinner,” he said, relieved he was off the hook. Kay would be mad if she knew what he’d done.

“Snacks? We can watch a movie . . . ”

He said, “Do you want to watch Jackie Chan?”

“If you want.”

“Maybe,” he said, “or we’ll find something.”

Kay stepped ahead of him, and he followed her into the kitchen. She still didn’t turn lights on, opening the fridge and using its light to withdraw containers and see where she was putting them on the counter.

“What are we having?”

“What do you want?”

“Popcorn?”

“Microwave?”

He said, “Why is it so dark in here?”

“Conserving electricity. Practicing for when I’m in my apartment.”

“We have to pay utilities?”

“I just like it dark, all right? You need to let things go, sometimes.”

He laughed, looked around. “Is your dad home?”

“No, he went away for the weekend.”

“What’s Big Jim up to?”

“Went to grab a Hellcat to bring down for his lot, out to Detroit. Staying over.”

“Oh yeah?”

Kay eyed him, then examined a bunch of different cheeses she pulled out and were arranged on a tray, holding them up, smelling them, putting them back. “Yeah, he brought his girlfriend.”

“I didn’t ask.”

“I don’t care.”

“Okay,” he said and shrugged. “Where’s the microwave popcorn?”

“Pantry,” she said, pointing to an archway that led out on the far side of the kitchen

“Am I allowed to turn on a light?”

“Do you have to?”

“I don’t know where I’m going, Kay.”

“I like it dark, Harrison, you go throwing on lights and I have to get my eyes all adjusted again—do you *need* popcorn? Eat some cheese with me. This is good fucking cheese.”

“Yes, I want popcorn—that’s what you have when you watch a movie.”

She laughed, hefted a heavy wooden handled butcher knife and pointed it toward him. “We’re having sausage, too.”

“Ah, just like when I was a kid and I would go to the movies with my mom and dad and we’d buy cheese and sausage.”

“Elk sausage.”

“Big Jim?”

“Yeah. Six-point he got up north.”

“Okay,” he said, giving up on the pantry, “now I’m in.”

“You want to grab some Cokes, I’ll carry the tray . . .”

* * *

TOGETHER, they escorted their odd combination of movie snacks to the front hall and down the elaborate circular staircase that led to Big Jim Miller's basement—the man cave frequented by some of Sag's more illustrious businessmen, and some of the more prestigious fathers of their high school. It was a place lined with trophy heads; elk and who knows what—things with horns and antlers that were mounted on the wall. And through the study, past the home gym and sauna, was the home theater. A ten-seater complete with a velvet curtain and 100-inch projection screen. They arranged their picnic in the front row, sitting on the floor and leaning their backs on the front faces of the cushy leather loungers. Kay managed the tablet that controlled all the systems, a real live bear skin rug complete with bear face spread out between them and the huge screen. She brought up Netflix, said, "What do you feel like watching?"

"Can we talk instead?"

She set down the tablet, regarded him. "Yeah."

He stared back, said at last, "Everything okay?"

"Sure," she said unconvincingly, then adding a quick, "Uh-huh."

"You sure?"

She asked him what he was talking about and he shifted uncomfortably, said, "We're still cool and everything?"

She rolled her eyes right up to the ceiling. "I told you."

"Look, I don't want to talk about it either," he said, "it's just . . ."

"We're fine," she said, showing him a puzzled face. "I've talked to you like every day, you said you'd move in, take a room from me, and I invited you over to watch a movie . . . what more do you want, bro?"

"Okay," he said, "okay."

She said, "You're weirded out?"

"I hadn't really thought about it. I try not to think about it."

Her mouth tucked to one side, and she scowled. "It's nothing. Don't *Harrison* it up and make it something it's not."

"No, I know it's nothing, it's totally nothing, right?—it better be nothing," he said, attempting to smile.

Kay still scowled. "Gross, don't act like it was something, okay? You think it was something? . . ."

"No, it's not that, I'm not saying that, I'm—"

"I think you should just not talk about it. Everything is totally cool, so let it go," she said now, smiling meanly, chin tilting down so she could give

him a serious look from under her brows.

He chuckled, put up his hands, but now regretted even mentioning it. The days after their weird night in her dorm room bunk were uncomfortable, both of them acting like nothing happened, both of them very aware that the other was overacting in a way to make it seem like nothing was a big deal. Sometimes he thought maybe that meant it *was* a big deal. He hadn't told Taylor. Didn't know how he would say it to her. There was no way for that to come across that didn't sound wrong. And it wouldn't be just about breaking rules. It wouldn't be like if she came back at Thanksgiving and jumped into bed with Colt, the one person she was forbidden to sleep with. He was forbidden to sleep with Kay—and they hadn't—but the whole damn thing was just so . . . *weird*.

* * *

THEY TALKED FOR A LITTLE WHILE, every subject in their immediate lives, and nothing about what had transpired last Saturday. Talked about school, the gym, her dad, his parents, and how they were going to decorate the apartment. Which was pretty much just him listening to how she was going to do it, but he had little concern, anyway.

With what must have been her father's hunting knife—one with a large blade, its spine serrated—she sliced cheese. He watched her, halogen reflecting off the blade's cheek and drawing a white slash of light on Kay's pretty face, zipping up and down her chest and the large Misfits fiend skull that eyed him from her breasts.

The cheese was super salty and stinky; Kay serving it on baguettes with thin slices of elk sausage while they talked. He tried not to look at her bare feet, and her black painted toenails, tried not thinking about what it was like laying in bed with her bare legs touching him, and how he'd lay in her bed while she undressed anticipating it, and *wanting* it, too. When he looked at Kay that way, it made him think of betrayal. And he would be devastated if Taylor betrayed him—so he wouldn't do it to her.

He asked her if she was serious about doing her laundry. She said, "What makes you think I'm *not* serious about that?"

"Is there a machine in the apartment?"

"No."

“In the building?”

“Yes.”

He made a face, and she went after him. “Aw, what’s the matter, Harrison, afraid of a little hard work? Put your muscles to use.” She turned the knife around and poked his arm with the butt that looked like it might be a compass.

“Is it on the same floor?”

“The laundry?—yeah.” Now she eyed him and smiled. “I might make you use one down the street.”

“Why?”

“Cause you like to suffer.”

He ate a strip of elk sausage and sneered at her, squinting one eye, trying to make her laugh.

She gave a little chuckle, turned the knife to him again, this time blade first. She aimed it at his heart and slowly moved it closer. He didn’t flinch, stood his ground. Kay of course didn’t back down and soon the point of the blade pressed his skin.

She said, “You like to be hurt, don’t you, Harrison?” She pushed harder, and it hurt enough he thought she might have drawn blood. He knocked her knife away, grunted with the pain, saying, “Don’t.” He rubbed his chest, peaked down his neck hole to see if she’d cut him, then held out his shirt to examine if she’d put a hole in it.

“You love it,” she said, still eyeballing him, blade pointed his way.

“No, I don’t.”

“You like to be hurt.”

He looked in her eyes. “I don’t.”

“You let Taylor hurt you.”

“I guess. I don’t want to lose her.”

“So you’ll suffer for her.”

He nodded, looked away. “I will.”

Kay inhaled, let it out with a happy sound. She cut another thin slice of sausage with the razor sharp hunting knife, said, “You’re a good dude.”

“I know.”

She held out the slice for him; he opened his mouth, and she pushed it in. “You think she deserves you?”

He chewed. Swallowed. “You don’t?”

She raised her eyebrows, considering. “We put up with her because we love her.”

“We really do.”

Kay’s eyes narrowed. “She’s hurting too.”

“I sure hope not.”

“She is. She hurts all the time.”

“Why did we let her go?”

Kay cut more meat. “That cage thing, bro . . . If you love something let it free.” She set the knife on the floor next to the plate, made a bird with both hands, made it fly off.

“I want her back.”

She sneered, bounced her eyebrows. “Back in your cage?”

“I didn’t have her in a cage, Kay.”

“Tiny little cage, Harrison. You were nice putting out water and seeds and one of those stone things so she could keep her beak sharp.”

“Fuck off, Kay.”

Kay laughed, leaned and patted his cheek. “I’m guilty too. We had two cages propped up side by side, and she passed between them.”

He pulled away, stared up at the blank screen, feeling heavy and forever lost. “My life is so miserable, Kay.”

“Mine too.”

He turned his face to hers, a weird glimmering hope inside. “Is it?”

“Of course. You know how much I miss her.”

“Why did you let her go?”

“What am I going to do—stop her?”

“You could if you wanted.”

“It’s the cage thing again, Harrison. She needs to go if she wants.”

“What if she meets a new best friend out there with pink and silver hair and a salty attitude?”

“She’s not looking for a new best friend.”

He nodded. “But she *is* looking for a new boyfriend . . .”

Kay shook her head. “Not really, Harrison.”

“Is she running from me?”

“I thought so. Now I don’t.”

“Do you mean that?”

Kay nodded, then her features transformed as if a sudden revelation came on her, it wanted out but she wanted it to remain inside. She growled

and raked fingers through her hair.

“What is it?”

Kay said, “She wanted to break up with you. Then she didn’t.”

“I know.”

“She was serious about it.”

“I know . . .”

“Look, before we went up to Wolf Lake, Taylor and I kind of knew what was going to happen.”

“Colt?” It surprised him and hurt him all at the same time—a double whammy.

But Kay said, “No, not Colt. Never even thought of him.”

“Then what?”

She made a funny fish mouth, puckering her lips, looking up and away—he got the impression she wasn’t supposed to say what it was . . .

Then her eyebrows raised, and she looked a quarter his way but wouldn’t meet his gaze. She said, “Taylor was going to fuck Brady.”

It was like his cables were cut. His whole body sagged, his arm slumping and his elbow knocking against the leather support of the lounge where it was most padded. Lungs deflated, new breath was hesitant to come in. “What do you mean?”

“I planned to fuck you, Taylor would fuck Brady,” now she dusted her hands, continuing, “and Taylor goes to SC feeling free and vindicated, you guys were broken up, and—”

“What the hell?” He scowled. It was ludicrous.

Kay’s features fell—she’d been energized in the moment and now was hearing back what she’d said in the way Harrison heard it. “Mostly my idea, Harrison,” she said, “honestly.”

He glowered at her, repeated, “What the hell?”

Kelsey didn’t wilt. “Take it easy, tough guy. It was for your sake, it was —”

“How the hell is that for *my* sake?”

“To spare your sensitive feelings.” Now she glowered back at him.

He met her gaze until he couldn’t, looked down at her bare knees poking through her torn black denim. “You knew she would sleep with Brady?” When he didn’t hear her answer, his eyes raised to meet hers—she nodded, gave him a hopeful smile. He didn’t see the hope.

She said, “And I was going to sleep with you.”

The thought was bewildering. Taylor'd conspired to fuck Brady just to break up with him. But before she'd even fucked Brady, she couldn't keep the lid on her debauchery-box, jerking Stevie off and making out with him, spreading her long tanned legs for her boyfriend's worst nightmare, Colt fucking Briggs.

Kay was close, surprising him, hand brushing at his hair. "The fucking shit she went through for you . . ."

"But fucking *why*, Kay?"

"She's a beautiful mystery and I think it's hot as shit to have her break my heart."

"You're ridiculous. And she's not breaking your heart."

"She is. You think it's hot too." Now she steadied eyes on him. She touched him on his heart, this time without a knife, just the tips of her first two fingers. "How fucking awesome does it feel to have that hurt, to face how much you love someone every breath you take?"

He nodded. "That thing we did . . .? You and me . . . I can't believe you would do that for me."

"My dorm? Who says it was for you?"

"Whatever, Kelsey. It was crazy, but it was . . . it meant a lot."

"I'm a freak, Harrison. Deal with it. You're a freak too."

"Am I?"

"Definitely. It's cool."

When their strange conversation thinned, they both stared at the menu screen for a zombie movie, the trailer playing photo stills, both of them reading the description for the tenth time. Kay said, "I know something we can watch."

"What?"

She didn't answer, and he tore his eyes from the hypnotic gaze of the Netflix menu to look at her. She was staring at him, her eyes wet and shiny, large and troubled.

Only thing he could think of was a snuff movie—he flinched, then thought of porn. Kay inviting him here in the middle of the night to watch porn with him. What would he do? His fingers tingled, and his own expression looked pretty much like hers: wide eyes, grave concern . . . He said, "What is it?"

Kay's lips pursed; her features tightened. "Nothing," she said, "maybe we shouldn't."

“What is it, Kay?” he said, thinking of that Mexican cartel video that Mikey made him watch when he was in grade 10, a sicario poking a chainsaw at these two tied up guys . . .

Kay chewed her lower lip, looked away from him, grabbed a slice of her dad’s sausage and ate it.

“Is this what you brought me here for?”

“It’s something crazy.”

“What is it?”

“I talked to Taylor . . . ”

“You did—when? . . . this week?”

She nodded, but said no more.

“And . . .?”

“She sent us something.”

“Sent us a video,” he said, “is that what you’re saying?”

Chapter Four

"YEAH," she said. "For me . . . *No* . . . for you. She sent it for you, but I asked for it."

"Taylor sent me a video?" Now he started to smile, brow lowered, top half of his face pinched in a scowl, the lower half of his face brightening with an approaching joy. "She sent me a video?"

Kay nodded again. "Yeah. Look . . ."

"What is it?"

"I thought it would be good . . ."

"Can we watch it?"

"You want to watch it?"

"Kay, what the hell? . . . Of course," he laughed.

"I'm going to watch it with you."

"I don't care."

Kay pushed a canine into the plumpness of her bottom lip, looked away again. "I already watched part of it, then I stopped."

"Why did you stop?"

"Remember, I did this for you."

He watched her pretty profile; she ran a hanging silver-pink lock of her hair back behind her many-ringed ear. Slowly her eyes looked upward, her face turned toward him. When their eyes met, he instantly knew what the fuck she was talking about.

"Oh, Kelsey . . ."

She said nothing.

"What's the video?"

“You want to watch it?” Her expression was tight, her eyes eager though.

His temples pounded; he went lightheaded. Hunched forward over his crossed legs, he leaned his elbows on the insides of his knees, staring at the fur of the bear rug. “Wow, Kay.”

“I want to watch it,” she said.

“You asked her for this?” His voice had thinned to a whisper.

“You want it, don’t you?”

He shook his head, saying in a whisper that he didn’t want to see it. But that wasn’t true. So far all of this was just words and imagination—whatever happened with Taylor in California only really existed in his mind. If what he suspected was on this video was there, it would be proof positive of his most-loved-person’s behavior thousands of miles away from him. His heart hurt suddenly, and his face pinched with sadness. But a hard lusty knot tightened just under his sternum. He flexed his stomach and could feel growing plumpness in his underwear. Knuckle pushed into an eyebrow, he stared wildly at Kay’s knees now. “Okay . . .”

“I know you want to,” she said.

“No, I don’t,” he said.

“Harrison, it’s okay.”

“I don’t want to watch her have sex with . . . is it . . . Tripp?”

“Yes.”

“You watched it?”

“I did, but then I felt guilty, because it’s really supposed to be for you.”

“What was on it?”

“We’ll watch.”

He couldn’t respond; his neck had gone stiff, his mouth hung open. Kay leaned forward and put two hands on his wrist making him jump. Their eyes met again, and she said, “We’ll watch it together . . .”

* * *

KELSEY SAT nervous next to him. Both of them with butts on the floor, backs against the folded down cushioned footrests of Big Jim Miller’s fancy theater seats. Kay had her knees up, bare feet skewed inward, black painted toenails curling over. The tablet rested where her bare skin poked out of the

torn knees of her black jeans. Her eyes moved from tablet to screen as she worked the menus, getting out of Netflix and into an HDMI input. The screen went black, the room dark, then light again as the black changed to charcoal. His stomach quivered and his hands shook; he wrung them together. His skin was clammy. The sound of swallowing was like the ocean in his ears.

Kay whispered, “You ready?” He nodded.

She tapped the tablet then set it down on the outside of her, hugged her arms and watched the screen like he did . . .

And there, on the hundred-inch white space above them he saw Taylor now. Just her mouth and nose, his girlfriend startlingly close to the camera. He could tell her arms were outward, guessing her hands were on the phone like she was setting it up. That mouth was so familiar to him; he’d watched it talk, watched it eat and drink, he’d kissed it so many times; he ached to be with her. Even looming large above him now, she felt farther away than ever—his heart began to ache.

Kay sighed and hugged her legs tighter. He grimaced—Kay’s action was a telltale sign this would get worse . . . then, sure enough, Taylor moved far enough back from the camera he could see she wasn’t alone. It was hard to say where they were. The space was dark, but lit with soft nearby lights—a table lamp maybe, nothing overhead, nothing harsh. Behind her and the figure that was another man, Tripp he had to assume, he could see a lit performance playing out. With no audio accompanying, he assumed it was a TV on in the background. It looked like a concert.

He said, “Where is this?”

Kay said, “Last night. Kendall Limerick concert in San Jose.”

“But where *are* they?”

Kay waited a beat, delivered the bad news: “Tripp got a suite.”

“At the show?”

“You know his dad—”

“Works in recording,” he said, drew up his knees now and watched as Taylor on the screen, recorded last night, sashayed from the camera to return to the guy waiting for her. Tripp. Taylor had a sexy walk. A woman’s walk. Not the normal walk of his best friend, but the walk of someone looking to entice a man. He bit his lower lip, trying to convince himself Taylor was doing that walk for the person intended to watch the video. “She recorded it for me?”

“She did.”

He wished it alleviated the awful burden on his heart, but it didn’t do much. It felt too easy to believe this was all for him. It wasn’t. Taylor was in California, she was seeing another guy, and all this was to placate her old boyfriend at home. One who didn’t drive a Porsche. One whose father wasn’t in the record business. One who didn’t have a fat dick she told all her girlfriends about on the phone.

When Taylor came to the guy in the video, she put her arms around his neck, went on her toes to kiss him; the guy’s arms went around her back. Taylor looked unbelievable. Skinny but sexy legs under a black skirt—a very short black skirt—big white sneakers, formfitting black top, hair hanging down her back. But as much as his eyes caressed the form of his best friend and lover, he measured the man who she was with. Tripp Heavens had been underplayed. Taylor had made Tripp sound like a run-of-the-mill nice guy, though popular. But it was clear he was more than that. Tripp was tall, and though dimly lit, Harris could tell he was good-looking. He had blonde wavy hair. He was thin, but with a good build. Dressed cool, too; good looking jeans, a light sweater that hugged his torso, showing off his broad shoulders and narrow waist. Taylor had hidden from him Tripp’s truth.

He drew a heavy hurting sigh and his brow knit. Did she do it for him? She had to see what Tripp looked like, how handsome he was. And he was rich, too? Taylor’s ameliorating description of Tripp Heavens was meant to placate her boyfriend. Was it to cushion his feelings, or was it to lessen the burden she anticipated her overly sensitive boyfriend would then thrust upon *her* shoulders? The guilt he would heap upon her. The hurt he would attempt to shovel at her feet. In anticipation, his Taylor had tried to make this Tripp guy sound like no big deal. *You guys would really like each other, Harrison . . .* But it was clear Tripp was a big deal.

And seeing them kiss was squeezing on his heart. His neck throbbed and his eyes began to tear. He wasn’t in threat of crying, it was his body’s automatic response to such emotional trauma. The love of his life in the arms of another man. A competent, capable man. The two of them made out, mouths working over each other’s, and Tripp’s hands explored Taylor’s body. Explored like he was already familiar with all her lean curves and taut flesh. Taylor was Harrison’s property . . . or was she? Was she merely on

loan? Fuck, if he said that out loud, Kelsey'd deliver another bruise on his arm. Taylor belonged to no one, and Kay would remind him of that.

"Fuck," he sighed out loud, not knowing if he'd be able to finish watching.

Kay said, "I know . . . this is fucking crazy . . ." He could tell her mouth was dry.

"Why do *you* want to watch it?"

"I don't know," she said, "but I'm going to."

"You don't have to."

She looked his way, her face turning toward him, but when he looked, her eyes remained on the screen. She said, "Don't worry, I'm not doing it for you."

"Why then?"

"Curiosity," she said, and returned her face to the screen, chin on her knees, eyes turned up.

He rubbed his face and watched his girlfriend make out with another guy. "Is this okay?"

Kay shushed him.

"Are they going to have sex?"

"I don't know."

"You watched it."

"Jesus, Harrison, this is as far as I watched."

"Okay," he said, "I don't now if I can watch them have sex."

Kay sighed, picked up the tablet and paused the video. Above them, Taylor and Tripp embraced, Tripp's butt resting on the back side of a couch, a kitchenette maybe somewhere on the left lighting up Taylor from behind, showing the sheen on her perfect legs, the roundness of her hip and ass. He exhaled again. Kay said, "Want me to stop it?"

He shrugged.

"You want it. You *want* to watch this."

"Kay, I don't—"

"Fuck me, Harrison, you *want* to watch it."

He stared at her, saw that she was mad. "Why are you mad at me?"

"Stop lying to yourself. You *want* to watch."

He stared at her, formulated a realistic response. But it was futile. He *did* want to watch. He just didn't want to be the guy who wanted to watch.

Kay knew his thoughts, saying, “It’s fine. I want to watch. You want to watch. It’s cool . . . ”

“Just play it already,” he said, shooting one leg out, throwing his back against the leather chair. He crossed his arms and when Kay didn’t resume the video he looked to her, caught her looking between his legs. His erection was obvious. He tugged his pant leg; that didn’t work, so he pulled out his shirt to hide it. “What are you . . . doing?”

“Nothing,” she said, her eyes moving from his bulge to his eyes. “I’m just trying to tell you it’s cool.”

“I never know if you’re fucking with me or not.”

“I’m not fucking with you tonight, Harrison, this is a big deal.”

“You’re telling me,” he said, folding his arms tighter, expression shrinking into surly.

Kay resumed the video, and up above them Tripp and Taylor continued to make out.

Kay said, “I watched this far, but it felt weird.”

“Why?”

“It’s not for me, it’s for you.”

“What did Taylor say when she sent it?”

“I’ll tell you *later*—Jesus, Harrison, what does it take for you to shut up and watch this god damn thing?”

He made a growling sound, scratched his hand through his hair. The video continued, Tripp and Taylor getting more into it now. More hand movements. Taylor got higher on her toes so she could whisper in Tripp’s ear. Tripp nodded, rested his hands on her hips. Taylor leaned her body against his, kissing his neck now. He caressed her hair, and Harrison feared he knew where this was going. “Oh shit,” he whispered.

Kay said, “She’s going to go down on him.”

“Fuck,” he said, making fists, pushing them into his cheeks and peeking over his knuckles at his girlfriend lowering onto her knees at the feet of another man. Taylor crouched, working Tripp’s jeans open, popping the button, Tripp helping her out, doing down his fly.

Here it comes . . .

Taylor’s hand went inside Tripp’s pants, pulled out a whopper of a half-hard dick. “Fuck,” he said again.

Kay stiffened next to him. Tripp’s cock was club-like. It was rim lit by a table lamp somewhere behind them, Kendall Limerick jumping around on

stage behind Tripp's back. The thing between his legs was a fat dick like Taylor had described, and once again Tripp had been underplayed. Harrison's own dick wasn't competition for Tripp's. He saw it only briefly before Taylor began to kiss it and run her tongue over its shape.

In his periphery, Kelsey Kay's toes curled tighter.

Taylor's knees went out wider, and she gripped the base of Tripp's cock, put it in her mouth. It wasn't even like Taylor. It looked like somebody else. From behind, he could pretend it wasn't his girlfriend. Some other hot girl with a skinny body and beautiful hair. But occasionally he would get a glimpse of her profile and be instantly and ultimately reminded that, no, this was *indeed* Taylor Brooks.

He rubbed his temples and watched. Taylor sucked him off, doing a good job, pleasing him. Tripp's hands caressed her hair, his head rocked back and forth, sometimes rocking right back till his face turned up to the ceiling when Taylor did something particularly good that he liked. "Jesus," he sighed wanting to run out of the room but glued to the spot.

Then Taylor's mouth was off, and she was looking at the thing in her hand, stroking, her fist swirling, his big dick shining. Harrison ventured to the room a plain statement: "That's a really big dick."

Kay was holding her breath; she exhaled, said in a tight voice, "That is a big dick."

"Fuck," he said, feeling a squeezing cramp in his side. "Is it?"

"That's a pretty big dick, Harrison."

"Is it really?"

"You're looking at it."

"It's . . . not what I expected," he said.

Kay said, "It's kinda sweet she said you might be bigger."

"Longer."

Kay studied what Taylor jerked off. "I don't know . . . maybe." It felt strange that his friend knew the size of his dick, stranger to have her comparing it to the one on screen. Now she asked, "Is that bigger than Colt's?"

"Fuck, Kay," he said.

"What?—you *saw* it."

He rubbed his hands through his hair. "It's not bigger than Colt's."

Kay still watched the screen, and now he felt a weird jealousy that his friend admired another guy's dick. She said, "Guy's got a good-looking

dick.”

“Shit,” he said, “are you doing this on purpose?”

“I’m not doing it on purpose, Harrison—you *want* the plain truth.”

“Yeah, I do.”

“It’s not the *biggest* dick in the world, but it’s pretty great. A girl could jam with that.”

“Taylor told you how she likes it?”

“Yeah, she does.”

His stomach cramped thinking of the two girls in his life on the phone together talking about some other guy’s dick, thinking how Taylor might gush over another man’s sexual organ. “Fuck,” he said, shifting and wincing, “and she’s . . . And that’s . . .” Words escaped him, and he could only gesture up at the screen.

Kay looked his way. “What are you trying to say?”

“This isn’t like when she fucked Colt. It’s not like a once and done, or like with Brady . . .”

“This guy’s got a way bigger dick than Brady.”

“I know, okay—I’m not talking about dicks, I’m talking about Taylor. How Taylor likes this guy’s dick and *knows* it, like *really* knows it . . . she’s been with him a bunch of times, and she’s talking about it to you, and look at her the way she is, you can see she’s into this guy . . .”

Kay studied him for a few beats while he was quiet. “Don’t you want Taylor to be happy?”

He groaned again, made fists and rubbed them on his rib cage, driving his back against the leather lounge. “I do, but . . .”

“Just enjoy it, Harrison, she’s about to have sex with a nice guy who took her out for the night, so what he’s got a big dick . . . Don’t you want her to have a good time?”

“I know,” he said, closing his eyes for a moment to shield against the pain but then snapping them open again because he didn’t want to miss a single second.

“So, just relax. It’s already done, she fucked him last night. She fucked this hot guy, she was thinking of you, making a video to send . . .”

His head slumped to one side. “Did she make the video for me or to send it for me?”

“What’s the diff—oh, yeah . . . No, Harrison, she made it *for* you, okay? . . .” She gently punched the side of his thigh.

Some of the tension in his chest released. It was true. She'd done this for him and that had to mean something. "Tripp doesn't know . . ."

"Fuck if I know."

A weak and reluctant smile tugged his mouth to one side. "She did this for me."

"Are you going to talk through the whole movie?" Kay moaned, Taylor putting Tripp's big fat cock back in her mouth.

"What's the point of watching this together if I can't fucking talk it out with you?"

"Sorry," Kay said, eyes still turned up to the screen.

Taylor had her mouth off again, jerking Tripp, looking up and saying something to him. Maybe Tripp's *wasn't* much longer than his own. But Kay was right, it was a good-looking dick. Impressive. Even the fact that he had a foreskin wasn't that bad. He didn't know what to expect, the way Kay talked about foreskin made it sound like it would be a gnarly thing. But it wasn't, sometimes it was like it wasn't there. But every once in a while, Taylor would form a pucker on the end of Tripp's cock, use her lips to pull closed the foreskin then examined that single eye peeping out at her before kissing it again. And the cock head might've been the worst part; it was huge, plump—a shining flesh army helmet. Try as hard as he could, he could go to the gym every day, watch what he ate, but he would never unzip something from his pants that Taylor liked as much as she liked Colt's . . . and now Tripp's. Shit, he wasn't even better than Brady. And what the fuck?—he wasn't even small. He was just normal.

He groaned again, narrowing his eyes, Taylor getting to her feet, climbing up Tripp's body, Tripp gripping her above the elbows to help her stand. They kissed, Tripp's wet cock pressing into Taylor's ribs.

She whispered something in Tripp's ear . . .

Chapter Five

THE LOOK of puzzlement on Tripp's face when she requested he wear a condom stuck with her. What would he be thinking? They hadn't used condoms before . . . *Was Taylor sleeping around?* That's what he would be thinking. He would be thinking she'd just had a one-night stand with some questionable partner, now she was worried about passing something on. So what did she say? She whispered in his ear reminding him she'd just been on the pill for a bit, and she got weirded out. Worst part about that excuse was to him Taylor Brooks *could* be that kind a girl to get weirded out by something. Have a strange mental reaction. She was the kind to be mental over something . . .

But it didn't matter, the awkward moment was over, and Tripp—good guy that he was—agreed to wear a condom she'd brought him. And that'd been a weird chore . . . Going down to the Condom Co-op and buying an eight-pack of Magnums. But she watched him now, standing there with his dick poked out of the fly of his jeans, smiling at him, leaning her butt on the high table and flexing her legs, shoulders up high and giving him her best *I want it* face, and it seemed he'd forgotten the weirdness of the condom request, because he was smiling now, too, tearing open the gold foil pack and plucking out the rubbery disc of the condom.

She lurched off the table, kissed him again, took the condom from him, pinched the reservoir tip, tested the direction of the roll, and then with her tongue in his mouth her hands sought blindly between them his dick, caressed it, plopped the end of the rubber down and rolled it as best she could making sure the camera caught it all. It was a performance for

Harrison, but there was trepidation—hoping Harrison wasn't watching it now in his bedroom and analyzing every little movement, trying to figure out why she and Tripp had that weird exchange about the condom. Detective Wade was on the case, and she was sure she would hear about it. *Are you always wearing condoms? You sure, promise me . . .* Yes, I'm wearing condoms she would have to tell him. And from now on she would. One simple rule . . . If she wanted to be with Harrison, and she did, and she wanted to be with other guys, and she did, that would mean she and Harrison were open. And being open, despite the openness, drumroll please . . . Meant there were rules to follow. This wasn't a free-for-all. She'd be a good girl from now on. Be a very good girl.

So with the condom on, she cupped Tripp's neck, her fingertips slippery on his skin with the greasy condom's lubricant. He caressed her arms, hands going to her waist, then clutching her ass and hoisting her up to his hips; she threw her legs up and locked them around his back. He walked her three steps, bypassing the table, and she hoped wherever he was taking her the camera would see. He popped her butt down on the back of the couch, his thighs between her legs. The camera sat on a shelf and their action would be caught here . . . She resisted smiling at the camera, an unsure feeling making her uncomfortable, like it would be for Harrison, but if she and Tripp were to watch this together later, Tripp would see in her eyes she was communicating with her boyfriend back home in Michigan.

She pushed Tripp's jeans down while they kissed, and he pulled her top off. She squeezed her arms together, presenting her breasts in their black bra and he kissed her collar, kissed the softness of her meager cleavage, hands going behind to unhook. He pulled away her bra, and now she was topless. Her nipples ached, and she put her arms together again, curling her hands on the top of the couch where she sat, pushing her breasts forward, hoping Harrison was getting a good look at how hard her nipples were. It was wild; wild to think that this would turn Harrison on. It was still hard to take sometimes. Hard to believe. And the things Kay told her . . . Told her how much he liked it. Told her he wanted to watch . . .

She would do that. She would show him . . .

Tripp's hand went up her skirt, fingers curling under the front side of her panties, and she lifted with her arms until her butt was up off the couch, squeezing her knees against Tripp's hips. The panties were shimmied down her thighs, and she laughed, putting her legs together as he stepped back

and threw them on the floor. Instead of returning for another kiss on her mouth, Tripp dropped down between her legs and kissed the inside of her thigh. A loud, surprised moan escaped, and she wondered if it would be heard on the camera. The buzz of the Kendall Limerick concert still burred through the hard edges of the executive suite. Mostly bass, lyrics vague but detectable.

The feel of Tripp's mouth on the inside of her thigh caught her off guard. Now she leaned forward, watched him work his mouth to her center. Her breath came quicker, and she ran her nails on his back, then crawled fingers to pull up on his sweater. Tripp removed it while he kissed the shapes of her mound, never breaking stride, losing contact only briefly to throw his shirt away. He was topless between her legs, shoulders warm against the insides of her knees.

And then his tongue touched her and it was like she was zapped. She jolted, breasts jiggling. Tripp chuckled, feeling her tense movement, the sougling of his breath against her wetness feeling so fucking amazing right now . . .

* * *

NEXT TO HIM, Kay gasped a quiet, "Oh wow . . ."

His eyes were wide, pulse pounding up his neck, the muscles and tendons seized tight. He watched another man use his mouth on his girlfriend. Watched how his girlfriend loved it. Watched Taylor run her fingers through the other man's hair, watched the movement of the man's head between her legs. Tripp's hands squeezed Taylor's beautiful thighs, gripped her knees, moved to her waist as he ate her out. Taylor's chin nodded forward, then back.

There was a snap in the home theater, followed by the sound of a zip. He still watched, but now his ears were tuned to the rest of the room. There was no real audio input from Taylor's video, just a throbbing drone, a rap bass beat that hummed and bumped under Tripp and Taylor's actions—but his ears detected new sounds now, and then movement . . .

He looked to the side, could see Kelsey pushing down her jeans, black fabric scrolling downward, bare white thigh being exposed. She pushed them down over the knobs of her knees, but had to turn them inside out to

get them off her feet they were so tight. She didn't look his way, said quietly, "Too hot."

Now his heart pounded harder. This awful lurid heartbreaking display looming bright and awful above him; next to him, a sudden unexpected promise of something else. A replay of what they'd done in bed together. He already began to form protestation.

Oh no, Kay, we can't . . .

No way . . .

It was just that one time . . .

We can't do that again . . .

But now his hands came together at his waist, and he unbuttoned his own pants. He didn't dare move them down, but popped the button loud enough so Kay would hear—if she didn't want to do anything, she would let him know right away. Up on the screen, Tripp continued to eat Taylor out, Taylor continued to love every lap of Tripp Heavens's tongue. Kay said nothing. He did down his zipper, eyes widening further. *Kay could help him jerk off. He would bite her inner thigh again. He would love to bite her inner thigh.* But he had to watch what was on the screen. If he could jerk off while he was watching and Kay was sitting next to him . . .? Well, he didn't know how he would deal with it, but he wanted to find out.

In the slowest, least provocative movement possible—trying to be unnoticeable—he pushed his pants down, leaving his underwear on, getting them to his knees.

Next to him, Kelsey: "Too hot?"

"Yeah," he said, his jaw stiff.

* * *

TRIPP ROSE from between Taylor's thighs, loomed over top of her. Her knees poked out on either side of his hips, and they looked in each other's eyes. That was worse than watching him go down on her. Something was said between them, and when Tripp moved to kiss Taylor, she laughed and moved her face away, brushing at his mouth with her hand. She didn't want to kiss him with his lips wet from her pussy.

Kay laughed. "Typical Taylor."

"She doesn't like that," he said.

Kay looked his way, and he expected to be scolded, but instead saw an expression of curiosity, like that was interesting to know.

He shrugged and said, "She doesn't."

They both watched the screen again now, Tripp's hands behind Taylor, tugging at her skirt, probably unzipping it. Taylor slipped off the couch, hands caressing Tripp's arms as he pushed her skirt downward. She shimmed her hips, and it fell around her ankles. She lifted her feet out of her skirt, totally naked now except for her big sneakers.

Kay said, "She really likes those sneakers."

"She looks smoking hot in them," he said, defending Taylor.

Kay agreed. "She does."

Taylor had unbuttoned Tripp's pants, and they dropped as well, but he took his shoes off before he stepped out of them. Now he was naked. Light gleamed on the round muscles of his back. He looked more muscular than Harrison would've anticipated. Must've been the dramatic lighting in the executive suite. They made out again, then Tripp slowly shifted Taylor backward until the backs of her legs touched the couch. Tripp helped her butt up onto the couch again and she opened her legs. He fingered her while they sucked mouths. Then he lowered, sagging his body weight against the couch and dipping at the knees.

"He's going to fuck her," Kay said.

"I know." It was obvious.

Both Taylor and Tripp watched as Tripp gripped his erection, stroked it against Taylor's opening, fixed it inside her enough that he could rest both hands on the couch, touched his forehead to hers as he slowly pushed himself inside her. Taylor hugged him, thumped her chin in that muscle between his neck and shoulder. As Tripp eased himself inside her, Taylor's face went through elastic changes of hurt and pleasure. It was awful, and Harrison looked away . . . but just for a moment. It was enough to see Kay almost *mimicking* Taylor's face, mouth hanging open, eyes wide and wet.

He wrung his hands together, heart twisting. Here he was a lone *nice* guy plopped in the lives of two beautiful girls with whom he'd grown up, both of them moving beyond him. Even the one that belonged to him. Kay watched with excitement as this good-looking Tripp and his dropped designer jeans put his large cock in Taylor. It was like the guy had control of two girls's sex drives. He gritted his teeth and tried to shake the ugly thought away.

Now Tripp began to fuck Taylor. His ass muscles slowly flexing, round humps bulging and releasing, pushing his thing in and out of her. Taylor hugged herself to Tripp, and for the briefest moment her face moved to the camera and her eyes connected with his. He hitched a breath. He was sure he heard Kay hitch one as well. Taylor was looking at both of her friends in Michigan.

Taylor bit her lip, smiled and closed her eyes. The moment was gone—a strange elusive connection between them reaching through time and space.

Chapter Six

IT FELT good to be in Tripp's embrace. Felt good to reciprocate, put her arms around his warm body. Tripp was such a pleasure to hold. Hard and strong, masculine, but not pumped up, not too much. And his dick was incredible. Perfect. No pain, just a little stretching, the right amount, deep but not too deep; the head large and plump, getting her deep in the pocket and spreading her wide.

"You feel so good," she told him, rubbing her hands on his back.

"You're incredible," he told her.

"Keep going," she whispered, "I could do this all night."

He bit her neck, told her they would. It delivered a strange feeling of welcome, or acceptance. Tripp accepted her. Everyone else at Santa Cruz had some problem—probably instigated by Makayla. But Tripp got to know her. She let him in, because . . . he was Tripp. And here in this stadium suite in a weird time travel way she was also with Harrison.

This was openness. This was togetherness. If what Kay said was true, Harrison *wanted* this. How perfect was that? If Harrison could watch this and love her, all would be right. But there was something wrong, and she knew it . . .

The bad news came up from behind her and slipped a black hood over her head, bad thoughts throwing her into a panel van and taking her to do terrible things to her.

Tripp didn't know what she was doing. Tripp had no idea. Tripp wouldn't *want* this.

“Fuck,” she squeaked, doing her best to make it sound like this wasn’t another Taylor problem, it was just the amazing fucking he was giving her . . .

* * *

THE WAY TAYLOR and Tripp moved together bothered him. They looked good. They looked . . . *practiced*. That was it: this wasn’t their first time, and it was obvious. They knew how each other worked. Knew what each other liked. Didn’t have to talk and ask if everything was okay. Tripp knew how to put it in Taylor . . .

For fifteen minutes they watched Tripp make love to Taylor. That’s what it was, making love. Not that power-fucking or sport-fucking Colt had given Taylor in her Wolf Lake bedroom. This wasn’t some dominant asshole trying to throw down and be a girl’s *ultimate*. Tripp was bad news. The guy was a lover. He did things right. He cared for Taylor, cared about her pleasure. He supported her back when he thought she might have arched too far. He stroked her legs. When they’d change positions, Tripp guided her, helped her to be comfortable as they did their balancing act on the back of the couch. And the crazy thing was it was all performative. This was Tripp working under the conditions Taylor had set. Taylor told him she wanted a video, and Tripp was giving her what she wanted.

Tripp had Taylor’s legs to one side, her thighs together, him going into her, holding her neck and kissing her. Both of them gleamed with sweat, Tripp’s muscles bulged with the effort it took to make love to her and keep her from falling back over the couch. What would it be like if there was no camera? How good was Tripp with Taylor when they were comfortable, both of them flat in bed, not trying to look good for a video? How great was their sex then? Because it was really good right now, and Taylor had handicapped themselves for her boyfriend-in-Michigan’s sake. So her boyfriend could watch when it was all done. It was a strange, *obverse* thought. Ugly on the front face, when you first looked at it. But you flipped it over and on the other side there was plenty of good. It was all the same coin. All the same truth. Good and bad. Just like Taylor. Shit, just like him . . .

Kay sighed an uncomfortable, frustrated sound, and he was aware of her movement in his periphery. She'd been watching with her knees up, naked from the waist down, rubbing the back of her neck a lot. He watched her profile for a moment. Pretty Kay, soft and feminine, beautiful eyes with a hard penetrating stare that could threaten. But from the side she was so innocent. Silver hair hanging down, the tips bright in hot pink. Her cheeks blushed and her eyes were wet. Even the tip of her nose had gone pink. It reminded him of her excitement when she and Taylor and Brady and him had engaged in the foursome on Taylor's bed. This was Kelsey Kay aroused. It was kind of startling to see her this way. For someone so hard and confident, Kay *aroused* was a vulnerable thing. He smiled watching her, felt sudden warmth. He reached over, not even scared. He just touched her elbow. She bit her lip, looked his way, ran hair back from her face. She smiled, whispered, "How can you watch this?"

"You practically made me," he said. "How can *you* watch it?"

Kelsey did a bashful thing. She looked down, looked away. Then she tilted toward him, and her legs opened, one knee up, one down, very near his own thigh. She wore black panties, and he was disappointed she wasn't naked like he'd thought. She looked past her shoulder now, up at the screen again. Tripp supporting Taylor to get her sneakers on the ground, turning her around, Taylor folding over the back of the couch, showing off her narrow but round ass.

"Holy shit," Kay said, "look at her."

"She's so beautiful," he said.

Without looking at him, her hand touched his leg, and though he'd expected from himself an exhortation of protest, he gave none. Only looked down to see her black fingernails work under his T-shirt, begin to pull on the waistband of his underwear. He looked at her, but she watched Tripp and Taylor. He waited to see what she would do.

She said, "Take them off if you want," and tugged one side of his briefs down his hip though he still sat. It squashed one of his balls, tightened the cotton on the head of his erection. His stomach hardened; he grunted, spewed pre-come. He took them off because he *did* want. Balled his underwear and sat next to his friend with his still-hidden erection bumping out his T-shirt. But Kay paid it no mind, face still turned up the action on the screen.

Tripp dipped at the knees again, lined himself up and gripped Taylor's waist as he pushed himself back inside her, Taylor bent over the couch and helpless, being taken from behind.

Kay swiveled to face the screen again, but now she put her hands on the floor, shifted her weight to move closer to him. She hooked thumbs in her panties, pushed them down her legs. Now she was next to him naked, her crotch hidden under her generous Misfits shirt. His heart pounded, wanting to remind her not to get too close, but then again, wanting her close. She moved until their naked hips touched, and he said nothing, let her sit with him . . .

* * *

GOD, what would Harrison see? Was this hot or was it terrible? Her toes on the floor, her body weight folded over the couch back, its hard ridge pressing into her stomach . . . Harrison would see Tripp's ass. *Is that okay?* She tried flexing her thighs, hoping Harrison liked that. She even lifted one foot up, hoping it would make her butt look good as Tripp fucked her.

Tripp slowed, and she moaned to let him know everything was good. He kissed her back, ran his hand in a circle between her shoulder blades then stood, eased himself from inside her. She waited for guidance, but when nothing came, turned to find him crossing naked over the executive suite, cute butt flexing, going to the shelf for her phone. The phone her father had bought her. She hid her face in her hands a moment, then forced a smile and pushed back her damp and heavy hair. Tripp returned, face down, watching her phone. He looked good. The way his body moved excited her. His wide cock bobbed out ahead of him dancing with his stride.

She asked him, "What are you doing?"

He smiled, eyes still on the phone's screen. "Don't you want point-of-view for our video?"

She smiled, thinking about it. "I do . . ."

Chapter Seven

FOR A MOMENT he wasn't sure he could watch this. Top down and personal . . .? Was he prepared to get a firsthand view of another man's penis going inside his girlfriend as if it were his own? Before he'd glanced away, the camera had jostled, bouncing all around Taylor's naked body, showing flashes of bare skin; arms, legs, a navel . . . Taylor was getting off the couch's back and Tripp was trying to film her while it seemed he guided Taylor around so they could combine their bodies on the comfort of the couch's seat rather than balancing on its narrow spine. He looked away, stared at the velvet drapery that framed the closest side of the screen.

Last time he was here in the Miller home theater, if he remembered right, was high school, maybe grade ten or eleven. Party at Kelsey's, but not a rager, about ten kids watching movies and keeping it cool. Kelsey's mom had passed away before Harrison moved to Sag; Kay must have been four or five. She was an only kid and her dad her only parent, and Big Jim had intimidating presence. Enough that his daughter carried some of it around. He could remember that party, all those kids there, some of them even using coasters, none of them daring to bring alcohol into Big Jim's home, but still wanting to hang with cool Kelsey Kay. He chuckled now at the thought in retrospect, the chuckle fading as retrospect became juxtaposition. His eyes returned to the screen to see Taylor, naked except for her sneakers, situating her bare ass on the leather couch seat, making eye contact with Tripp somewhere just above the camera's lens. She smiled in anticipation, ready for more fucking, a grown woman now, no longer the kid that cuddled up with him here watching Pixar movies, boyfriend and girlfriend squashed

into the same leather lounge chair, Harrison proud to show off to their friends that he and Taylor were a couple.

And next to him now, a brand new Kelsey Kay; mature and intimidating but also held in fresh appreciation. The juxtaposition showed everything changing around him, some of it good, some of it awful and profoundly hurting. Beside him Kay sat watching Taylor, her best-friend-forever, sitting low on the couch, head tilted forward, shining chestnut hair spreading over caramel leather, occasionally the camera dipping low enough they got a glimpse of her shining and shaved pussy, blushed rosy from fucking. Kay sat with her knees up, feet turned in, eyes wondrous, and her hands were tucked between her legs. The last year had them all changing. *Fuck, look down, Harrison, your own pants are off, you're touching your dick with Kay next to you, sitting here acting like it's only the girls who're changing . . .*

Worst thing about Tripp holding the camera now instead of it watching wide-screen from a distance was they could hear their voices, Tripp telling Taylor how fucking hot she was, Taylor liking it, cocking her head and making a face for the camera that reminded him of the way porn stars acted.

Kay said, "I thought he'd have a deeper voice."

Harrison shrugged and shook his head, his expression going slack, the sound of the other man's voice disheartening him now.

Kay still talking: "She is so fucking hot, huh?"

"Yeah."

Taylor's bashfulness on camera, this coy porn girl act—was it playfulness with Tripp, or what was it? Taylor knew Harrison would watch, was there shame for how Harrison would see it? Or was the porn girl act *for* Harrison . . .? Or was it something else, too, that was something he had to consider. It'd only ever been him and Taylor naked together for sexual intercourse, and she hadn't been with anybody else till last August. She wasn't a porn star, wasn't a girl who'd fucked a lot of guys (though maybe she was on her way and that was a tangential thought that was sinking his stomach while he still sorted it out). Maybe Taylor was self-conscious on camera, and not knowing how to act when filmed having sex this was just the best she could come up with regardless of who the performance was for—like it wasn't for him, it wasn't for Tripp, it was just a matter of how else would a girl act trying to be a turn-on while she's naked? . . . It was hard to reckon her mindset with the time difference since this wasn't happening live; what was Taylor thinking last night when it was just her and Tripp?

Tripp got the camera close to Taylor's face now, and she didn't shy away, those big beautiful shining grays trembling into her phone's camera as Tripp told her how hot she was again.

"Get some new material," he lamented, Kay chuckling and supporting his grumpiness.

Kay and him looked down through the camera's eye seeing Taylor the way Tripp saw her last night, all lean young woman body, ribs against skin, tight navel, her small teacup breasts perfectly shaped and jostling with her movement, her quarter-size pink-brown nipples hardened with arousal. Taylor above him was larger than life, her face two feet in height, her beauty blown up in bright pixel light that while satisfactory was still a pale comparison to her beauty in real life, that electric charge that came from being near her missing.

Tripp's voice through Big Jim's expensive theater speakers: "You ready for it, Michigan?"

Kay chuckled, and he was glad to hear her go for it first; he chuckled harder, hoping to get it rolling, the two of them in unison making fun of Taylor's California boyfriend with the Porsche, the connections, the big dick . . .

But Kay's laughter stilled, something on the screen getting her attention.

Tripp had lowered the camera, now his cock visible too, hovering between Taylor's legs, blotting out the sight of her pussy, the wet pink part of her peeping at them sometimes from around Tripp's fat condom-sheathed cock.

"Michigan," Harrison repeated, making fun of Tripp's dumb nickname for Taylor, hoping he could coax Kay's attention. But now Tripp pushed his erection down, stroked its belly across Taylor's slick sex, and Taylor responded with mewling sounds of arousal, a sure sign she wanted his big dick back inside her. Now the nickname Michigan didn't seem so stupid. It seemed *personal*, and obviously Harrison would never call Taylor that since they both came from Michigan. Taylor probably liked being called Michigan, probably liked having a cute pet name that reminded her who she was, and at the same time showed she was with someone who *wasn't* from the same dumb place she grew up. It probably reminded Taylor that Tripp was *not* from Michigan, that Tripp was from sunny California where it didn't snow, and you could drive your precious German sports car year round under the palm trees never once thinking how you'd have to store it

for the season, or maybe get snows on before the first fall, make sure you had chains in your trunk . . .

His heart sank knowing Taylor's boyfriend had a name just for her.

And now Tripp ran his hips back, nestled the crinkly reservoir tip into the nest of Taylor's membranes, and Taylor's hands gripped her own thighs. The large plump glans sunk inside her opening, the reservoir tip scrunching up around her clit before finally getting swallowed up inside her, and Taylor made a low breathy sound that let him know fucking Tripp felt amazing.

Tripp's voice: "You ready?"

"Yes, Daddy," Taylor said then giggled, the sound horrifying, making him sink low against the chair, getting his brow to drop.

"Gross," Kelsey whispered like it was to herself, and he couldn't have been more glad to have her with him; if he'd watched this alone, there were parts that may have burned him alive. Taylor calling Tripp Daddy would have left him gutted on his bedroom floor.

He nudged Kay's elbow in a gesture like two buddies were in some shit together, but Kay made no response, face still turned up to watch that big dick sink into Taylor's guts. The nudge against Kay's arm also proved to him that Kay's hands were indeed between her legs and wanted to be there; Kay was playing with herself too.

On the big screen, Tripp panned up from where his manhood sank into Taylor, running up her flat stomach, over her breasts to her face. Taylor's expression showed lust; brow pinched, eyes mournful, her lips parted as Tripp fucked her now, her head rocking on the leather. She gasped and panted, looked to Tripp and said, "Oh baby, you're so, *so* big . . ."

* * *

THE BALANCING WAS TOUGH. The act of recording her sex with Tripp was walking a weird fine line she didn't like to consider too much. It reminded her of cooking an omelette, the way her dad would do on Sunday mornings back when she was little and it was a dark winter morning and he was making breakfast before taking her and Riley to figure-skating. She could picture him at the stove with Trish's apron on, shuffling the pan and then wrist-flicking, the omelette doing a heavy flip and landing on its back. Sex with Tripp tonight should be all about Tripp. He'd been so awesome

bringing her out to San Jose, getting her into the concert, and it was kind of disrespectful to record them having sex for Harrison's benefit. Like that omelette, one second she was cooking one side, happy, then *flip*, she was upside down thinking of Harrison. It wasn't terrible. If this was her biggest problem, hell, she was doing pretty well in life. A guy in California showing her a good time, and a guy at home thinking about her every day and loving her even though she didn't deserve him . . .

With a quick head shake, she disengaged that thought from the destination its track would lead and now—*flip*—she focused on Tripp, fucking her, holding her phone between them and watching himself fuck her on its screen. Her legs draped his hips where his thighs spread wider, his stomach flexing. He didn't have a set of abs like Brady or like Colt, but he was toned. *Oh fuck, remember Stevie?* . . . He might've had the best body in his own way. She'd touched his abs when they made out in the boat house and it got her so wet it felt like she'd sat in something. What Tripp lacked in abs he made up for in confidence, humor, and general stellar charm. Stevie couldn't string two ideas together, Brady couldn't help him. Colt was smart, probably, but an asshole (which was charm in a different form). But Tripp was something else altogether. He made her feel special. He made her feel special in a place where she felt small. *But wasn't she supposed to feel small here, didn't she come here to feel small?*—no, not small, but . . .

She wanted the camera, so she reached out a hand, gave Tripp a face to let him know she was being fucked right (and it wasn't faked, only conjured), took the phone from him and fumbled it around to watch through the viewfinder. Only now, though she'd intended to capture what a wonderful view she had in this position, looking up and seeing this hot guy between her legs, the idea of committing his face to video and transmitting it to Harrison felt like it violated Tripp. Though she'd already captured his face, she was sure, in her shelf-positioning of the camera, to do it up close and personal like this seemed like a wrong committed against a really decent guy. *Flip*. Shit, now she was thinking of Harrison again.

For her boyfriend in Michigan then, now she filmed Tripp's stomach between her thighs as he fucked her. Caught the ripple of his tight flat belly, the tangled treasure line from his belly button to his cock. Big cock. She'd even made sure to compliment Tripp's size—for Harrison's benefit. That was easy because she knew Tripp would appreciate it, so that was a definite win, helping out two guys at once. Kelsey told her it would turn Harrison

on to highlight Tripp's larger size, and she saw it herself anyway, saw it in the way Harrison lusted after her when she'd fucked Colt. Her sweet best friend spying from her window and watching her fuck the worst guy possible . . .

"Shit, oh Tripp," she gasped now, an unexpected spate of her sex sweat surging inside her making Tripp's stroke go so slippery her scalp tingled. The idea her Harrison would lurk outside her window and passively watch Colt Briggs fuck her made her feel so wildly sexy. Her skin went to goosebumps thinking of Harrison and what he saw that night—and now what he would watch if she ever found the nerve to send this video she recorded.

* * *

KAY SAID, "I don't want to look at this guy's stomach."

He said, "Me neither."

But they continued to watch, the camera held somewhere over Taylor's breasts, shot down her tummy between her legs, Tripp's glistening stomach heaving, the camera rocking with his thrusts. Sometimes they would get a flash of the base of his cock. There was heavy breathing and panting, the crackle of the condom. Taylor moaned a high squeaky sound, purred, "Oh baby."

He said to Kay, "Can you fast forward?"

"We'll just ride it out," Kay whispered.

They were quiet while they watched, listened to the slap-slap of Tripp's thighs against Taylor's bottom now. Taylor's flesh shook; her gasps came quicker and heavier.

He looked down to watch Kay without getting caught. The curve of her knee was a small white peak, her legs shapely, her thighs squashed against her calves. The tendons rose on her feet while her toes scrunched on the floor. There was a wet sound, a crackling that wasn't the condom because it didn't come from the speakers, it came from beside him. Kay definitely pleased herself watching sexy Tripp fuck their friend. Now with his hand snuck under his shirt still, he stroked a little thinking of the possibility there could be another foursome; Taylor bringing Tripp home for Thanksgiving and all of them hooking up in his brand new apartment he shared with Kay.

He lowered a leg so he could better pleasure himself—what was Kay going to complain about, she was doing it too, and hell, she told him to take his pants off. And, shit, this wasn't the first time he'd jerked off with her near him. It was getting to be a regular thing, maybe. A good thing. Still, he kept his hand on his junk hidden under his T-shirt.

Kay glanced over and it thrilled him suddenly to be witnessed. His crotch was lit by the light of Taylor's video, the movement of his hand clearly visible.

She returned her gaze up to the screen but said, "Taylor ever tell you you've got big balls?"

"No."

"She will. Once she's handled a bunch, she'll tell you you've got some plums."

"Oh, man," he sighed, reeling from the absurd and dirty comment that also provoked an image of his girlfriend's familiar hand cradling various scrotums. "Fuck, Kay," he whined, disturbed by the imagery she'd prompted.

"Aw, I'm kidding, Harrison," she said, then correcting, "I mean, you've got a big sack and all . . ."

He lamented: "Who cares about big balls though?"

"Somebody probably cares."

He turned to regard her, Kay's arm moving, playing with herself while she watched Tripp fuck Taylor. He said, "Are you fucking around with me, or are you serious?"

"About what?"

He nudged his chin down between his legs but she wasn't looking. Quiet, he said, "My balls."

She drew a deep inhale, eyes turned up to Tripp's torso, his hands gripping Taylor's thighs now, the pounding coming quicker. She looked toward Harrison, between his legs, and his hand stilled its stroking (he had to stop, he was edging like crazy here, anyway). He was frozen, his wide eyes studying her face as she looked between his legs. Her eyebrows raised, her eyes looked sleepy; her hand squeezed from between her own legs and moved between his. He held his breath. She pulled and tugged his T-shirt upward till his erection was revealed to her. He moved his hand away so she could see it, the thing raging hard, bursting with veins, the tip thrust up to her theater's ceiling. T-shirt tucked up and away, her hand moved to his

thigh, then her clawed fingers closed on his scrotum. Her fingers were warm and damp (from her insides, he swore it was that) but his balls climbed high and rolled over in her hand.

“Don’t hurt them,” he said, still holding his breath.

She squeezed gently, ran her nails on his saggy dimpled ball skin, watching him, studying his genitals.

“Taylor likes your balls,” she said.

“Does *she* think they’re big?”

“I think so,” she said.

“She talks about me like that to you?”

“Sure,” she said, squeezing his balls, lifting them, letting them drop, holding them again.

Quieter: “She ever talk about . . . *my dick*?”

“Not really.”

For some reason he was offended. “Never?”

“Oh sure, yeah, like a long time ago.”

“What did she say?”

“Said it was nice.”

“Just nice?”

“Normal.”

It wasn’t the thing a guy wanted to hear his girlfriend divulge to her girlfriend. “How did she know what normal was?” She was supposed to be a virgin. But he supposed he knew the answer.

Kay confirmed it: “She’d seen dicks before yours, Harrison.”

It was awful. A twist turned in his stomach, and a weird erotic screw tightened behind his balls somewhere. He stiffened and his cock let out a stream of glimmering pre-come that ran down the belly of his erection. He was instantly worried, but Kay watched it and said nothing, didn’t even whip back her hand.

He swore he’d stop her from taking this too far, but in the moment he was frozen, turned to stone by this sexual Medusa he’d grown up with, his brain begging for her to grab his cock, already forming rationalizations why it wasn’t cheating on Taylor.

Pretty Kay looked at his cock, bit her lip, squeezed his balls, then let them go. He sunk with disappointment . . . but her eyes moved to his. She said, “You want to come together?”

He nodded rapid jabs.

Kay got sheepish again, turned away showing him her back and her bare ass. She got to her knees and worked out something hidden in the tight seam between her chair's seat and arm.

She sat back down and he could see she held a phallic shape in a neon purple-pink. It had a chrome base and when she twisted it, the thing hummed a low vibrato. It was ridiculous, and he should want to laugh but instead he just stared at the thing as it was eclipsed behind her thigh, Kay's knees upright again as she maneuvered the vibrator to her pussy. But she hadn't forgotten him, her hand slipping into his lap again and cradling his balls while her eyes moved to the screen. The camera jostled and spun, the viewpoint changing, both of them hoping it would turn back on Taylor.

"Thank God," Kay said.

He started to stroke himself again, the heel of his hand bumping the leather bracelets on Kelsey's skinny wrist.

* * *

IT WAS hard to keep the camera in place. Plus, Harrison would probably rather see her than Tripp—she just thought it would be nice for him to get the full tour, see what it was like from her side. But now it was weird passing the camera back to Tripp, especially since his pace was picking up (and, God, did it feel good) and he must be close . . . she was close, too—would Harrison like to see them come together?

Shit, she'd need to get the camera to Tripp soon because Harrison would not want to watch Tripp come. Or, wait, would he?

Harrison'd seen her make two other guys come; if he had a problem with other guys's cum she would have heard about it by now. Harrison watched her jerk Colt off near her face, even getting some of it in her hair, and he watched her jerk Brady off too, jerk his cock onto his stomach. Harrison had seen her only jerk guys off, but what about inside her—oh, no, he demanded condoms, that's right . . . What about coming inside the condom inside her, was he okay with that? Was *she*?

Now all she could picture was Tripp's balls flexing their contents into propulsion tubes, and she could understand as a whole Tripp's seed's excitement at its purpose, boiled up from his testicles ready for joyous release, ready to perform their duty. Then all that happiness, all that

intention swamping uselessly into the condom's reservoir tip like sad dolphins strangled in a fishing net, their potential dashed, lost forever.

And what of *her* predicament (oh, no, don't, Taylor) . . .? What about her reproductive impingement? Not just a device meant to scoop up fertilizer, but an oral chemical meant to subvert her female purpose so men could dump inside her. Her breaths squeezed in rapid hyperventilation. Tripp, encouraged, fucked her faster. Wasn't it harm? Wasn't it awful medical intervention?

Now, unbidden, she could imagine her tubes strangling, turning purple, all her eggs jammed up like cars on the freeway bulging out her fallopian tubes, her cervix coughing finally, spraying sand, dried up like someone crossing the hot desert.

"Ah," she gasped as if in pain, and now Tripp slowed, eyeing her.

Her cheeks blushed with hot strange shame. Why'd she tell him about being weirded out by her pill? A little too close to home, like she was playing cards and lowering them so other players could see. It was a trick so Harrison wouldn't see her have sex with him without protection—something she'd let slide. But it was so close to the truth, wasn't it?

It was, and now she couldn't stop thinking about it. While he pushed slower careful pleasure in and out of her, she could see a way out, a way for all to be happy. Proof she wasn't worried about germs or disease because she'd been fucking other condom-less guys on campus, Tripp's pleasure, Harrison's pleasure (she could practically guarantee this would knock him out) but mostly *her* pleasure. She wanted *something* badly . . .

With the swaying of her hips she seduced Tripp to slow, Tripp knowing she sought change of some kind. He pulled his cock out and she complained but liked the look of it on her belly. The camera stayed on his manhood as her other hand pet it, stroked his topside and Tripp humped it over her mound like he still wanted to finish inside her. And that was what she wanted too. She pinched the reservoir tip, happily empty, tugged, making it tighten, but needing to pull far back before the thing would consider budging on his thickness. Tripp held the base of his cock and let her tug free the rubber and throw it off the couch. He asked her what she was doing. She jerked his hot cock, said to him and Harrison in cold Michigan, "I want you to come inside me . . ."

* * *

THE CAMERA SPUN around in wild arcing movements again, Harrison's stomach squeezing as Taylor's words echoed in his head: *I want you to come inside me*. When the camera was still again, it had gone wide-screen, showing Tripp, the couch, and Taylor. It was obviously set on the coffee table in front of the couch, Tripp looming large on the left-hand-side foreground, bent over studying the phone, the other hand on his knee, his big dick hanging down between his legs, shining wet, eager to go inside Taylor's body again. And Taylor sat on the couch with her knees pressed together, hunched a little, looking timid, or almost worried, except for the anxious smile on her face. Where Taylor's eyes looked was obvious: Tripp's ass. Checking her boyfriend out.

He said, "She's not going to make him wear a condom?"

"She took it off," Kay said.

"I wanted her wearing condoms in California."

"Me too," Kay said.

Now Tripp was moving away from the phone toward Taylor, the two of them joining center-stage on the home theater screen, Harrison also getting a look now at Tripp's cute ass as he bent over, held Taylor's shoulders and kissed her mouth. They spoke quietly to each other, voices undetected by the microphone. Taylor nodded; Tripp nodded. Then Taylor was turning around, putting knees on the couch seat and resting her hands over the seat back. She looked beautiful naked, still wearing her shoes, her skin tanned and shining, her ass paler, stripes at her back where she'd worn bikinis. A Michigan girl. Tripp's Michigan girl.

And now he could see Tripp's luck. Tripp's excitement. Imagine being Tripp right now. Getting a girl like Taylor out to some special executive suite your dad set up, and bing-bang-boom the girl's naked and eager. Sucking your dick, opening her legs, a dirty girl like Taylor wanting to be filmed . . . "Holy fucking shit," he sighed, jerking himself faster, a tiny bell on one of Kay's bracelets beginning to sing with his movements.

"Oh, wait, I know," Kay said, some revelation coming to her. Maybe you had to be a girl to see it, because he didn't, just looking up on the screen and seeing this play out as bad as those horror movies he watched with Kay at the bowling alley.

"Know what? . . ."

Tripp got one knee on the couch, began to stroke his hands on Taylor's back, feeling her beautiful body against his palms. Kay's bracelet sang

faster, Harrison knowing exactly the heaven Tripp's hands caressed right now.

Tripp held his dick, looked down at it, then pursed his lips. A line of spit fell against the head of his cock, then he was moving closer, running that spit in the crack of Taylor's ass, taking the end of his cock and mushing it against her sex and then higher . . .

"Oh . . . now I know," he said seeing what Kay saw, a beat or two behind, his mind reeling.

"In her *ass*," Kay said.

"I guess," he said, slowing his stroke because one careless move right now would have him splashing all over Kay's hand still clutched on his scrotum. He stopped and watched. Kay gently raked her nails on his balls.

They watched as Tripp's large cock head ran circles against Taylor's anus, then he tried to guide himself into her. Taylor's white sneakers kicked, and she threw her head back. Tripp and Taylor laughed. Harrison's heart sank watching them share this funny but dirty moment. Tripp backed away, used the pad of his thumb to stroke against her anus now, running light circles around it. Both of them still laughed.

Tripp pushed against her, and the first inch of his thumb sunk inside Taylor's sphincter. Taylor's voice was thin but the cry of pleasure was obvious.

Kay laughed, said, "Oh, Taylor, you are a bad girl."

Harrison crumpled, sighing, "How can she do this to me?"

Kay gave his balls two quick squeezes, making him jump. "Don't do that," she said.

"Don't do what?" He spoke to the screen, his eyes glued watching Tripp put his dick in his girlfriend's ass.

Kay said, "Tripp's doing you a favor."

"How?"

"He's giving Taylor what she wants. From what she says he's not a jerk, he's nice to her, and she's having fun with him . . ."

As Tripp sank his large size deeper into Taylor's assuredly tight ass, Taylor cackled a pained but amused sound. Laughing and crying, kicking her bright white sneakers, the muscles in her sexy legs twitching. She crossed one ankle over the other as Tripp got deeper, one foot flexing up and down like on an imaginary accelerator.

“Oh, my gosh, this is, oh, *way* too dirty,” Kay said low and quiet, the sound of her vibrator fluctuating as she angled it forward and back, Taylor working the accelerator, Kay changing the gears . . .

Taylor gasped and threw her head back as Tripp began fucking her, his hands on her skinny waist.

He grimaced, said, “What if she falls for him?”

“She might. What if that’s okay? What if she falls for him and it doesn’t change one bit how she feels about you? It’s possible for her to love two people, it’s got to be.”

He watched Taylor up on the screen, getting it good from behind from a guy he’d like to be. It hurt his heart so bad, but he wanted that beautiful girl so bad—it wouldn’t hurt if he didn’t. And she was keeping him, wasn’t she?

He jolted as Kay put her hand around his, her hand over his hand gripped on his cock. She pumped his hand up and down, her movement clumsy but insistent. She dragged her eyes from the screen to regard him. She smiled. “See? It’s possible . . . She loves you, that’s for real. Look at her up on that screen having a real good time, and she’s *including* you. You’re one lucky motherfucker, Harrison Wade. That girl’s got you on the brain and you don’t even realize it.”

Taylor tossed her hair, cleared her eyes so she could peep over her shoulder on cue and look into the camera—their eyes met. Taylor loved him no matter if he could hear it or not. “Kay . . .”

“Oh, *now* he sees it everybody,” Kay said out loud to the room, hand leaving his cock to cup her cheek, projecting her voice like there was a big crowd gathered and she wanted the ones in the back to hear.

He chuckled, bowed his head and pressed thumb and first finger into his squinted eyes.

“Enjoy it, man,” Kay said, quieter, closer. “Taylor can love you, she can fuck Tripp . . . she can love Tripp, she can fuck you. It’s all possible, Harrison, you just got to open yourself to it. And never leave her heart. Be there for her the way you always were. But you don’t own her, okay?” Her finger poked his arm.

“Yeah . . .”

“This Tripp guy is treating her well, taking her out, fucking her with his big dick . . . if you care for her, if you love her, you should be happy . . .”

Could he be happy for her?

Chapter Eight

IT DIDN'T CONCERN her anymore what Harrison thought or what Tripp thought. Her mind was satisfied and stilled. Pure outrageous pleasure plunged in and out of her dirtiest place. She thrust a hand between her legs, ran two fingers along her greased groove and sunk them inside herself. She curled her thumb, mashed the knuckle against her clit as Tripp fucked her ass. The pounding was insane. He spread her wide, her fingers drove pleasure inside her, thumb coddling the button of her lust. All thought was extinguished. All she wanted now was to feel the wet, feel Tripp gush inside her, kick a leg up over that high pleasure-wall. And it was coming fast.

As Tripp gripped her waist, held her in place and fucked her with that big sausage, she hurtled toward the goalposts like a cannonball. She opened her eyes, closed them again, opened them. It was like her heart galloped in her chest, and soon her shoulder and the back of her arm ached from her furious hand movements. She pushed her knees wider, looked down her own stomach, being pounded *into* the couch, shoulder blade pressed against the leather seat like she was going to fold in half while Tripp fucked her.

Tripp's brownish ball pouch jiggled and jostled, and her other hand sought it. Her fingers crawled against the hot sagging skin of his scrotum and gently squeezed. Just the movement of her hand like that on him sent a gush of wet inside her. He hadn't come, but that wasn't her sex sweat back there, that was the grip she held on his sperm factory. He'd flexed them, responding to her grip, propelling lubricant into her passage, making his cock slide easy in and out and in and out.

She clutched her knees together now so she could flex her thighs, pinching her forearm against her sex, against her hand rubbing circles on her clit.

That was how she came, her head folded against her chest, crying out and blurting, practically blubbering, choking and coughing, snorting through her nose. Then Tripp was roaring, gripping her so tightly on her waist his fingers pinched her with hurt. He roared and bucked against her, his cock bulging and flexing in her anus, spreading her wider, gushing into her his seed, filling her body . . .

* * *

UP ON THE SCREEN, Tripp stabbed Taylor's ass hard, all the muscles in his arms flexing. The guy roared and Taylor cried out, turning her chin up, her profile a dark silhouette against the lit kitchenette beyond the couch. In his hand, his steely cock throbbed and flexed as he propelled to the launch off. Next to him, Kay's toy hummed, pink-purple inches teased up inside her pussy. His jaw dropped at this insanity and his ears whooshed with an ocean sound that must be his pulse.

"She's coming," Kay whispered, her voice like it was spoke through cotton padding.

And he represented the male opinion: "He's coming inside her." Just like Taylor wanted.

Tripp and Taylor both gasped and cried out with their explosions of pleasure, Taylor rocking with Tripp's thrusts, her ribs pressing skin, her head going up, nodding forward till her forehead touched leather. They never stopped moving the whole while, like the pleasure was too much it had all their synapses firing, both their attractive bodies writhing on the couch. Then they both laughed as they grew ticklish, Tripp moving against Taylor and Taylor moving with him; they chuckled and groaned and Tripp put his arms around her, hands caressing her slender curves.

"Oh shit, Kay," he said as a courtesy, letting her know he was coming.

Now his eyes turned down, watching his hand jerk furiously, triggered past the point of no return, everything inside him swelling tight with pressure. And Kay didn't retract her hand, continued clumsily squeezing his

balls. His *big* balls, as she told him, her and Taylor maybe talking about his male parts one time over the phone or whispering secrets to each other.

“Kay, fuck,” he grunted, giving her one last chance. Her grip squeezed and held, and he could see in the corner of his vision Kay watched for him to ejaculate, her knees up, her other hand working the vibrator, eyes on his cock.

His hips and ass flexed off the floor, his legs both straight, hand jerking on the hardest erection he could produce, stabbing the thing up in the air, Kay’s hand riding along with his bucking like a bronco rider, the whole while giving his testicles squeezing pressure.

He laughed and coughed as he came, so happy to produce a fireworks show if he was going to have an audience, yanking back at the last second to send hard pulsing streams (lots of them) up his T-shirt. He humped his hand, spurted it all out of him, his testicles rolling and retracting—Kay coddled his balls, wiggling her fingers. An errant tab of his semen plopped over her pinky and ring finger, filling the cup of her silver skull ring’s menacing eye socket, and still she didn’t recoil, her thumb curling back now, black nail reflecting screen light, the last three fingers of her grip closing too hard, her hand pulling on his scrotum and twisting.

“Ah, fuck, fuck,” he hissed, lifting higher off the floor on his heels and a hand so she wouldn’t hurt him.

At last she released them, and now without the hurting panic racing his mind he could see it wasn’t a desire to injure him that had her grip doing that, it was Kay’s own impending orgasm—a sight that had his heart clenching.

She chugged soft inward breath, her pretty mouth hanging open, her lips shining with tongue-licked wet. On screen, Tripp was pulling out of Taylor, her spread asshole visible only for a second before she rolled to a sideways sitting, Tripp plopping next to her, both of them still laughing, red-cheeked and eye-shiny. Taylor ran a hand through her hair, then gripped Tripp’s thick cock and jerked it a little saying to him, “I just came from anal sex, what the hell, huh?” It made Tripp laugh before he took her neck and guided her for a long kiss.

Taylor and Tripp engaged in a caring make-out session, touching arms and sucking tongues, and Harrison turned his gaze back to Kay who looked like she was seconds from bursting. Taylor pulled from their kiss, and, God, she was a beautiful young woman, all lean grace when she was naked,

smiling her white smile, happy. Fuck, she *was* happy—and it hurt only a little. Taylor ran her hands through her hair, breasts jiggling, nipples still hard, scooted forward and stretched, her ass on the lip of the sofa seat.

Harrison sidled closer to Kay, his soaking wet dick flopping against his stomach, the tip coated in a thick layer of his semen. Kay didn't move, her eyes still up on the screen, her hand wiggling and rubbing her dildo, chasing down her orgasm.

He whispered, "Want me to bite your thigh?"

"I want you to sh-shut up," she hissed, and he had to fight the absurd impulse to burst out laughing, a strange and abounding feeling of friendship for her that had him wanting to wrap his bristly pal right now in the warmest of hugs.

Taylor loomed close to the camera, and he looked up to see her face taking up most of the 100-inch screen, smiling down on her two masturbating friends in Michigan. "That was amazing," Taylor whispered into the screen and he was sure it was meant for him and not for Tripp. He smiled at the image of his girlfriend.

"Oh shit, pause it, pause it, pause it," Kay gushed in breathy urgency.

Taylor was seconds from turning off the camera, and he got it—there was nothing worse than a video ending when you were about to get what you'd been trying to earn. He leaned over her feet, ribs pressing her shins, his cum-covered hand held up and away, nudging the tablet with his clean hand—thank God, the pause button large and clearly labeled on its glass screen. Once tapped, the rushing ambient sound of an executive suite with Kendall Limerick's beat in the background ceased. The sound of Kay's personal toy buzzed loud, joined in with the soft sticky sounds of her wet pussy.

He pushed himself to sit up next to her again, grimacing seeing the wet semen mess his T-shirt had left on Kay's bare feet, biting his lip and looking up at Taylor's huge and beautiful face poised above them mid-vowel. Any other face paused unexpectedly like that would look like someone was stoned, but Taylor was plain perfect; pouting lips forming a u-sound, sexy eyes narrowed.

Kay gasped, bucked, began to shimmy next to him. He chanced a look her way, and she was so far gone in her orgasm he was able to watch her when she came. Her pouted mouth opened and closed, her eyes went slim, her lashes fluttered. Back arched, she thrust out her chest and writhed like

her body was twisted with wonderful agony. Kay was beautiful in her own right and he admired her, watching her, smiling, a sick lusty feeling squeezing at his balls just like she'd done herself a few seconds ago. As Kay came, he felt his own sympathetic arousal stirred, his cock hardening anew, and while he'd love to stroke her thigh, he left her untouched, instead watching her large soft breasts, the humps of her hard nipples pressing out the black of her Misfits shirt.

His eyes dropped lower, Kay's knees going in and out, her bare heels touching. His cock surged to full hardness as she accidentally revealed to him where the dildo entered her body. Her pink pussy lips caressed the slender toy, shining with her wet, and his heart pounded so hard he went lightheaded. Kay squeaked whispering sounds of pleasure as she rode her orgasm out, finally closing off the sight of her sex from him. He thrust himself back with a heavy exhale, eyes wide, staring up at paused Taylor, ears doing that loud whoosh-whoosh again. What a fucking crazy night . . .

Chapter Nine

WITHOUT A SHIRT, Harrison sat on the corner of Kelsey Kay's bed, both of them up in her bedroom. Kay's bedroom was a mishmash of the expected and the unexpected. Things that fit: a Cramps poster; Mexican Day of the Dead paraphernalia, printed bunting slung over her mirror, a lamp made of the cartoon skulls; saucers of rings and chains and other silver jewelry she wore; a closet door propped open, the light on and showing a mostly black wardrobe; framed pictures of her and her dad, a picture of a beautiful woman Harrison figured must be her mother—a woman with frizzy blonde hair and eyes like Kelsey, a shapely woman in jeans and an untucked white dress shirt, holding a swaddled grumpy baby, red-faced and crying, the woman laughing through the whole thing; pictures of Kelsey and Taylor, pictures of just Taylor, Taylor in one wearing sunglasses, maybe twelve or thirteen, a kid really, sticking her pink tongue out at the picture taker. The unexpected in Kay's bedroom was the basic and feminine structure her 'Kelsey Kay' things strung on, like her pretty and Victorian four-poster bed in deep almost-black mahogany, the matching dresser, and the matching vanity with spindly curved legs where Harrison would more likely picture a teen princess brushing her hair and dreaming of the prince she would marry someday, and not the silver and pink haired martinet standing now in the closet, indexing through her hung clothing.

While pulling out a sweatshirt from the messy file of her clothing, she said to him from the closet: "This shirt fit you?"

He said, "The one you're wearing?—maybe."

“It’s pretty big,” she said, doffing the shirt now, the sweatshirt held between her thighs. She chuckled it aside, standing there in a black bra, not entirely minding him seeing her partially dressed. What the hey, right? Maybe they weren’t going to be college fuck buddies, but it certainly seemed like they would be jerk-off pals or orgasm friends. She stepped out of the closet to toss her Misfits shirt in his face, her hair still tucked down the neck of the hoody.

He caught it in a hand, and she said, “You be a doll and wash that for me?—I gotta get into some comfy pants.” She nodded her chin next to where he sat on the bed. The purple-pink dildo she’d jacked herself off with lay next to him.

Once they’d both caught their breath after orgasming down in the home theater, they sat there probably dealing with their shame each in their own way. Kay sat with the dildo in her lap, the thing shiny from being inside her, her two naked legs straight out, the soles of her feet brushing the bear skin rug. Her face was turned up, both of them watched over by the frozen and perfect visage of their best friend. Sitting there like that with his hand chilled with wet semen, his dick shrinking and not exactly looking its best, he’d sat up. The front of his shirt had been messed, and he took it off, turned it inside out. Kay had watched him and he couldn’t help trying to flex his muscles even if they didn’t really show yet. He scooted down to her feet, dried them with the inside of his shirt. She’d smiled, watching him, then looked at her hand. She held it out then, and he cleaned it as well, Kay whispering a quiet, “Gross.” It got them both chuckling quietly, and the weirdness eased a little.

“Sure,” he said, but Kay was already back in the closet, and as he stood, picking up her dildo, he could see her standing with bare legs in just a sweatshirt, hands tucked up underneath, folded behind her back, unhooking her bra. He lingered, waiting to see her pull it out of a sleeve and then toss it in her dirty laundry hamper. He left her alone.

* * *

IN HER EN SUITE BATHROOM, he regarded himself in the mirror. Though his body looked no different, it sure felt different; different enough he could walk around Kay’s house with his shirt off and feel comfortable.

His muscles might look like the old style Harrison muscles, but they weren't. They were harder. They ached, and the surprising thing was they felt like they enjoyed the punishment he delivered three times a week. They wanted to transform as much as he wanted them transformed so he would be irresistible to Taylor.

When the water ran hot, he tempered it with some cold then used soap to scrub her dildo, wondering if this one was her favorite. Did she have more than this one, or was this the only one? Curious questions that interested him because while he handled the dildo he couldn't ignore that his dick was bigger than this thing.

Once it was clean, he dried it in a fluffy towel, folded the towel over and rested her vibrator atop for her to hide when he was gone. He returned to the bedroom, pulling on the oversized Misfits T-shirt she'd been wearing. It smelled like her.

When he was seated on her bed again, Kay came out wearing just the sweatshirt and a pair of black shorts in sweatpants material. "It fits you," she said, meaning her shirt.

"Yup," he said.

Kay stood with her hands tucked up into her sleeves, watching him. "You okay?"

He nodded.

"That's good."

He said, "I guess it's really official. We *are* open."

"You can do it," Kay said, then raising an eyebrow and smirking said, "And it's been official for a while."

"You and her planning this, the breaking up with me, the thing with . . . Brady . . . Taylor knew she wanted to fuck in college?"

"She wanted to be on the pill."

"Not for my sake."

Kay sighed, turned her face up to look at her ceiling, chewed the inside of her cheek. "She has a weird thing about getting pregnant. She knew she'd mess around in college . . ."

"Knew it would happen, or planned to *make* it happen?"

Kay huffed, stared at the floor and smiled. "Yeah, I guess there's a distinction."

"There's a distinction."

She waffled, thinking. "I can tell you, you're a grown up . . ."

“I know the answer already.”

Kay looked in his eyes like a person she respected and who deserved the truth. “You do. She wanted to have a lot of sex in college.”

“She told you that?”

Kay nodded.

The time for him to reel from Taylor’s actions was over. That Harrison would only suffer, and if he were to survive this, he would need to find in it what could nourish him. If he didn’t, Taylor’s desire for other men would eat him alive. Plus, there could come a time Kelsey Kay grew tired of the perpetual pep talks. So while his face was still held firm and grim, he straightened, nodded, even though his insides were rotting. He rubbed hands on his thighs, formed them to fists and drummed.

Kay leaned against the post next to where he sat, tucking her sleeve hands in her armpits, sucking on her lower lip and smiling.

“I want her to have a good time,” he said, almost believing it, but at least liking the sound coming out of his mouth and being heard by Kay.

“It won’t change how she feels about you.”

“Can I get that in writing?” Something his dad would say to his buddies, and it just popped out because he had no real feelings of his own right now.

Kay laughed, which was nice. She said, “Like, my dream is to have as many dogs as possible. Five maybe. I’ll love all five, but if I make a shit ton of money I’ll have twenty—think I won’t love all twenty?”

“You’re so fucking crazy, Kay.” He held her gaze, shook his head, and they shared a quiet moment. Then he said, “You don’t think she’s running away from me?”

“A million times I told you no.”

“But she’s running?”

That made Kay stop and consider; her eyes rolled up, and she looked to the canopy over her strangely feminine bed. “Yeah,” she whispered.

“Any idea what?”

“Lots. Michigan . . .”

“*Michigan*,” he said in a mocking tone, imitating Tripp in a dumb version of his voice, hoping she’d join in and they could make fun of him together for his own enjoyment. Kay disregarded it, some of the humor falling away from her expression. Now she lay her head against the post, looking suddenly very tired. He asked her what.

“Not Michigan, the place, Michigan, the people. Us.”

“Why?”

“She stresses.”

“I know . . .”

“Shit, Harrison, she’s always supposed to be sunny Taylor, the center of attention. Smile for everybody, look hot . . .”

“She’s not like that.”

“Exactly.”

“She wants to be someone else, and to do that maybe she needs different eyes on her.”

And hands, he lamented.

“Everything here weighs on her . . .”

“The divorce . . .”

“The divorce, her sister and brother gone, and, shit, your sister too.”

“Heather? What would she have to do with it?”

Kay sat down next to him, butt on a foot, her knee pressing the side of his thigh. “It was heavy, man, you know that.” She cupped a hand to his cheek and stroked. “Not just for you—none of us can know what that’s like—for all of us . . . all of us in our own way. It pales, I know, but it exists.”

“What did Taylor say?”

“Nothing. She *never* wants to talk about it. You can’t even bring it up to her. Look, she had to be strong for you, but she was busted up in her own way she never talks about.”

“So I’m like a sad sack. She doesn’t want to break up with me because I might be so fragile.”

“No. Don’t say that. That’s bad energy, Harrison. I don’t think it’s like that.”

“It makes me feel pathetic.”

“Bad energy, dude. Don’t do that to yourself, Harrison. Don’t roll back down the hill—you’ll just have to fight your way up to the top again.”

“Can we not talk about it?”

Now she held his face in both hands, touched his lips with a thumb, first the top then the bottom. “You’re on your way to becoming what any girl needs, dude. I’m serious, don’t slide back down, it’s so hard getting up that hill . . .”

Before his brain knew better, he hunched closer to Kay, looking to . . . what?—get close, express how he felt, shit, was he going to *kiss* her? . . . It didn’t matter, Kelsey prevented their faces coming together—he was only

going to hug her, that was all, that was *all* it was—holding him at bay with her hands cupping his face; he could feel the tremble in her forearms as her muscles sought to stop him from doing what she thought he might be doing, but staying gentle. It took a lot of respect for Kay to consider your feelings, not just shove you away and ridicule you.

He lowered his eyes and when that wasn't enough, tipped his chin down as well, staring at Kelsey's bare leg; the pale skin where it met the black of her sweatpants cut down to shorts.

"Hey, Harrison?"

"Uh-huh," he said, letting his sheepish gaze drift her way again. Kay had beautiful eyes, smoky and confident, perfectly shaped with long black lashes that bowed gracefully.

She said, "I'm not . . . I'm not sure I like dudes that way, okay?"

"Dudes?" He didn't catch her meaning. She didn't clarify, only kept her gaze on him in a way that showed she waited for him to catch up. He got it. "Oh . . . *really*?"

Kay looked away a moment, then returned, imitated his request when she wanted to talk about Heather's death and he didn't: "Can we not talk about it?"

He nodded, wondering now if he was understanding what she was saying. While it made sense, it also didn't.

* * *

KAY STOOD at the front door watching him while he put his shoes on. Arms shrugged into his jacket, he paused and waited. Kay leaned with her back against the front door, wearing her black sweats, nothing on her feet, barefoot in her warm home. He said, "We good?"

She nodded once, no change in her expression, turned and worked the door's lever with both hands tucked in the sleeves of her sweatshirt. Cold October air chilled them, standing there with the door open not knowing what to say.

He said, "You want a ride in on Monday?"

Kay nodded again, her hood up, framing her pretty face, silver hair hidden, two cascades of bright pink hair on her chest.

“See ya,” he said, not sure what else you said after a night like tonight, tucked his hands in his pockets and stepped out onto the gray stone terrace that was her stoop.

The door closed behind and he breathed in the cold, shivered, bewildered, then headed for the wide circular steps that led to her drive.

Light spilled around his feet and he stopped on the top step, turned around.

Door left open, Kay trotted to him, her small feet tucked into a pair of Big Jim’s lace-up boots in size 13. Boot tongues flapping, heels clomping, she skip-shuffled to him, hugging herself.

He opened his arms, and she banged her body into him, her own arms still closed around herself. For a second he’d thought she’d intended to kiss him, and standing and holding her now his heart still pounded with that anticipation. Slowly Kay relaxed against his body and her arms went around him. She hugged him tight, and he hugged her the same in return. When she stepped back, she looked up at him unsmiling. She said, “Text me later, okay?”

“Okay.”

“Take me to lunch.”

“Okay.”

There was a pause, and his imagination burst again with the notion she would kiss him, but instead she turned and trotted back to the house, big boots scuffing stone. She got inside, gave him a small wave and closed the door.

He stood staring at the closed mansion door, huffed a weird laugh, put his hands back in his pockets and headed down the steps.

* * *

SNEAKER TOES PLANTED in the sandy skid-mark underneath the swing-set, denim butt slung in the seat, Harrison dangled, head down. It was midnight now, his childhood neighborhood quiet, dark, and blue, the playground where he played as a little boy just a collection of black boxes and posts and poles against the starry indigo sky.

In the aftermath of the events tonight he felt like a membrane had been breached, like he was now on the other side. But this world was dark and

unknown, full of threats. There was one thing he knew:

Strength was what got him through the membrane, and it would be strength on this side that would keep him alive.

Taylor wasn't lost to him, and for the first time, the challenge of being in her life, of being her lover, seemed a surmountable one. Not something he would have to survive, but something he would conquer. Taylor wasn't lost, wasn't out of his grasp, it was just a shaky static in their connection, like their contacts had come loose or corroded. Just brush them, tighten them down, the current would flow again. And what he'd thought he'd lost in Taylor truly wasn't about Taylor. What he'd lost was in himself. The part that held her so tight was gone. Didn't love her one iota less, but maybe that weak part of himself had gone to its knees in surrender—the loss just as remorseful, because he loved that Harrison. That Harrison was who he was. But that Harrison wasn't served—even if that Harrison *deserved*. But at least now there was hope. At least now he could see clearly his path through the deadly minefield surrounding the girl he'd been in love with since he got his first pubic hair.

It wasn't her; it was him. Taylor'd said it, Kay'd said it, and he'd nodded, said he saw it. Truth was he hadn't, at least not clearly, he'd just nodded agreement so they wouldn't turn their back on him.

Thank God he had Kelsey Kay in his life. How had he never appreciated her before? Scared of her, probably.

He drew in a long cold breath, got the swing creaking and moving side to side, withdrew his phone from a jacket pocket. He texted.

Harrison: I love what you sent me

Harrison: you can't help loving me can you?

Chapter Ten

TAYLOR SAT on the dorm room bed with her back against the wall. She laughed quietly and honestly at Harrison's text. What weird feeling was that that just gave her a warm tickle?—oh yeah, *relief*. She snuffled a quiet laugh, texted in return.

Taylor: I can't help loving you

Harrison: I've been told I'm lovable

Taylor: I miss u

Harrison: ur amazing Taylor hope ur having the best time out there I mean it

An unexpected spate of tears swelled her eyes. There was no way for her to anticipate how much his words meant to her. She sniffed, wiped her eyes with the back of a wrist.

Taylor: all that dirty stuff I said on the video I hope you know that was for u

Harrison: Tripp looks like a trip ha ha he good to u?

Taylor: You'd really like him Harrison I swear to god

Harrison: I like him if he's good to you baby

Taylor: he's so good to me Harrison

Harrison: all I care about is you

She stared at the text a while, wondering if this was Kay with Harrison's phone. On cue, dispelling that thought, a text from Kay.

Kay: u around?

Taylor: yup

Kay: look at u answering texts right away who's a good girl?

A homesickness slithered through her, but it was kind of a good one, enough it got her smiling.

Taylor: ha ha 🙌🏻 🙌🏻

What had she expected in SC? Come out here and just slip into a crowd of people like how she knew in Michigan? Nothing was ever so easy. Yeah, she had her looks and that brought attention but it wasn't the same anymore; *she* wasn't the same anymore. The people she knew in Michigan saw her the way she'd been, the people in SC weren't so easily fooled.

Kay: he watched it

Taylor: I know

She watched the three dots from an incoming Harrison text wiggle for a bit then disappear. It was hard to know what to say, she understood that. For

the first time it didn't seem like an open relationship was impossible. The parts of Harrison that held him back had loosened, and the parts that held her back seemed to ease their grip. There were always new challenges and the knowledge sunk her stomach again. For now she was happy to know Harrison was happy.

Kay: I watched it too

Taylor: Kay what the fuck

Kay: I didn't want him to be alone

The two of them together, and she could see them now, Kay and Harrison in Kay's home theater, both of them watching her lurid performance on the big screen. Whatever. After she'd got home last night and was alone, she'd re-watched what she'd recorded. It wasn't bad at all. It was pretty good. She'd anticipated having to cut scenes out but in the end she sent it whole. Tripp and she'd done a lot more last night, there was plenty that went un-recorded, but a taste was all Harrison needed. Just needed to see she was okay, Tripp was good to her, and hopefully he'd get off on watching her get fucked like that. She hoped he did, and was grateful her faithful boyfriend loved her so much her sexuality turned him on. Then her stomach sank again.

She bundled sheets around her bare shoulders, saw kay had a message incoming and waited.

Kay: he really took it ok

Taylor: u sure?

Kay: for sure I mean it

Taylor: I love him

Kay: he loves u

Now her head nodded forward and rested on her knees, the phone held at her stomach. She made a quiet groaning sound. There was something she had to say but couldn't. She put it off, thinking she could let it go, but the compulsion squeezed at her. Against her own better judgment, she texted.

Taylor: I think I have real feelings for Tripp

She waited a long time for a response and grew heavy and disheartened when she saw one didn't come. Brightened for a moment seeing Kay's dancing dots . . . She waited . . . They stopped and no message came. Now she could see Kay had got offline.

In the dark and quiet she sat for a long while feeling the threat of tears but rode out the hurt until she could breathe steady again. Big breath taken, held, she shook off the sadness, stretched out in bed and tossed her phone under the pillow. Her naked body slunk against Tripp's, her hand stroked his warm back, then nails wove into his hair, her body slithering up against his. She kissed his shoulder and closed her eyes.

* * *

HARRISON SMILED, thumbs caressing his phone's edges, looking up at the stars and watching the thin trails of his chilled breath. He chuckled, texted.

Harrison: I'll c u soon

But Taylor was offline. She'd read it tomorrow. He tucked the phone in his jacket pocket, hand fumbling around in there.

It wouldn't matter how far Thanksgiving was because even if it was this coming weekend he couldn't be without her another heartbeat; he'd still do what he was intending.

When his hand emerged from the pocket, it held a velvety pouch. In his lap, he undid the gold strings that tied the bag's mouth and removed the impossible object from inside. Now held up to the starlight he could see the toe ring's shape held between his thumb and forefinger. The odds were impossible. The ring's discovery in the creepy old boathouse was kismet.

He would deliver the ring by hand, and Taylor would know its discovery by her Harrison had to mean something. With great care he put the ring back in its pouch and closed it tight, tucked it back in his pocket.

The hard parts were over. The breach had been made. New directions were scouted and he would travel them with confidence.

Behind him loomed his past; the home where he'd grown up, but now the heavy seeking dread therein seemed thin and powerless, and he planted his sneakers in the dirt, smiled and kicked the swing into motion.

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